



COMMUNICATING WITH KIDS

WHAT WORKS AND WHAT DOESN'T



STEPHANIE DAVIES-ARAI

This is like no other parenting book. For one thing it doesn't tell you how to parent (you already know that), but rather explains how your kind of communication helps or hinders your parenting. Full of staggeringly simple but hugely effective tips – this book might actually change your life.

Helen Saxby, Specialist in early learning toys for children, mother of two

Stephanie gives the kind of commonsense advice that is so blindingly obvious once she points it out that you wonder why you never thought of it before. Buy this book!

Jane Summers, Student Nurse, mother of two

Drawing on her own experiences as a parent of four as well as the latest psychology and neuroscience research, Stephanie re-examines what it means to be an effective parent. With sometimes counter-intuitive advice and laugh out loud truths about the shortcomings of modern parenting, this book gives you all the guidance you need if you want to be nice but still in charge. You won't find a more comprehensive and powerful guide for turning the heavy weather of parenting in to lighter-hearted good fun!

Lizzie Overton, former Head Teacher, Education Consultant, mother of two

Feeling confident about your parenting? Ok, as Stephanie says: 'shoulders back, head up, tap into your inner Mary Poppins' – and read this book. Parenting is tough – because the two standard methods everyone uses just don't work. Stephanie brilliantly guides readers to a new ease and enjoyment with our children.

James Greyson, Head of Blindspot Think Tank, father of two

Stephanie offers that perfect mix of science based theory and common sense which leads to sighs of relief and AHA! moments round every corner. Her humour, insight and experience make you instantly comfortable and help put all the pitfalls of parenting into perspective.

Kate Alderton, SEM Practitioner, mother of two

When you're at your wits' end, reading anything by Stephanie will pull you back from the brink and humorously guide you towards being the happy

fulfilled parent you want to be. Does what it says on the tin!

Nimmy March, Actor, Patron BAAF, mother of three

After just a few pages of Stephanie's book, I felt calmer, more together and actually able to do something positive about my son's seeming inability to listen to anything I said! Stephanie writes in such an inviting and warm manner that she at once puts you at ease and makes you laugh – no mean feat when you feel at the end of your tether. There are no blame or shame tactics, just brilliant, sound and simple advice. She understands what us parents are feeling. What's even better is that her ways of communicating are not hard to implement and I even remember them in the heat of the moment. No more wearing emotional outbursts on my part, no more contrary, outright challenging behaviour from my son – what more could I ask for?

Catherine Hooper, Editor, mother of one

A clear, practical and intelligent approach to a hugely neglected subject (how to talk to your children). *Communicating with Kids* is the only parenting course I've done so I'm not an expert but the reason I've not tried any other course is that this one helped me. We don't have as much shouting, arguments, confusion and mayhem in our house anymore and I don't think it's a coincidence that we have both attended Stephanie's course. Helped me change a lot of my bad parenting habits, I still screw up but I realise it a lot sooner and deal with it a lot better.

Sean Lock, Comedian, father of three

Stephanie writes with incredible intelligence and humour about parenting. She is unafraid to tackle difficult issues because, after all, those are the areas with which we need the most help. I love the honest appraisals of her own experiences because they mirror our own, and the way in which she resolves them offers us both hope, and a pointer to how we might deal with our inevitable parenting challenges. I just love her stuff – so easy to read, and so simple to apply.

Jackie Charley, Author of best-selling book *Unlock the Cage*, mother of two

There is something incredibly powerful about being able to shake off the stereotypes and expectations that society has of you and to be who you want to be as a parent. Stephanie has helped me to do this and to become a truly happy parent. She has helped me to accept and embrace my own personality, to make me an intuitive parent and most importantly has given me the tools to make my children feel secure and loved.

Angela Towers, Director, mother of two

Stephanie's writing provides me with honest and insightful observations about parenting and family life. When I read her words, I invariably find myself thinking, "yes, that's exactly how I feel!" She not only manages to articulate many of the same issues and concerns that I have, but offers her view in a non-judgmental way. I really enjoy her blend of subtle humour, experience and knowledge and when she writes about the external pressures on the family, she combines passion and intelligence.

Judy Weatherhead, School Assistant, mother of one

In her new book, Stephanie breaks down so many of the myths about parenting and empowers you to enjoy the learning journey that you and your kids are on a whole lot more.

Mike Ellicock, Chief Executive, National Numeracy, father of three

Stephanie's writing is funny, thought-provoking and incisive and above all acutely relevant to parents raising kids in the world today. Without a hint of know-it-all she raises questions on familiar issues, and offers refreshing new perspectives. She reflects openly (and amusingly) on her human foibles within the context of parenting.

Amanda Berry, Events Organiser, mother of one

What I find so refreshing with Stephanie's approach is that she is so totally non-judgemental. Not only have her suggestions and ideas worked brilliantly with my children, I realise that actually it's all about me and not about my kids. Totally empowering!

Christine Griffin, NCT Breastfeeding Counsellor, mother of two

Stephanie's approach is authentic and grounded in real-life and at the same time full of joy and laughter. Her approach takes away all the blame, shame

and punishment which invites a negative response from children. Instead through clear communication and positive relationships children respond with respect and understanding which leads to good models of behaviour.

Debby Hunter, Principal of Independent Primary School, mother of two

Stephanie brings compassion, practicality and a disciplined clarity to family communication issues. She has a rare authenticity and draws upon a vast wealth of experience, both from her own life and the many individuals and families she has worked with to produce elegant solutions to complex issues.

Gavin Burke, Primary School Teacher, father of three

Powerfully and with humour Stephanie demonstrates that when you begin speaking from a place of self respect, magic happens! Her approachable and non-judgemental manner is refreshing. Stephanie makes me laugh, she has retrained my mind and made me do a few U-turns inwardly too.

Paula Rhymes, Artist, mother of four year old twins

What resonates the most with me about Stephanie's approach is her compassion and insight around communicating with young people combined with a wonderful sense of humour. Also, it works!

Maddy McClellan, Printmaker, mother of two

Stephanie teaches how to communicate, both verbally and non-verbally, in a way which is clear, honest and respectful. I love the balance in her approach; both communicating clear boundaries *and* giving children space to be, grow and learn for themselves. Both hearing my children's feelings *and* expressing and meeting my own needs. I love the way she draws on and shares her own experiences – she is understanding and totally non-judgemental and I really appreciate her humour and light-hearted, down-to-earth attitude; encouraging less stress and more relaxation. Positive, liberating and empowering.

Dawn Casey, Children's Book Author, mother of two

Stephanie Davies-Arai's writing always makes me feel that it's ok to be the parent I am.

***Lisa Clarke, Clinical Nurse Specialist in Immunology and Allergy,
mother of two***

As a local osteopath I treat many children and families and have referred several parents to Stephanie when they have been struggling with various issues. They have all benefitted from her clear, heartfelt and accessible training courses. I do not hesitate to send people her way, I am impressed with her warm professional manner, passion for her subject and her ability to engage her audience.

Ruth Wharton, Osteopath & Naturopath, foster carer

www.communicatingwithkids.co.uk

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STEPHANIE DAVIES-ARAI



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9 Priory Business Park
Kibworth Beauchamp
Leicester LE8 0RX, UK
Tel: (+44) 116 279 2299
Fax: (+44) 116 279 2277
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For my children (you know who you are)

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INTRODUCTION

I think that having children should be fun. This book is a story of how I moved as a parent from incompetence and anxiety to confidence and enjoyment, simply by learning to communicate clearly and ignoring all other parenting advice.

I have been a parent for over twenty years now and I have brought up my children during an era of increasing anxiety and focus on children, and a corresponding proliferation of parenting methods which tie us all up in knots. What I slowly realised along the way is that parenting is a much simpler job than it's made out to be. You don't need lots of strategies and techniques. You don't need to be perfect – and there is no one right way.

It's much easier than this. Honestly. Even with really challenging children.

A Bit of Background

I have four children of my own, three boys and a girl, and my oldest and youngest were both extremely challenging in their different ways. When my boys were little I took a parenting course out of desperation which was called Parent Effectiveness Training (P.E.T.), a communication skills-based programme designed by Thomas Gordon. I then trained to become an accredited instructor and ran courses for parents and teachers over a period of around eight years. During this time I also worked closely with children in various roles in the playground and in the classroom at a small school of which I was a founder member. I slowly learned what worked and what didn't and began to modify the skills I was teaching to reflect my experiences with a very wide range of children. Finally, through my

experience and a lot of research, I designed my own course: Communicating with Kids.

What I had learned over the years was that there was one simple thing that seemed to work with any type of child I was dealing with: they all naturally responded well to clear, honest, direct communication. So that's what I based my course on.

Why I Have Written This Book

I have been running the Communicating with Kids course for a long time now, and participants have asked me when I am going to write the book. So, finally, here it is. I wanted to write it because I have become frustrated with the amount of confusing expert advice for parents out there which I know will not work, and I feel there is a need for a book for parents based purely on communication, and not on a personal ideology or parenting model.

Really, it's not my business how anybody chooses to parent their own child. All I want to do with this book is make it easier for you to be who you want to be with your children and to have more confidence and fun in doing so. Parenting is not a competition. Popular parenting advice is contradictory and confusing, so I also wanted to provide a way for parents to understand what they are reading and feel more confident in making their own choices and decisions.

Clear communication provides the building blocks for the way you parent, whatever your beliefs and values, so understanding the principles gives you all you need to parent in the way that feels right for you (which is all that matters).

How I Have Written This Book

I take the two opposing ideologies of parenting advice today – the tough discipline approach and the gentle child-led approach – and I then show how each method can create the opposite of what it aims for. I then show you the communication that does work and why.

The first four chapters set the scene of underlying principles and approach, and the following seven chapters build on this information to show its practical application in real life. I use my own parenting journey to demonstrate each step, so each chapter begins with a story or observation – sometimes a personal example of where I got it horribly wrong – then explores typical language and approach, shows why it doesn't work, and

progresses onto extensive practical examples of alternative language and approach. Every chapter ends with a summing-up of the three main points to remember.

I have overwhelmingly used my own experiences throughout the book, simply because I know both the actual script and the context of these scenarios in the most detail. I include three examples from parents who have attended a course just because they fit well, and my thanks go to those parents who allowed me to use their stories. However, although I continue to receive testimonials from parents years after they complete the course my aim in using real-life examples is not to provide lots of proof, but just to illustrate the application of a skill in the real world – so I decided not to clutter up the book with endless evidence but to keep it simple.

Research

As well as my own experience there is a lot of reading behind the principles and skills outlined in this book. The most helpful books I have read over the years of bringing up my children have not been parenting advice books at all, but books which range from the fields of neuroscience, language, genes, evolutionary psychology, social psychology and anthropology, to Enid Blyton's *The Famous Five*. I have included the information that is really relevant for parents throughout the book.

Rather than interrupt the text I have listed some of the inspiring books I have read in a bibliography, so that you can go on to read more if you choose. I feel I need to make a disclaimer at this point: I have not read everything there is to read on every subject. I am not an expert in any one area but I am an avid reader. What I have done is read opposing viewpoints and matched them with my experience.

I haven't included the books I no longer agree with, or whose ideas do not stand up to scrutiny, although I have included Thomas Gordon's book *Discipline That Works* because I still draw on some of the overall communication principles I was introduced to through his work. I am especially indebted to Gordon for my understanding of the difference between behaviour and labels, the difference between needs and solutions, the typical responses to negative feelings and the use of I-messages and I incorporate these ideas throughout the book. However, I now place his overall P.E.T. model firmly in the child-led camp of parenting ideology.

I have also not included my online research, partly because there is too much, and partly because it is so easy to google subjects you may be interested in researching further.

I also may not agree with all the ideas in all these books – some of which may even contradict others – but they are all thought-provoking, interesting, and contain some (or much) information which is useful for parents. I would like to credit all the authors in the bibliography for their contribution to the ideas that shaped this book.

Through this reading and my experience I gradually learned that working with a child's developing brain is much easier than working against it. I hope I can get you there a lot quicker than I managed it.

How to Use This Book

None of the recommendations I make in this book are the law – and the skills are not inflexible rules that you must follow or otherwise feel a failure. Nobody is obliged to get it right all the time: parenting is a journey like any other, and it has its ups and downs.

We worry far too much about getting it right as parents and I don't want to add to that pressure with this book, but to empower you with some simple relevant information you can use to make things easier for yourself.

I warn you that a lot of the effective communication skills that I illustrate in the book may seem counter-intuitive. All the 'how not to' examples of language you read here you will recognise, because we all do them (and our parents probably did them, too). This does not make you a bad parent. I have used all of them, some for years and years before learning that they didn't work, and it hasn't damaged my children. So don't worry. Our children are resilient and luckily they survive our imperfections.

This book will be useful whether you have toddlers or teenagers: all the principles are applicable all the way through childhood, into the teenage years and beyond, because they are simply honest and direct. If you use these principles as your children grow up they become rooted by the time your child reaches the teenage years, and there really is no need for it all to go horribly wrong then.

Not to worry if you haven't, though. A relationship can change at any time, and once it does the past gets forgotten. It just ceases to matter any more. Children's brains are very plastic, and they adapt much more quickly than we do to change.

When you start saying things in a different way some children instantly respond positively, like magic. Others will push you to revert to your old self because that is familiar and safe, even if you used to be really horrible to them. In my experience children generally get used to new ways over a period of about two weeks, so don't give up.

Using the language in this book is like learning any new skill: when we start we have to do it very deliberately and consciously. We can feel like an actor and it all sounds a bit fake. It is only practice which makes new skills become automatic, and practising in your head works just as well as practice in real life. So when you're not happy with the way you responded to a child – and it didn't work – replay it in your head so that it does. And take little steps. Try out a new skill in an area that doesn't matter so much. Don't try to change everything at once.

What I don't do is give you a fixed one right way of managing anything – bedtimes, or sibling fights etc – but a range of skills and an understanding of where to use them, so that you can adapt them and apply them to your own circumstances. Different areas of behaviour may therefore come up in several places in different chapters in the book.

All parents, in the end, are just muddling through – and we all find our own ways, so I hope this book helps you in finding yours. My intention is to simply present a kind of road map and it's up to you how you use it. You will not be tested or graded on your performance.

What I do hope is that you will enjoy reading this book. Take the concepts and skills and run with them, add them to your own wisdom and make them your own. By the end of it I hope you will be muddling through with a little less worry and a little more confidence. And I hope you have fun along the way.

CHAPTER ONE: PARENTING METHODS

I was at a children's party one day when my first two children were little, where two little boys were running wild and creating havoc everywhere. They snatched and grabbed anything they could lay their hands on, barged into other children, threw things around... and when reprimanded they would not look any adult in the eye. In fact they would run away. They seemed half-crazed and totally uncontrollable. I thought about their respective families so that I could form a neat theory about what kind of parenting produces children like that and I was frustrated because the families were very different, so I couldn't. Then I realised that the families came from the opposite extremes of the parenting continuum we have today, yet they had produced the same result.

When I visited the first family once (an uncomfortable experience) I saw that the children were highly controlled, by means of a rigid punishment and reward system: the atmosphere was strict and uncompromising and the children behaved perfectly, like little grownups (completely showing up my children). Nothing they did was spontaneous: they deferred to their mother on everything and were continually checking the rules.

On a visit to the second family's home I saw that the child was allowed to do whatever he liked, including grabbing food off my plate and shouting at the adults: the home was chaotic, with toys and stuff strewn everywhere and absolutely no limits or restrictions placed on behaviour. It was all a bit scary. The parents believed in freedom of expression above all else.

I realised that the little boy from the first family was so restricted at home that he had developed no internal controls, so that when he was let loose in the world he went wild with the freedom. The little boy from the

second family, on the other hand, had no understanding of others' needs or boundaries at all and – with tacit adult approval – was accustomed to doing what he liked. In the first family the parents exercised total control. In the second the parents had no authority at all.

So I did make my theory in the end. These examples represent the parenting extremes – and they produced extreme results – but over my parenting years I learned how and why both methods can actually create the same behaviour, even if we are not as extreme as the parents in my example and our children don't react quite so wildly as those two little boys.

I have seen children from both types of families grow up to be perfectly reasonable, nice human beings. There is never a simple cause-and-effect result from within the normal range of parenting practices, and we can never say with absolute certainty 'This type of parenting produces this type of person.' The journey to get there could be so much easier, though.

The Two Camps of Parenting Advice

I have read quite a few parenting books over the years myself. One day I decided to do a bit of research on what these books are saying now, so I settled myself down in front of my laptop and clicked on Amazon. An afternoon's work, I thought. A few weeks later I gave up at around book number 4,000 and decided that that was probably enough. I didn't read all of them, obviously – only excerpts and reviews – but what emerged clearly from all this published parenting advice was two distinct camps of beliefs and approach, which I will be referencing throughout this book.

The two basic camps of parenting beliefs which are popular today were illustrated at the beginning of this chapter in their extreme manifestations, and I summarise them as the Parent-Centred (Camp A) and the Child-Centred (Camp B).

- Camp A believes in discipline, rules and boundaries, and the approach of this group is parent-led: in other words the parent imposes on the child.
- Camp B, by contrast, focuses on the child's needs, and this approach is child-led: the parent follows and takes his or her cues from the child.

Camp A sees Camp B's methods as weak and indulgent. Camp B views the authority of Camp A parents with horror.

All the parenting advice which I read through on Amazon came broadly from one or other of these camps. Both have claims that their way is best and will result in happier, more confident children. What happens when you get two opposing ideologies is that they both cite evidence which supports them and they ignore evidence against them, so they become more and more polarised and extreme. This means that, as parents, if we align ourselves with one we must necessarily be against the other.

As an individual parent you are naturally drawn to either one or the other overall view of parenting, but what may happen in practice is that you start from one camp and when it doesn't work you revert to the other. So you start off being lovely and understanding and cuddly and then when your child repays you by being obnoxious you come down like a ton of bricks. Or you start off trying to strictly enforce the rules and when your child resists you start pleading and cajoling, or give up. Most of us do this to a certain extent, no matter what our beliefs. It is very common, and not a problem in the sense that it is well within the boundaries of normal parenting practices. It's not very enjoyable, though, for the parent – who can constantly feel either guilty for being too hard, or angry and frustrated with the kids for not being more obedient.

The Unique Parent-Child Relationship

In reality there is a lot of wisdom in both Camp A and Camp B, and the parent-child relationship is characterised by elements of both. I take what I believe to be the two important aspects of the parent-child relationship from these two camps: Parental Authority from Camp A, and the Human Relationship from Camp B, and demonstrate how they work together to make the parent-child relationship unique.

- Parental Authority: the adult role, discipline, rules, boundaries, managing behaviour, parental responsibility.
- Human Relationship: intimacy, connection, understanding, respect, empathy, trust.

Being in parental authority is a role – one of many roles we play in life. For example, when you go into a shop you are playing the role of customer and the shopkeeper is playing the role of shopkeeper. You say 'I'll have this bag of apples, please.' She says 'That will be £1.50.' You say 'Thank you.' She

says ‘Thank you,’ and off you go, transaction completed successfully. If, however, you observe ‘Looks like you’re busy today’ or ‘When’s this rain going to stop?’ you have brought in a human aspect to the relationship. You still complete the business transaction successfully but you both (hopefully) feel a little warmer towards each other and you have slightly more spring in your step as you leave the shop.

As parents we want the successful transaction bit: we want it to be quick and easy, with little fuss, but we also want the human connection which fosters goodwill on both sides and makes life more joyful. Our children want both, too. Camp A may get transactions completed successfully but has only superficial human connection. Camp B takes forever just to buy a bag of apples.

We go in and out of parent role depending on the situation, but we probably never leave it completely: there’s always a bit of the parent on alert in the background even when we’re relaxing and having fun with our children. This book shows you where it’s important to step up into parent role and where it works better to relax it. It also shows how you can be in parent role without losing the human relationship bit completely – in other words, do the job and complete the transaction successfully in a way that still enhances the relationship.

The principles of both Parental Authority and the Human Relationship are important, but in this book I will show you why focusing on either one or the other doesn’t work. Yes, children are looking to us to be in our authority so that they feel safe and secure, but they don’t want to be treated like animals being trained. And yes, they want to be seen as human beings but they need us to treat them as children and not mini adults.

I will also show how many of the strategies employed by both camps are ineffective:

- Some of the discipline strategies of Camp A, designed to produce obedience, create worse behaviour.
- Some of the listening strategies of Camp B, designed to help children deal with their problems, create bigger problems.

I will show why the punishment and reward strategies of Camp A may be counterproductive and I will demonstrate a language of authority which is far more effective and which makes life much easier. I will also show how

the therapeutic model of listening employed by Camp B can create the problems it's designed to resolve and show you how to respond to your children's feelings in a way which acknowledges them without indulging them.

You, meanwhile, can remain the parent you want to be – but just get to do it more effectively and with more confidence.

The Messages We Send

The reason that some of the strategies of both Camp A and Camp B are ineffective is that so much of the typical parenting language we use doesn't work. Many of the messages we send to our children result in precisely the opposite of the expected behaviour – and as an illustration, here's a simple instruction – which I want you to obey.

Ready? Here it is:

Don't think of a lemon.

Did you obey me? Thought not. I think you probably did the opposite of what I wanted you to do.

As parents we go around using 'Don't think of a lemon' messages all the time, unaware that they don't work. I think it makes life much easier if you use messages that do work and that's why I've written this book.

It took me many years of getting it wrong to learn this.

The Subtext of Our Messages

All the things we say to our children contain an underlying message, a subtext, of which we are often unaware. What our children want is for us to be authentic and clear, but much of the typical parenting language from either method illustrated above really messes this up and confuses things. The hidden message in what we say and how we respond to behaviour is so often 'I don't trust you to do this' or 'I don't trust you to be able to deal with this.' That's the message the child hears, far louder than the actual words. If we just tweak our language a bit and change that underlying message to 'I trust you' it's amazing the difference it makes.

In this book I'll demonstrate why some language works and some doesn't, and how just making simple changes to what you usually say can produce miraculous results.

Parenting Methods

We are bombarded with advice about what's best for children, but of all the many widely different models of parenting globally and throughout history not one has ever been proved to work any better than any of the others. In the end you might just as well be yourself. As long as you don't go outside the wide range of normal and into abuse and neglect you're going to be doing all right. And, luckily for us, there is a wide margin of error and children are quite capable of thriving despite our mistakes. We will make many mistakes because we are human and human beings are not perfect. Happily, our children don't need us to be.

We bring up our children within the rules and traditions of our own culture, and in so doing we help to socialise our children into their society. The culture does its bit by publicly reinforcing the same messages as the parents – it really does take a village to raise a child. Incidentally, that's why transposing one culture's parenting methods into a different society may be problematic. The South East Asian Tiger Mother model, for example, works very well in Japan and South Korea because the whole society reinforces and supports that method, but it may not be quite so easy to put it into practice in the Western world which, broadly speaking, places more of a value on individualism.

Our Culture's Beliefs

We live in a particular culture at a specific point in history and its values and beliefs unconsciously influence our beliefs as parents. So it's useful to know something about this so we can make more conscious choices.

There used to be just one broadly-accepted way of bringing up children in the U.K. – and the emphasis was on discipline. Everyone smacked their kids and punished them and there was no hand-wringing and endless discussion about what was best for the child. Down our street there was only one family who spoiled their kids, and we all knew who they were.

Almost everyone was a Camp A parent, and the methods of this approach were rarely questioned or challenged.

We now have trends in parenting, one following the other, as the first gets disproved and then possibly reinstated at a later date when new research comes to light. We are constantly trying to find the set of factors which will produce the perfect child: we want to be able to say $x = y$ with absolute certainty – and a whole parenting industry has sprung up to help us, full of conflicting and contradictory advice.

The reason that parenting ideas and practices have expanded so much is because we know so much more now about children's development and needs – which my parents didn't. Children didn't have emotional needs at all back when I was a child: they were fed, watered, sheltered and exercised and that was thought to be enough. Emotional needs were invented later... I'm not sure when, but my children certainly had them. We now seem to have travelled from one extreme to the other, from not recognising children's emotional needs at all to focusing on them above all else.

We live in a post-Freudian society which sees parents as the greatest cause of long-lasting emotional damage to their children, so that these days we tiptoe around our kids trying not to hurt them at all and not allowing them to fail or to experience frustration. Our starting point as parents is now based on the belief that children are psychologically fragile creatures who need us to be in constant attendance lest they develop low self-esteem. That's why so much parenting advice is based on building your child's self-esteem, which seems odd to me as my kids were born with bundles of it. One of them nearly took over the whole family with hers.

From a wholly parent-led approach we have moved to the child-led ideology of Camp B, which in turn has led to a backlash from Camp A protagonists. It seems that you have to be either one or the other, as if these are the only choices.

Genetic Inheritance

The whole nature-nurture debate has now moved on from the simplistic Freudian viewpoint of cause and effect: we know now that – although certain factors may correlate to certain outcomes – correlation is not the same as causation. In other words, it is almost impossible to say x causes y . We know now that there are far more factors involved in the development of a child into an adult and that it's not all the parents' fault.

For example, let's examine the belief that an aggressive parent produces an aggressive child. Is it the parent's aggression which makes the child aggressive? Or is it the child's aggression which causes the parent to respond more aggressively than they would with an easier child? Or does the child simply carry the genetic inheritance of aggressive traits that run through the family? Is the child's aggression nurtured and reinforced more through interaction with the peer group or the parent?

In order to answer these questions there have been extensive studies with identical twins adopted into different families, and although it is beyond the scope of this book to go in to the research there is certainly evidence that we parents don't have as much power as we think to shape our children, and that who we are has a lot more influence than any parenting techniques we may use.

It is generally accepted that almost 50% of your child's make-up is genetic: in other words, your child has inherited nearly half their character traits from you. Every parent knows that children come as they are, and even identical twins will exhibit different characters from the word go. We parents are not God and we can't make a child into what they're not: our power as parents to shape our children is not absolute. But children's brains are plastic, and your child's potential is constantly influenced and shaped by a combination of factors: parents, environment (the wider culture), experience and the peer group.

Parents don't have the power to shape or change their child's innate personality traits absolutely, so we may as well not waste our energy on that. There was no way I could have changed the character of my extremely challenging fourth child into that of my very reasonable third.

There is also no evidence – once you take away genetic factors – that Camp A methods influence a child's outcome better than Camp B methods, or vice versa. Socio-economic factors are a far bigger indicator of outcome than a parent's exact method of discipline.

So, in other words, if we are loving parents who care about our children we needn't worry so much that we are doing it wrong or that we need to find some magic formula which will produce the best results.

There's an awful lot we can do, though – just through our communication – to change day-to-day difficult behaviour and make life easier with any type of personality.

The Parents' Relationship

In a two-parent family the parents' relationship with each other is the key relationship and, although I have written this book about communication with children, I need to stress that here. If our focus is constantly on the children then parents can lose the connection between themselves, and children can play up because of the insecurity that this produces in them.

It's amazing how much children's behaviour can just fall into place if the parents are busy getting along with each other.

When a child has the power to come between parents – and she succeeds in gaining the constant attention of both – she is not happy: it is not a power she really wants. A child needs to see the strength of her parents' relationship in order to feel secure, and also to learn that she is not always the most important person in the family. Sometimes the best way of dealing with a child's unacceptable behaviour can be to just turn your attention away from her and towards each other: start a conversation, or have a cuddle.

You are a child's blueprint for how to be in a relationship with someone: she is constantly learning, through the way you treat each other and the care you take with your relationship, so it's not something parents should neglect in deference to their child. And even if your relationship with your partner is not particularly good, I hope that some of the principles and skills in this book will give you some understanding about how to manage that in the best way possible.

One thing that can really interfere with the quality of a couple's relationship is differing opinions on how to bring up the kids. What happens when one parent is firmly in Camp A and the other believes passionately in the Camp B way? This is very common. In fact it would be amazing if both parents shared exactly the same views of parenting and agreed on everything right down to the last detail. Our beliefs and values around parenting are certainly shaped by the way we were brought up ourselves, and it's unlikely that both parents had the same experiences with both of their parents, or reacted to them in the same ways.

Managing Differences in Parenting Beliefs

If you and your partner have very different beliefs or tolerance levels around children's behaviour, the first thing to recognise is that children can deal with that: it's not as much a problem for them as it is for you. Children's brains are designed to adapt to whatever the rules are with whomever they happen to be. That's why they can go to school and adapt to a different set of expectations and discipline methods there from those they experience at home.

It is also why we shouldn't worry too much if the grandparents, or in fact any other adults we know, treat our child differently from the way we

do. When children are very young they will just accept people's differences: as they get older they will develop greater judgement and may view Granddad's idiosyncratic ways with amusement, but they will cope with them as long as we don't make too much of a big deal out of it.

So a child has no problem with the fact that Mummy lets him do certain things that Daddy wouldn't, or the other way round. He simply learns that fact and acts accordingly. If Mummy and Daddy, however, are always arguing about it and getting angry with each other he learns that he has the power to create (to him) a very interesting dynamic between the two most important adults in his life, and he is compelled to see how far his power extends.

It is the parents' job to sort out their differences privately. It is not the child's job to become involved with the decision-making when it comes to behaviour management. One general rule can help: if one parent is really bothered by a particular behaviour which causes them great stress and the other parent doesn't mind it, go with the parent who is bothered. So, for example, if a child continually gets up from the table during mealtimes you could make the rule that everyone stays at the table. It doesn't mean that the other parent has to pretend they don't like it either, but they can still support their partner: 'Mummy doesn't like it, so we don't do it.'

Day-to-day situations like that can be sorted out with a little give and take, but it gets trickier if two parents have completely opposing ideologies: if we are both fixed in our belief that there is one right way then we can build up frustration and resentment towards each other. If one parent is convinced that children need tough discipline he (I say he but it could just as well be she: this is really not gender-specific) will judge his partner as weak and indulgent, and get even tougher in response. Meanwhile she sees him as intolerant and unfair and becomes even more indulgent to compensate.

It is similar to what the Camp A and Camp B parenting groups do: opposing ideologies tend to become more and more extreme.

I hope this book will be a help to parents in that position, firstly through the understanding that the one right way is a myth, and secondly by gaining insights into principles that allow both ideologies to coexist (and skills in each that will work better and therefore not irritate your partner so much). Furthermore, although your overall ideology may remain the same, using the skills in this book will actually bring you away from the extremes and

more towards the centre in terms of behaviour management, so parents can become closer to each other in their approach. For this reason it's helpful if both parents read the book.

Maybe the most important thing is to recognise that we parents are all amateurs. We all do our best and luckily our children are very resilient, so our mistakes are really not that important.

Separated and Single Parents

It's a well-established fact that the most important thing for children of divorced or separated parents is that the parents maintain some kind of respectful relationship, but it's not quite as simple as that. Parents should certainly make an effort not to put their ex down in front of the children (that's what friends are for), but if one partner was abusive in some way then it is important that the other parent establishes boundaries and acts out of self-respect.

In a sense, if you are a single parent, the key relationship in the family becomes the relationship you have with yourself: it is very easy for a lone parent to allow the boundaries between parent and child to become blurred, especially if it is a same-sex relationship with one child. To maintain respect and develop a psychologically healthy relationship there needs to be two separate people, and single parents may need to focus more on that aspect of the parent-child relationship. On the plus side, you don't have to watch as your partner interacts with your child in ways that really irritate you.

A child is quite capable of moving from one parent's home to the other, following the different rules of each home. They may have preferences (usually the parent who lets them get away with the most) but we shouldn't assume that a child will need three days to recover from being with our ex-partner and to readjust to being with us. If we expect that we are likely to facilitate it, and our anxiety will fuel any slight grievances a child expresses. And children will always express grievances, especially if it gets them lots of sympathy.

There are principles and skills in this book which I hope will be helpful to parents in these positions as well as those in two-parent families and step-families.

Whatever situation you are in – and whether you are instinctively a Camp A or Camp B parent – I'll show you what's effective in

communication with children and what isn't, and I will explain why. I don't make any claims about what sort of children I'll create for you. All I do know is that it's possible to have an easier time of it with them and enjoy the journey more. So let's go!

If you only take away three things from this chapter, make sure they are these:

1. No parent is perfect, and we don't have to be.
2. No parenting method has ever been proved to be any better than any other so you might as well relax and do it your way.
3. No two parents are exactly the same, and that's fine.

CHAPTER TWO: THE PARENT-CHILD RELATIONSHIP

I remember the very first time my oldest child, aged two, said ‘No’ when I told him to do something. He had crawled under the table and I said ‘Come on out now’ and he looked me straight in the eye and said ‘No’ – and I hadn’t a clue how to deal with it. Should I get strict and order him sternly or should I entice him out with something he likes or should I let him do what he wants? What on earth are you meant to do in situations like this?

I was naturally drawn to the child-centred approach of Camp B when I became a mother. I wanted a good relationship with my children above all else but I had no idea how to achieve this while also getting them to do what I wanted without shouting and getting angry all the time. I didn’t want to be a shouty, angry mother. I wanted to be one of those nice ones.

Human relationships are said to be the number one important factor in emotional health and satisfaction in life. I wanted this core relationship to be wonderful. It couldn’t be otherwise: it meant so much. But I had no idea how to go about it.

At the end of this chapter I will tell you what happened in that story of my two-year-old under the table, but to start with let’s look at some background.

Characteristics of a Healthy Relationship

There are certain factors which help all human relationships run smoothly, whether the relationship is between friends, partners, colleagues, or between parent and child: good relationships have certain characteristics that make them work. We don’t need to get them right all the time because

nobody's perfect, but if we bear them in mind as a general rule we'll be doing OK. I've listed the four characteristics which I think are important in healthy relationships below, and these are the underlying principles behind effective communication with our children. I've written this in a way that makes it easy to remember to keep on **TRAC**:

- **Trust.** If you express trust it's more likely that the other person will act in a trustworthy way and trust you in return. Trusting yourself makes you feel more confident and your child more confident in you. You might as well trust in yourself because there's no evidence to show that anyone else is doing it better.
- **Respect.** Both for the other person and yourself. You feel respectful and respected. You view the other person with regard and you trust it's reciprocated, so you can relax. You show respect and you act out of self-respect.
- **Authenticity.** You feel you can be honest: be who you really are, not put on a show. And you feel the other person is honest with you, too. There is no pretence or play-acting. Being honest doesn't mean being cruel, though. Having integrity also means shutting up sometimes.
- **Clarity.** You say what you mean: you mean what you say. You don't mess around playing games so that the other person has to second-guess your true feelings. You use words to reveal, not conceal.

Psychologically healthy relationships also contain personal boundaries, because you have to be two separate people in order to have a relationship in the first place. This bit can be tricky for parents because we're so emotionally connected to our children and I talk about that throughout the book – especially in [Chapter Five](#), when we get on to feelings.

Parental Authority and the Human Relationship

The relationship between parent and child isn't just any old relationship, though. It's not the same as a friendship (which is equal, or horizontal), but it's also not the same as police and criminal (which involves absolute power and subordination).

What makes the parent-child relationship unique is that it contains both the parental authority aspect and the human relationship aspect. In this

relationship the parent is the Big Person and the child is the Little Person. That's all.

- Parental authority means rules, boundaries and discipline. We might also call it parental responsibility: being the adult, accepting the role. Authority holds a child safely and allows the child to be a child. Children like parents to be parents and not friends because they already have friends and they probably prefer them to be around the same age, with similar interests. This doesn't mean we can't be friendly, of course.
- Human relationship means closeness, intimacy and connection. It means relating to your child as a human being, not as either an animal to be trained or as a mini adult. It means understanding and tolerance and trust. It's important because you're laying the blueprint for all the human relationships your child will experience in the future. And also, of course, because you want to be close to your children and you hope they will still like you when they are adults.

It's a lot easier to have this close loving connection if your child is fairly well-behaved and you're not getting stressed and angry all the time. Some children just are more difficult and challenging than others and it's hard to feel that sweet gentle love you're supposed to feel if your child is constantly screaming at you and refuses to do anything you say. Life just becomes a battle and you're too exhausted to think of anything beyond just getting through the day.

A clear confident parental authority makes a child behave better so you've got more time to enjoy the relationship – and a warm respectful relationship makes your parental authority more effective, so these two factors work together to make life much easier and more fun more of the time.

If you focus on one of these aspects of the parent-child relationship to the exclusion of the other it doesn't work well because children are born expecting both, so if one aspect is missing they will fight to get it. Parental Authority is the focus of the Camp A model I discussed in the Introduction, and Human Relationship is the emphasis of Camp B, which explains why neither model is likely to be wholly effective. If you focus on the relationship but are afraid to step up into your authority your child will push and push you until you do, but if you focus exclusively on your authority he

will fight you to treat him as an individual human being. If we don't know what our child is asking for we will just assume that this is naughty behaviour, which is his fault.

So let's look at why children need both of these aspects of the relationship, because once we understand this everything becomes much clearer. Babies are born with two powerful drives or needs: one is for integration and the other is for individuation. They come into the world as both social creatures and individuals and they are driven to have both needs satisfied.

The Drive for Integration

We are social creatures – we human beings are by far the most sociable animal and our networks, customs and social structures are far more sophisticated and complex than either our nearest primate relatives or even those extremely social ants and bees – and our brains are literally built through relationship with others. We know from the rare cases of babies brought up by wolves that they do not develop what we would define as a fully human brain. Our complex social structure is one of the reasons the human baby needs a much longer nurturing period than any other mammal – there's just an awful lot to learn.

Every baby develops through a process of socialisation into their culture, with its specific rules, traditions and beliefs: they are born ready-primed to socialise into any culture, and they gradually specialise into the customs of their own.

The drive to understand and follow the rules of society is innate, and it's what children are doing continually as they grow up. It's their job.

Human beings have a need to feel that they are an accepted member of a group or tribe and to understand its rules, so that they feel comfortable within it. A child's first society is her immediate and extended family: it is here that she learns the blueprint that she will internalise and extend into the wider societies she enters at school and in the local community, where hopefully a similar set of rules will exist (so that it's a comfortable transition).

This social structure is what gives a child safety and security, within which she can explore and discover and grow. So she wants to know the rules clearly and obey them and she expects us to know them and let her know what they are.

- The concept of integration is socialisation and the need is to be the same as others.

The Drive for Individuation

Within our group or society we also need to find out who we are and what differentiates us from the crowd. A child who feels secure in the group is able to work on finding out what makes her unique and different; what distinguishes her and what makes her who she is. She is on a quest for self: she has a drive to define herself as an individual and to find out who she is, what she is capable of, what her individual strengths, weaknesses, likes and dislikes are. We all want to be recognised and valued for who we are and we all need to feel that we can be ourselves. Nobody likes to be a sheep or just a cog in the wheel. It's not surprising that a toddler's most often repeated word is 'Me.'

The existential quest for self is a lifelong journey, and it's another important factor that distinguishes our species from other animals. It's the other important job for the child, to the extent that it looks like that's all they are doing – being self-centred, selfish or ego-centric.

- The concept of individuation is respect for the individual and the need is to be different or unique.

The Two Drives Acted Out Within the Peer Group

We can observe the two drives for integration and individuation clearly when a child starts school, and again – even more so – when a child hits puberty. Parents worry when their child returns from his first excursion into the world of school wanting to be like every other child, but they shouldn't worry. It's an important job and a natural and intelligent response to be influenced by the peer group – this group is your child's present and future and he needs to find out what this group is in order to find himself within it. Imitation is the way he does it. It is misleading to think that he brings to the group a pure and defined self which he needs to hang on to: his self is being built through interaction with the group just as the building blocks were – and continue to be – laid down through the interaction with his parents.

Teenagers, of course, need to do this job almost to the exclusion of everything else in their lives. A child beginning the process of becoming an adult needs to define herself in relation to others in order to develop her

mature self, and her first job is to find her tribe and establish herself within it. She must strictly adhere to the dress code, speech habits and recreational pursuits of her chosen group, which she will defend in competition with others. She is not following the crowd, but taking the first steps to defining herself as an adult.

It's very lucky for teenagers that school provides them with rest periods from this very important and all-consuming job (they're called 'lessons').

Toddlers and teenagers are in fact going through a very similar process, as any parent who has both will know. The toddler is moving from babyhood to childhood, and the teenager is moving from childhood to adulthood. If we don't understand what's happening at these two crucial developmental phases we will fight it all the way, worry unnecessarily and label them the terrible twos and the awful teenage years, but it doesn't have to be that way. Both periods in your child's life are simply the times when the competing drives for integration and individuation are most evident in her behaviour and if you work with that, rather than against it, you'll have a much easier time of it.

The process of integration and individuation will be different for every child. Some spend years following the crowd before they emerge into a differentiated self, others resolutely go their own way until eventually they learn to modify the more annoying bits of their behaviour in order to fit in with their peer group. The peer group is very useful in this respect. We parents will worry either way. We'll say 'She's like a sheep; she really can't resist peer pressure; she needs to learn to stand up for herself' or 'He just doesn't have any social skills; he needs to notice what other kids are feeling; they all think he's odd.'

Some children follow around and attach themselves to just one other child, who would prefer to have a wider circle of friends: other children form threesomes and exclude all others. There are myriad ways of working out peer relationships, all of which are normal. We worry too much: they all get there in the end, just by different routes.

We will all, however, end up in varying different places along the continuum of sociable-individualistic behaviour, and the place where we land will be largely determined by our innate genetic disposition. The more introvert characters will go their own way more and dip in and out of the group, whereas the more extrovert characters will place themselves firmly in the centre of the action. Remember that it's a waste of energy to try to

change innate genetic disposition? Trying to force a more introvert child to be gregarious and sociable – or keeping a more extrovert character away from his peer group – will only end in tears. It's really not worth it. Yes, we can make sure there's some balance but – as life tends to provide that anyway – we needn't worry too much. There are advantages and disadvantages in both dispositions, after all.

The Two Drives Enacted Within the Family

If you observe how strong this drive is in children to fit into their peer group, think how much stronger it must be to fit into their first social group – the family. Trusting in the strength of a child's innate drive to do this makes a big difference to how we communicate with him. If we believe that someone is willingly doing their best, just with limited tools and experience, our whole attitude changes.

You can also see how an approach that focuses only on one or other of these drives doesn't work. The drive to socialise a child without considering him as an individual and giving space for that aspect to develop can stifle a child, but emphasising the individual without providing a clear social structure leads to confusion and chaos.

- Camp A focuses on Integration – the effort to socialise a child.
- Camp B emphasises Individuation – the respect for a child as an individual.

If you ignore either one of these drives the result can be acting-out behaviour, as the child tries to force you into meeting both sets of needs. We don't understand where this bad behaviour comes from so we try and fix it with more of the same of what we were doing anyway.

- Camp A gets stricter and tries to enforce the rules more stringently.
- Camp B listens more and tries to diagnose the underlying problem.

And then of course the child ups her game and protests more loudly. Camp A kids actually need a bit more understanding and Camp B kids need a bit more discipline.

Children need both because they need safety in order to explore. They need to know which society they are in so they can find themselves within

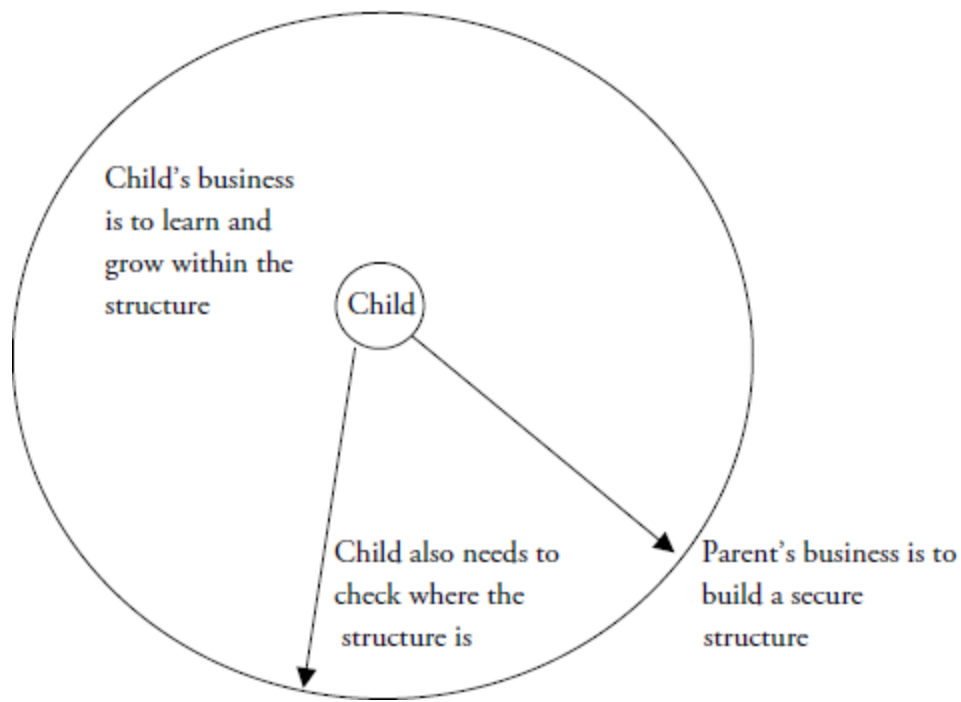
it. They need to have a structure or a framework in order to be free. We still have these needs as adults.

Building the Structure

Building the clear structure is the parent's business. The child's business is to learn, grow and develop within it. A shaky structure means that a child will spend her time trying to find out where it is, when her energy should be used in finding out who she is. By contrast, if a child's life is micromanaged with lots of rules within the structure, her energy is wasted in a constant bid for freedom and escape. A teenager may say 'Get off my back. It's my life.' A toddler just doesn't have the words for it yet.

These days we tend to get it the wrong way round: we're not too clear about where to set the boundaries – and spend time endlessly negotiating them – and we spend far too much time interfering with our child's business and managing their lives for them. That's an awful lot of time and energy spent in unnecessary work, especially when you think that it can create and exacerbate problem behaviour which you then have to manage on top of everything else.

Fig. 1. The Structure



Getting the structure right means first knowing where it is and what it consists of, so we need to define the two main points to bear in mind.

Daily Routines: Rules and Non-Negotiables

The first part of the structure consists of the practical rules: the daily routines, your family's way of getting out of bed in the morning and going to bed at night and all the bits in between, like getting out of the house, mealtimes, doing the supermarket shop, picking your child up from a friend's house, having playmates round, taking your child in to school, and bedtimes. Think non-negotiables: the areas where you give the orders and directions and life is easier for everyone if they are just followed without question.

It is the parent's job to set the daily routines because they have to be done in a way that suits you. You are the one who works, pays the rent, cooks the meals, looks after the children and carries all the responsibility, so it's important that your daily routines work for you and meet your needs. You have to put your own oxygen mask on first before you can help your child and your responsibility gives you the legitimate right to do it your way. Your routines really have to work for you because if they don't you'll be stressed and incapable of functioning well in your job as a parent. You also may as well look after your own needs here because your child doesn't care what the daily routine is, as long as there is one.

Everyone is different and it doesn't matter whether you have a more easy-going or a stricter daily routine. The important thing is that you know what it is and that you communicate it clearly. If you home educate or it is the school holidays there is still some daily routine even if you like it to be minimal, and there are also things you have to do which work better for everyone if they run smoothly: doing a supermarket shop, picking up your child from friends' houses and car journeys (for example).

Your child expects you to know what the rules and routines are and to tell him. He does not want to be in there deciding them with you – that's not his job. He expects and wants you to take that responsibility. Obviously it's also his job to check and challenge the rules, but it's important to recognise that all he's asking for is reassurance that they are there. He is not asking to be a grown-up and help you make them, even when it looks like it. He doesn't want to reinvent the wheel: he wants you to know what you're doing.

Children are happier with an established routine – whatever it is – because it is predictable in the child's world, where so many things are chaotic. There is a safety and security in knowing what is going to happen, and that this is under the adult's control, not the child's. If this bit is sorted by the adults, a child can relax and get on with being a child.

If daily routines are painless and automatic for everyone, then energy is freed up for the more important stuff. What you are doing here is building your child's social brain, the default setting which will serve her for life, establishing patterns and habits she doesn't even have to think about. That's a great gift for a child. This is not an area you want questioned or endlessly negotiated: you'd never get out of the house.

Personal Boundaries: Respect

The second part of the structure consists of your own personal boundaries: in other words, what you accept in the way other people treat you. This is self-respect – knowing where your line is and when it is crossed. Knowing your own personal boundaries and expressing them clearly gives a child an internal model of how to act with respect for herself and how to express her own personal boundaries. If your boundary is unclear and she is allowed to treat you with disrespect she will be confused and unhappy because, no matter what it looks like, she wants and needs to respect you. You represent her future self as an adult, and she wants to see a positive self that is worth growing up for. She will also then be able to extend this knowledge into other relationships and she will learn to respect other people's boundaries, too. She will also learn from you through lived experience how to have personal boundaries and how to express them clearly, without hurting others. You are being a fantastic role model when you stand up for yourself.

It's a useful check to think about situations outside the family and what behaviour we would accept from other people, because it helps us to get to know our own personal boundaries. Sometimes we are not sure ourselves whether we find someone else's behaviour acceptable or unacceptable, but having children is a great way of finding out. If we wouldn't accept disrespectful behaviour from other people, why do we accept it from our children? We may have our reasons in certain circumstances, and we may have more tolerance because our children are still learning, but it's a useful guide to bear in mind.

When a child crosses your line and treats you disrespectfully she needs to know it, and she would prefer that you did not allow it so that she can hold on to her respect for you.

‘Children need boundaries’ is something we hear a lot, but that’s misleading. It suggests that we should set limits and restrict our child for her own good. It’s more accurate to think of it as the other way round. Parents need boundaries: we just need to know where they are and to express them clearly so that our children know them, too.

When a child comes up against this structure it should be strong and clear. Part of the child’s job is to constantly check it, not in order to break it and feel powerful (which is what it may look like) but to reassure himself that it’s still there. This doesn’t mean that we can’t ever be flexible with it, though – in fact being clear and confident about where the structure is actually enables us to be genuinely flexible when we want to be.

The Child’s Business

Knowing that the structure is there holding him safe, a child can get on with his own business. A child’s business includes his way of doing things, his learning, his challenges, his feelings, his relationships. In this area he needs to discover things by himself as much as possible. This doesn’t mean that you never go in and join him in there, just that you recognise what belongs to him. Trying to control him, enforcing your way on him, helping him too much or changing him in this area will stifle and suffocate him and he will be constantly trying to push you away.

Of course, it’s part of our job to teach or guide our children, but the basic understanding that learning and growing is your child’s job (you can’t grow him) changes the way you teach and guide him. For example, if you trust that his innate drive is to learn you are less likely to lecture and control (which isn’t very effective because nobody likes that) and more likely to support and nourish his learning. A plant will grow strong and healthy all by itself as long as there is sunlight and rich soil. If a parent can provide a rich environment then the child will grow healthy and strong.

By that I don’t mean that we have to buy lots of educational toys. Most of our ordinary homes in the Western world are already rich enough environments: throw in a loving, caring parent or two and your child is already one of the most privileged in the world in terms of rich soil and sunlight.

Obedience and Self-Discipline

When we're in structure areas, obedience is the desired result. When we're dealing with behaviour within the structure we want to help children to think for themselves, to achieve self-discipline, to do the right thing because it's right – and not because they're just following orders.

Following day-to-day rules is achievable for most children. It's physical behaviour in the physical world so it's simple. It's doable. Most children from a very young age are able to understand and follow a simple direction like 'Coat on now' and form the habit of doing that every day, so that it becomes an automatic behaviour. Other behaviour (let's say teasing your brother) is more complicated. An order such as 'Be kind to your brother' is not going to set a habit for life in the same way as 'Coat on now'. Orders, directions and instructions work well in the structure areas but behaviour within the structure needs a different approach, a different language, which allows our child to work stuff out by himself as much as possible.

It's not an exact science. There will be non-negotiable behaviours *within* the structure, too – things that are not allowed (hitting your brother, for example, may be a non-negotiable in your family), where it's best to state the rules clearly. It's just useful to remember that for a child there is an awful lot of learning and growing and getting it wrong to go through in many areas of behaviour that are not as simple as the physical act of getting your coat on every morning. These areas are more complicated because they involve feelings, needs and impulses, which take time to be mastered fully.

Knowing that 'Get your coat on' works and 'Be kind to your brother' doesn't (or only until the next time) shows us that there is a time to be uncompromising in our expectations of behaviour, and a time to be understanding that some things are part of a longer learning process (which doesn't mean indulging bad behaviour, but managing it with trust).

So how should I have dealt with my first child when he wouldn't come out from under the table? Well, it depends. My memory doesn't furnish me with all the circumstances around that interaction but had it been non-negotiable – had I needed him to come out for some particular reason such as going to bed, or dinner time – I could have given him a clear, matter-of-fact and direct order. Had it been for some other reason, like needing to clean under the table for example, I may have given him some clear information and left him to work out the appropriate behaviour by himself.

There are lots of things you can say to confront a child's behaviour - all coming up in this book - but what actually happened in this case was that while I sat there trying to figure out what I should do he came out anyway. And that was probably my first lesson in the power of sometimes just shutting up.

If we're clear about where the structure is and we understand that within it our child is getting on with the very important job of learning and growing, we can be more confident about our responses in any situation and less stressed about our child's behaviour. We can relax and enjoy the journey more.

To gain that confidence we first need to know the difference between what we say to a child and what a child actually hears. In order to understand that, in the next chapter I'm going to take you back 200,000 years to the birth of language. Don't worry, we won't stay there long.

If you only take away three things from this chapter, make sure they are these:

1. Don't be afraid to be both a parent and a human being. Your child needs you to be both.
2. Get clear with yourself about your non-negotiable rules and routines of daily life and be clear and direct with your child in letting her know what they are.
3. Get to know your own personal boundaries so that you are clear about when a child crosses your line.

CHAPTER THREE: UNDERSTANDING LANGUAGE AND KNOWING WHAT YOU ARE SAYING

Imagine how excited the child who has just started school feels the first time he hears the teacher say:

‘All right, children. It’s going to be wet play today.’

Or what he imagines when he hears for the first time:

‘Line up, children. Form a crocodile.’

Words can be so confusing.

Communication is such an important factor in relationships. When we have a good connection with someone we talk about ‘speaking the same language’, ‘coming from the same page’ or ‘having a shared language’. It’s the basis of a relationship that works: it makes a connection and creates understanding and goodwill. We are closer, genetically speaking, to our children than to anyone else... so you’d think it would be a breeze to build this shared language with that initial advantage in place, wouldn’t you?

The Development of Language

Words are a very recent invention in the history of the human species. In fact, if you looked at the whole history of our species as a clock face of human evolution, words only come in at about two minutes to midnight.

Language was invented around 150,000-200,000 years ago, when we developed a whole new area of the brain called the prefrontal cortex. The other big things that changed then were our unique ability to reflect and self-reflect and the ability to make more and more sophisticated tools. These are the things that really distinguish us from all other primates. It was

the start of a cultural evolution (not just a genetic one) and the development of modern human beings.

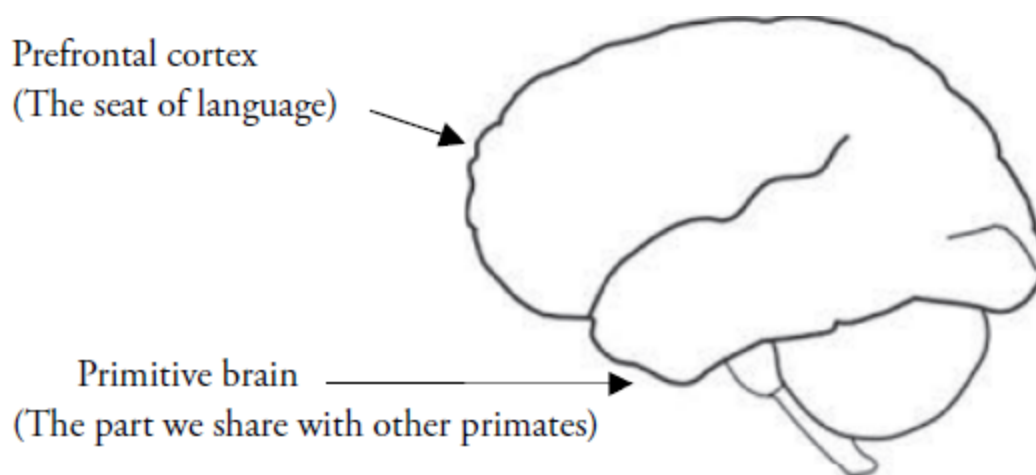
If you think about our brains as computers it was as if a new piece of software had been added to the original hardware of the primitive brain. Not all in one go, obviously: the software has been continually upgraded ever since and its development still continues.

It was a hugely complicated business because not only did we have to invent and understand words, but we also had to physiologically develop a larynx, lips, a tongue and a palette which were capable of saying them. So, a huge job for both the hardware and software development teams.

On the other hand the primitive or reptilian brain has been performing since the year dot, from the moment we first crawled out of the sea, and we only had that part to use for communicating with each other right up until two minutes to midnight. So it's been in production a very long time, refined and improved over millions of years: it's so good that it runs on automatic, below the level of consciousness.

Given that words are such a recent development, we're amazingly sophisticated at using them or – looking at it from another angle – still not very good. Half the time we still don't know what we're saying.

Fig. I. Brain areas



How Words Work

Words are simply symbols for things. If I say 'Cow' it is not a real cow. It is a sound – a vibration in the air, which I hope you will interpret as the real thing. If we want to communicate an experience it is impossible to make

another person actually experience it themselves – so we have to use these clunky symbols called words and hope we are being accurate, so that the other person will understand. There's a lot of room for error, confusion and misunderstanding.

Think about a simple feeling you want to communicate to someone else. Let's say hunger – something that everyone understands. Think of the range of ways we have to communicate that simple experience using only words:

'I'm hungry.'

'I'm starved.'

'What's for dinner?'

'Is there anything to eat?'

'I could eat a horse.'

'Do we get a coffee break?'

'I could murder a doughnut right now.'

'Mmm... that chocolate looks good.'

'Why isn't dinner ready yet?'

'I want something to eat.'

'My stomach's rumbling.'

'Why can't you get dinner ready on time?'

'Is there anything in the fridge?'

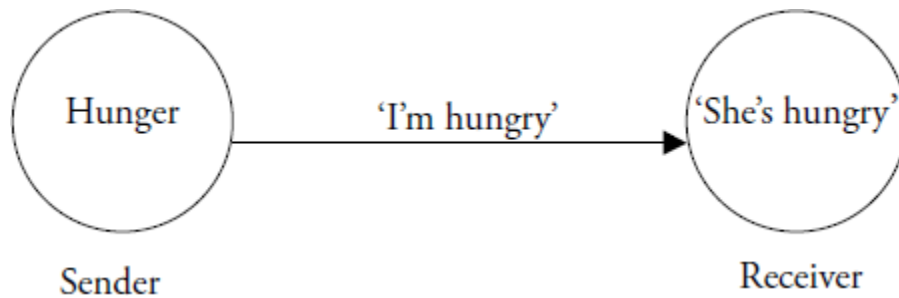
'Get me something to eat.'

We could go on and on and on for pages. There are almost limitless ways we could communicate this one simple piece of information.

Some of the statements above are clear and more or less detailed. Some are idioms, open to interpretation only by a specific culture. Some are heavily disguised. Some are questions or orders. Some are socially-accepted hints. Even the most simple and clear 'I'm hungry' will be received in different ways by different people depending on their experience of hunger (some people actually like the feeling, apparently).

Still, 'I'm hungry' is the clearest and most simple concise statement – so it will have to do. If it's really important that we are understood accurately, it's the statement we would use because it stands the least chance of being misunderstood. Sometimes we can't risk hinting 'Mmm... that chocolate looks delicious' in case the reply comes: 'Yes, it is, thanks.'

Fig. II. Communicating clearly



See how that works? Message received and understood.

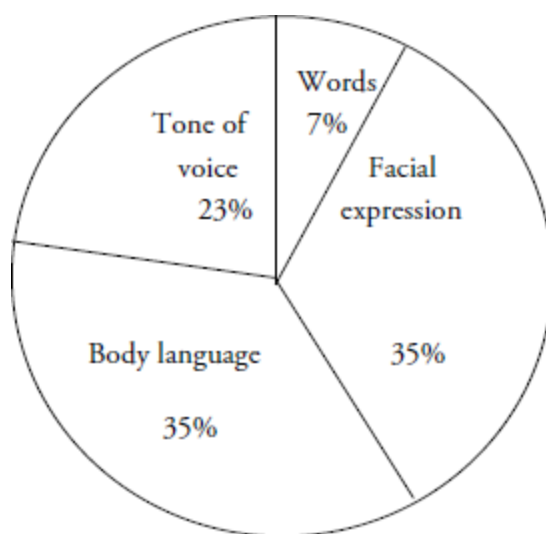
If we only have words to use it's very important that we get them right. Have you ever sent that text or email and spent agonising hours wondering if it's been misinterpreted? We think words are a great communication tool which makes our messages clearer, but they can also misrepresent and obscure our true meaning. They can be used, deliberately or unconsciously, to conceal as much as to reveal. In fact, we probably communicated more honestly with each other in the days when humans were roaming the savannah and only had their bodies to use because with words we can tell great big whoppers, but our bodies never lie.

The Role of Words and Body Language

Words are open to a wide subjective interpretation, so to communicate our true message fully we support our words with our facial expression, tone of voice and body language. That's where we get back to the primitive brain. This part, you'll remember, works very well. It sends out our body language messages automatically. We don't have to try and we are generally not even aware of it. There's an awful lot of lived experience behind what the body does to communicate and it works very well without our input. The brain has a lot of work to do and so it likes to do as much as possible on automatic.

Research has shown that words make up only 7% of a complete message. Tone of voice makes up 23% and facial expression and body language make up a whopping 35% each. These exact figures have been disputed, and it's clear that in different situations words carry more weight than in others. A factual lecture, for example, relies more heavily on words and their meanings. But there is consensus across the board – and cross-culturally – that the percentage of a message conveyed by the words we use is very small compared to body language, and especially in situations involving feelings and needs.

Fig. III. Words and body language



Our deep-seated emotions and needs originate in the primitive brain, and this area gets on with expressing them through body language quite happily by itself while we consciously struggle to find the words. Our prefrontal cortex does not work too well when the primitive brain is in control so the words we use may not be especially accurate. So you can see why, when feelings are involved, body language communicates more honestly than words.

It's surprising at first that tone of voice is not a higher percentage of the message, but it makes sense if you remember that tone of voice is connected to words and language – and needs the same sophisticated level of physiological development of throat and vocal chords, which we didn't have in those pre-language days: our range of guttural noises, grunts and screams at that time was likely to have been fairly limited. So, in effect, we communicated with each other throughout that period using primarily just facial expression, body language and grunts.

The power of facial expression is widely recognised – to the extent that people who work in call centres are instructed to smile when they are talking to potential clients on the phone, as it changes the tone of voice and therefore the message received.

Children's Brains

Children are born with the primitive part of their brains fully developed and firing on all cylinders from the word go. That long period of evolution has

equipped them with fantastically sophisticated skills in deciphering facial expression and body language, and understanding its meaning. This is not something your child has to learn throughout childhood. It's already in place.

Has your child ever said to you out of the blue, 'Mummy, why are you upset?' when you didn't yet fully realise that you were? (Or, 'Mummy, why are you angry?') Those primitive-brainers are very good at this. The more we learn language and how to use words the less conscious of body language messages we become, but we still have that skill as adults. Have you ever come away from a perfectly nice polite conversation with someone you've just met, with the thought 'She didn't like me'? We sense things about people that are communicated to us through their body language, and some people are more attuned to this than others.

Unlike the primitive brain, the child's prefrontal cortex is developing over the course of childhood. It doesn't come ready-made and complete. You can actually chart the development of your child's prefrontal cortex through her acquisition of language. Incidentally, it starts a whole new area of neural connections from the age of about fourteen which doesn't finish its job until around age twenty-five.

So what you communicate through your body language is received loud and clear by your child, whereas the words you use are not. That takes time. If you think about the 'I'm hungry' example above you can see why clear simple language, using as few words as possible, would work better for a child if you want to be sure that they get your message. There are lots of other times when you can be as long-winded, complicated and obscure as you like but, if it's important that they understand, the message needs to be simple and concise.

Mixed messages are sent when our spoken words do not match our body language, which is busy giving off completely different signals. That's why these messages create confusion and uncertainty for children, which just shows the importance of honesty: to say what we mean and to mean what we say. Children know whether or not we are being authentic. They know this better than we do ourselves.

When the hassled mother responds to the child who is kicking her with a forced, sweet and patient, 'Now darling, you know Mummy doesn't like that. Come on, sweetheart. I know you're angry, but...' the child doesn't hear those words. The child hears the tense facial muscles, the strain in the

voice, the tight lips, the pleading eyes and the furrowed brows. This mixture of niceness, anxiety and anger that he picks up confuses him, so he kicks Mummy again.

The Power of Body Language

I will just point out here, though, that there's a difference between the mixed message discussed above and when you consciously and mindfully act as something you are not, like acting confidently when you don't feel confident or being strong when you feel weak. It's a credited technique used by adults in all sorts of situations: for example, acting confidently when you give a public speech helps you to actually feel confident. Body language is so powerful and we can use it to help ourselves. If you consciously force yourself to smile it is impossible to actually feel unhappy while you are doing so because the body tricks the brain into automatically believing its messages. It also tricks our child's brain. In other words, you don't have to feel confident in order to act confidently. It works the other way round too: acting confidently makes you feel confident.

We can harness the power of body language mindfully to fool our brains. So if you examine a feeling (say, lack of trust) and consciously try to change it and act as if you trust, that helps you to genuinely feel trusting. Fake it to make it. It's only the unexamined, unconscious feelings that seep through and communicate very clearly to our children. In other words, when we are pretending but are not fully conscious of doing so – when we are acting a part we don't really feel, just because we think we ought to respond in that way. Acting nicely when you're feeling angry never works: you might as well be honest because that's the message that comes through, anyway. You can still control the way you express your anger without pretending that it doesn't exist.

As adults we pick up on hidden messages and they make us feel uncomfortable. Children are even more sharply adept at understanding hidden messages, and yet the language we use towards children is full of underlying meanings.

The Way We Communicate With Children

We not only use far too many words in our communication with children, but we also use the wrong ones in muddled ways. We go on and on, not realising that the more we repeat ourselves the more we weaken our

message. We also use a lot of subjective words whose meaning is open to interpretation, rather than simple words whose meaning is clear.

As an example we are urged to patiently explain things to our children rather than just saying 'No', and doing this is supposed to make children more accepting of our rules and more willing to obey us. But every new explanation we give actually just serves to nullify the previous one. The more we explain and justify ourselves the more we reinforce the idea that our original reason wasn't good enough by itself.

I once saw a mother trying to get her two-year-old son to leave the beach. He wanted to take some pebbles home but she wouldn't allow him to, and (as good mothers are supposed to) she explained her reasons. When he inevitably responded 'Why?' to her first reason she carried on. 'What would happen if everyone took home pebbles from the beach?' she asked. 'There'd be none left.' The child looked at her, turned round and gazed thoughtfully at the billions upon billions of pebbles stretching out to the far-distant horizon. He considered for a moment, turned back to her and said confidently 'Yes, there would.'

The mother had progressed onto the subject of the history of coastal erosion in Britain when I left the beach and for all I know she is still explaining it to him now.

It's lovely to explain things to our children, of course, but when you want them to obey an order is not the time. In this scenario the mother clearly just wanted to leave the beach quickly. She was obviously impatient but felt obliged to give patient, long-winded explanations to her little boy, for whom it seemed to have become a bit of a game to keep her there for as long as possible. He refused to move, demanded answers, and the more patient explanations he was given the less satisfied he became.

I never really had a clear taking-pebbles-home-from-the-beach policy, but had I been in the position of this mother I would have said simply 'I think we should leave pebbles on the beach' and when asked why 'Because that's where they belong. Come on, off we go. I'll explain in the car.' I would have said this quite carelessly and matter-of-factly, and then turned my attention to getting ready to leave the beach, sending a clear message of trust that my child was reasonable enough to accept this.

In the situation I witnessed the mother sent a clear underlying message of mistrust in her child's willingness to accept her decision, and in his capability to experience disappointment but still behave appropriately. She

used explanation to placate him as if he were an unreasonable tyrant, which he obligingly became.

The explanation was really an argument, and your children will always win arguments. They are far more tenacious and clever than us and they have loads more energy to stay the course.

We don't realise that the underlying message we are communicating is so often likely to cause the opposite of the behaviour we want. Like 'Don't think of a lemon' we make it impossible for the child to obey us. That's because the underlying message of so much of what we say to our children is one of mistrust rather than trust, and when we hear a message of mistrust we are not motivated to act in a trustworthy way.

There are lots of ways we do this as parents. Much of the typical language we use is ineffective because it is manipulative: we are trying to influence our child's behaviour in some way, so we become a little careless with the actual facts.

Instead of a simple, clear, direct, matter-of-fact 'I'm hungry' we send a muddled, heavily-loaded, emotional, difficult-to-interpret message like 'Why can't you ever get dinner ready on time?' and expect our child to crack the code. Here's how we do it:

Sharing Toys: An Example of Unclear and Clear Communication

My first child had great difficulty in willingly sharing his toys with friends who came to play. I tried everything: explaining why it was important, bribing, bargaining, reasoning, getting angry – all the usual things – and nothing worked. Finally, one day when a friend was due to come over, I said 'OK. Let's hide all the toys that are really special to you. Put them in the bedroom and we'll close the door, and just leave out the toys you don't mind sharing.' He nodded seriously, went over to the cupboard to sort through the toys there... and I went off, thinking I'd cracked it. A while later he called me, and I entered the room to find that he had moved every single toy from the cupboard to the bedroom. 'I don't mind sharing this one, Mummy' he said, seriously, holding up the only thing that was left – an old battered tin lid.

Let's look at that issue of sharing toys as an example of clear and unclear communication, as it's such a perennial favourite of parents everywhere. We try lots of different tactics, so let's first look at a few of the most typical examples of what we say. Then let's recognise the underlying

message of mistrust that the child is receiving loud and clear and look at how we can replace it by simply giving the child some clear accurate information – and in doing so, send an underlying message of trust.

- Exaggerating:

‘If you don’t share your toys people will think you’re mean and you’ll lose all your friends because no one will want to play with you any more.’

Underlying message: ‘I don’t trust you to do this unless I make the consequences absurdly bad and I also expect you to believe preposterous extreme outcomes and modify your behaviour through fear of them.’

- Flattery:

‘Come on, darling. You’re usually such a kind little girl... and kind little girls share their toys, don’t they?’

Underlying message: ‘I don’t trust you to do this unless I really butter you up, and I also think you are incapable of identifying insincere flattery.’

- Moral lecturing:

‘Now, come on. You’re old enough to know better. At your age you should be able to share your toys without making such a fuss about it. Some children don’t even have toys to share. Think how lucky you are.’

Underlying message: ‘I don’t trust you to do this unless I make you feel really ashamed of yourself, and I have unrealistic expectations of your ability to change that feeling of shame into willingness to do the right thing.’

- Threatening:

‘Right. If you’re not prepared to share your toys I won’t allow you to have friends round any more and you’ll have to play by yourself and then you’ll be really lonely.’

Underlying message:

‘I don’t trust you to do this unless I threaten you with punishment if you don’t, and I also believe that you are weak and easily bullied.’

Manipulative messages like these depend heavily on body language, so we need to look at that too (as a large part of the message).

We use a tone of voice which is:

- Disapproving, annoyed, desperate or irritated.
- Sweet, patronising, pleading, questioning, apologetic or cajoling.
- Self-righteous, judgemental, accusing or belittling.
- Threatening, scary, angry or fed up.

Our brows will be furrowed or our eyebrows raised. We'll be tight-lipped: our eyes will be searching, angry or pleading. Our facial muscles may twitch, or we may have a fixed and fake smile.

Our body language may look helpless and defeated, our shoulders slumped. We may point and stab the air with our fingers, shake our heads, wave our arms about, gesticulate wildly or shrug helplessly.

Whatever we are expressing all these body language messages carry strong emotions –which by themselves communicate mistrust clearly enough for the child to be incapable of really hearing the words anyway.

Sharing Information with Our Children

Sometimes we go all round the houses before we arrive at the idea of just telling the truth and sharing what is, to the best of our knowledge, accurate information: giving the honest facts, without which a child is disadvantaged in terms of knowing how to behave. When we tell the truth and simply relay some information to our child there is no need for any strong feelings to get in the way of the message. It's not an emotional issue.

If we think about our tone of voice and body language when we share information with someone in another area of life – say, for example, when we are giving directions to a stranger (not to our partner, obviously. That can be very emotional) – what do we do in order to get the information across clearly?

We speak with clear enunciation of words. We are concise rather than rambling. We are matter-of-fact – perhaps quite cheerful and willing – friendly, calm, even, neutral. We smile and nod our heads. We expect understanding, so we're fairly brisk... and we don't patronise. We don't lose ourselves in anxiety that the message will not be heard. We don't try really hard to convince or persuade, and we don't speak in a disapproving, judgemental tone of voice. We know what we're talking about: we have

information the other person doesn't possess and we simply share it in a matter-of-fact way. We're quite pleased to be able to do this and we just hope that our superior knowledge has been helpful. When we're done, we move on.

We know a lot about the world that our children don't – or they forget it, or their feelings get in the way of locating the facts. We need to perfect our 'Goes without saying' or our 'This is self-evident, but...' tone of voice if we want to communicate trust in our child's intelligence, and we need only give the simple facts which – in the example of sharing toys – may be something like this:

'The way it works is like this: your friends share their toys with you when you go round to play at their houses, and you share yours with them when they come to play here. That's the way it's done because that's fair.'

If you look at that message it contains nothing but clear information. You can see how important body language is, though: imagine saying exactly the same words, but in an angry and threatening or pleading and apologetic way. The message would be very different.

Holding on to both your trust in, and your assumption of, intelligence and reasonableness in your children, is important if they respond by questioning you. 'That's the way it works in the world,' is a perfectly adequate reason if they ask why. Don't forget that children are born with a strong drive to follow the social rules and they expect us to let them know clearly what they are. You don't need to give lots of reasons which will weaken that fact, especially those that go into moral teaching. If you plead reasonably or state self-righteously that, for example 'It's nice to be friendly and share things' then 'No, it's not' is the automatic answer to that one.

You can, however, get away with that sentence if it's delivered with a shrug of the shoulders in your matter-of-fact 'Goes without saying' voice. Just take a moment to feel the difference.

Although you don't need to give lots of reasons, do be prepared to keep that trust in the way you respond three times: there seems to be a magic three times in whatever we are communicating to our children, as if they need to check a couple more times to be convinced that we really do mean it.

Parents can easily get stumped by their clever children, who may argue 'You don't have to share your things. Why do I have to share mine?' Here's the correct answer to that one: 'Adults share their food and drink with

friends. That's the equivalent. You can't not: it's just expected of you.' A shrug of the shoulders, a wrinkling of the nose and a slightly 'Surprised you had to ask' tone of voice communicates this piece of information, with the trust that your child will get it and will have no need to push you further.

Children often question in this way and it may seem logical to them, but there is nothing odd about things being different for adults and children. It would be a bit weird if things were the same. Children don't need us to lecture, justify or apologise for that.

In the end, life is easier and everyone – you, the friends, the friends' parents and the child herself – is happier when a child is able to share her toys with minimum fuss. So act as if it's a given – a done deal.

Sharing a simple piece of information involves no strong emotions so there are no confusing feelings for your child to try to interpret, which makes it much easier for her to hear your message. If you think of it as just being straight and giving the facts rather than an obligation to explain or defend your position, you are more likely to actually feel quite matter-of-fact about it. Our children do love us to look like we know what we're talking about. They much prefer this to our patient, reasonable, patronising teacher voice, or our disapproving, angry insistence.

In so many situations we actually cause resistance and create the behaviour we don't want by the way we communicate with our children, and in the process we make life more difficult for ourselves in ways that are unnecessary. We think that children are resisting our message but in fact they are resisting the way we are sending it. We assume, by their angry reactions, that they really don't want to share their toys... but it's not about that: that subject has got lost for them. In reality their anger comes out of their confusion that we're not being straight with them: they are angry about being patronised, talked-down to, flattered, accused, judged, lectured to or disapproved of. Or unfaired against, as one child I worked with put it so beautifully.

Communicating Trust

We think we have to be really nice or really cross to get children to do anything or to accept our decisions, but really we just need to be honest and clear and have confidence in what we are saying and our right to say it. If we can change the way we send those messages we may find that our child has no problem with sharing her toys at all.

I had four children who all seemed to find it a hugely difficult concept, and it took forever with my first three to get them to share their toys in any way other than ungraciously and grudgingly. In fact I think in the end they just grew up: it wasn't me at all. I would have said (if anyone had asked) 'I've tried everything,' but in fact my language above gives the game away: I was trying (very hard) to get my children to share their toys.

This is what we do, in our various ways: we try to persuade, convince, force, insist, influence or get our children to do something, without assuming and trusting that – given the relevant information – this is something they would naturally accept and want to do. We so often act from the assumption that they will find something unpleasant, and our language and approach send that message very clearly.

Consciously or not, we put on our teacher voice when what we need is our 'conversation with a friend' voice.

Finally I learned with my fourth child. I was fed up of watching her jealously guarding her possessions when her friends came to play, and fed up with having to deal with the fallout. Just before the next play date I said to her carelessly, almost as if it was an afterthought:

'And you'll share your toys with her.'

She looked annoyed. 'Why, Mummy?'

I thought a bit. 'Well, you know. It's just how it's done. Your friends share their toys with you: you share yours with them. That's how it works.' I shrugged.

'You don't have to share your things.'

'Mmm...'

'So why do I have to?'

I thought about that. 'Hmm. Adults have to share their tea and coffee and stuff with their friends. That's the same, really.'

'Um.'

'It's just the way it works in the world.'

I shrugged and wrinkled my nose, as if to say 'And I'm not too happy about that sometimes, either' and wandered off to do something else, sending out the clear message that I had no expectation that she would need to discuss this further, being an intelligent child.

She shared her toys happily from that day forward and the subject was never alluded to again in my family, which made me wonder why I had

never thought to simply share the pertinent information with my boys and trust they would get it. I could have saved myself an awful lot of work.

In the following chapters I will show you how to send those clear messages when you need to communicate a message clearly to your child: how to state a simple 'I'm hungry' rather than an anguished 'Why can't you ever get dinner ready on time?' I will demonstrate how we send those 'I don't trust you' messages in various different areas, and how to change them to 'I trust you' messages. To begin with, if you don't feel trusting, use the power of your body language and try acting as if.

If you only take away three things from this chapter, make sure they are these:

1. Use fewer words and make sure that the ones you do use are clear and unambiguous when you want your child to get the message.
2. Stop the endless explanations and just matter-of-factly share the relevant information.
3. Remember that sharing information with someone is a neutral issue, not an emotional one.

CHAPTER FOUR: DEFINING BEHAVIOUR AND THE DANGERS OF PRAISE AND BLAME

My oldest son was jealous of the baby and would hit his little brother whenever he got the chance. One day he was sitting on the floor of the living room next to the baby, who was sitting on cushions in the washing basket, crying. My son put his arm around his brother. Stifling my amazement, I gushed ‘Oh, you’re such a kind big brother.’ He immediately took his arm away, scratched the baby’s face and looked me straight in the eye defiantly, as if to say ‘Still think I’m kind?’

On another day in the life of my young family, my second son, now about three, proudly brought a painting over to show me. ‘Oh, that is so brilliant’ I exclaimed enthusiastically. ‘No, it’s not!’ he shouted furiously, and he tore it up and stormed off.

Fast-forward a few years and I’m in the kitchen with my daughter, who has just thrown me a look of undisguised contempt. Pushed to my limit, I shout ‘That is really rude.’ ‘No, it’s not!’ she screams back. ‘You’re really rude!’

Parents are continually dealing with behaviour. It’s the behaviour of our children which causes us the most problems and worries: we manage it all day, every day. So it’s helpful to know some background information and to understand what motivates children’s behaviour – and it also helps to know what behaviour actually is and what it isn’t.

A Definition of Behaviour

When we experience any person’s behaviour we cannot help but bring all our experience, beliefs and values to our interpretation of it. In other words

we view behaviour subjectively. Looking at the behaviour of a child, for example, one parent may say ‘She’s a right little madam. Needs to learn some manners,’ and another parent may describe the same child as ‘Feisty and spirited. A real character.’ The behaviour observed is exactly the same: the viewpoints are different. We all look at behaviour through our own unique lens, and we tend to describe it using words which express subjective qualities or assumed motivations or character traits.

The dictionary definition of behaviour, though, is only that which is done or said: it is an action which is observable in the physical world: we can see it, hear it or feel it. When we talk about behaviour we rarely describe it in this way. What we do is express our interpretation of it. We don’t comment on the behaviour we can actually observe: we jump straight ahead to our assumptions of the child’s intention or motivation for it.

So, for example, smearing chocolate over the sofa is a behaviour – while being messy is a subjective interpretation of the behaviour. It is a judgement or a label.

- We can see a child smearing chocolate over the sofa but we can’t see messy.
- We can hear a child saying ‘You’re a stupid idiot’ but we can’t hear rude or disrespectful.
- We can see a child lying down on the settee but we can’t see lazy.
- We can observe a child setting the table but we can’t observe considerate or helpful.
- We can feel a hard kick to the shins but we can’t feel nasty.
- We can see a child putting his arm around his brother but we can’t see kind.
- We can observe a child holding her finished model but we can’t observe clever.
- (And although a painting is not a behaviour I will just note here that we can also see a very dark painting which is mostly black, but we can’t see brilliant).

Going back to the importance of clarity when using words, it’s clear that labels are not very helpful. They are subjective judgements which say more about us than they say about the child. As such they are difficult to interpret, especially for the child who is still learning language.

Learning to view behaviour as the physical act that it is starts us off on the path of clearer communication. If we observe in our minds ‘Ben’s just turned away while I’m speaking to him,’ rather than ‘Ben’s being really rude and disrespectful to me,’ we’re starting from a point of fact rather than an assumption. Ben may have just got something in his eye. He may have been momentarily distracted by something catching his attention and he may have had no intention to show disrespect at all, so interpreting his behaviour in that way immediately sets you on a certain path (which I call the fight path). An awful lot of arguments and fights can be prevented if you don’t set off on that path to begin with. I prefer to set off on a path which leads in a completely different direction. It makes life much easier.

Children will get it wrong a lot because they live in the present moment and are so often in their own worlds that they forget what is outside. They are also living so much more in their primitive brains than us: more in the feelings that can overwhelm their reasoning. Jumping to assumptions about their motivations is not fair when often there is no motivation. They just didn’t realise what they were doing.

Negative Labels

If we don’t distinguish between behaviour and subjective interpretations of behaviour, we will inevitably use labels. We will say things like ‘That’s really rude’ or ‘Don’t be so rude.’ And as nobody likes to be labelled or called names, it doesn’t work: you don’t get the desired result. We react to labels defensively: we resist being put in a box and judged. We defend ourselves against accusations and judgements, especially if we feel they are unfair.

We tell our children that name-calling is unkind, and yet we call them names all the time. That’s what labels are. If we are labelled negatively – lazy, untidy, thoughtless, unkind, mean, naughty, spiteful, careless – it feels like an attack, and if we are attacked then our instinctive reaction is to defend ourselves.

Name-calling is like batting the ball over the net and the automatic reaction is to volley it straight back. Just think how you feel when someone insults you. You want to (childishly, you might say) insult them right back. Or stick your tongue out. Or shout ‘No, I’m not.’ As adults we have some control over this reflex action. We can stop and think and we can

consciously decide not to escalate things, but a child isn't experienced enough to do this. A child will inevitably bat the ball back.

Being attacked rouses primitive instincts housed in the reptilian area of the brain called the amygdala, and as our children are less in control of this area than we are, their instinctive reactions will be stronger. We defend ourselves in different ways based on the primitive reactions of fight, flight or submit. Fighting back may mean arguing, shouting, hitting or kicking. Flight may take the form of literally running away, ignoring, or a child who takes flight into his own head and simply withdraws. The children who respond in these ways are seen as naughty children, whereas the child who responds by submitting is judged to be a good obedient child. We don't realise that this child will most likely still be resisting the message inside but will obey us out of fear or a sense that they have no other option.

So negative labels are a great way to foster resistance and start arguments. If you're up for a good ding-dong that's fine, but if you want your child to learn something and change their behaviour it's best not to use them. Better to deal with the facts there in front of us rather than responding to what's going on in our own minds.

Sibling Rivalry

There's another point here about labels which is especially pertinent when it comes to sibling rivalry. If we have a situation of two siblings fighting, and one of them (could be the older one or the younger one) is the stronger, then labelling that child automatically labels the other. You don't even have to use the word bully for it to be clear in the way you react through your body language that this is your judgement. The problem is that if you treat one child as a bully you are inevitably treating the other child as a victim, and that is not a helpful way for any child to view himself. The bully-victim dynamic is very strong and you help diffuse its power when you respond to the actual behaviour rather than jumping to a subjective judgement.

Labelling siblings, in any case, will increase the competition between them. The sibling who gets the positive labels will become more and more unbearably smug while the one getting the negative labels will feel increasingly resentful (and hate their sibling even more).

There is a common idea that labelling the behaviour rather than the child is OK, so for example 'That's very naughty' is better than 'You're very naughty' – and it may be – but I'm not convinced that children really

feel the difference. They just hear the word naughty and know it's about them.

Those judgements we make about behaviour may be accurate or they may not be, but the fact is we don't really know. Labels jump ahead to an assumption of guilt before the case has been fully examined, and that's not fair. If we assume rather that our children are willing to get it right but often get it wrong we will base our reactions on trust rather than mistrust, and trust is far more effective.

Much of this book is about alternative, more effective ways of responding to the behaviour we don't like, so I'll leave that there for now and we'll take a moment here to look at the issue of positive labels: why they may not work and what we can say instead.

Positive Labels and Praise

When your child has just put his arm around his little brother to comfort him when he's crying, what's wrong with calling him kind? Surely that would make him feel good about himself and he'll be encouraged to do it again?

We are taught to use praise to reinforce the desired behaviour. So in fact our praise is disingenuous and manipulative: we use it dishonestly as a behaviour-modification technique rather than as a genuine response. Children pick up our underlying message more clearly than our words so they are liable to feel the manipulation more than we do as adults, when even for us praise can be very uncomfortable. If you think about how suspicious we feel when someone flatters us – we wonder 'What does he want from me?' – you can understand how, for a child, that doubt about motives can be even stronger. A child doesn't have the life experience to understand his own confusion and complicated feelings. He just feels them and reacts accordingly.

What if you use that label – kind – and your little boy doesn't feel very kind? Or what if he knows (and knows that you know) that he is not usually kind to his little brother – in fact, he is the opposite. He knows, in other words, that you've just lied. He feels suspicious of you, his parent, and that is a scary feeling for a child. He doesn't understand why he feels so angry.

Or how about the child you call kind so often that she feels she's got that one sorted and doesn't have to make an effort any more? She just is kind. You only have to watch the auditions for TV talent shows to spot the

kids who have always been overly praised, to the extent that they have built up a completely unrealistic belief in their own talents. It comes as a very nasty shock to be disabused of their own high opinions of themselves in the real world.

Or what about the child labelled kind who becomes unable to behave in any way which is self-serving because she is scared of losing her kind crown? She believes that being kind is her passport to approval and her greatest value and she no longer dares to look after her own needs in case her behaviour is seen as selfish and unkind, which would lose her that approval from others.

Positive labels can become very addictive: the quality we most want to instil can become a straitjacket for our child. We can also create anxiety and insecurity in the very area in which we want to build our child's confidence by continually reassuring them they are beautiful or clever or whatever it is.

Over-praising

My parents' generation generally didn't do praise for fear of spoiling the child. In this generation (if we feel insecure as adults) we are encouraged to see it as a result of receiving no praise from our parents when we were children, so praise has become the holy grail in the creation of self-esteem. In one generation we have gone from no praise at all to total overkill. We have found one factor to blame for our low self-esteem and tried to fix it, but there is never just one reason. All these factors played their part in shaping us:

- What we experienced as children over a whole childhood (most of which we've forgotten).
- The environment.
- Our relationships with our peers.
- Our genetic disposition (which may have made us more vulnerable to the effects of a lack of approval).

It's not so easy to find a simple technique to fix all that.

The popularity of praise was informed by the spread of the concept of emotional intelligence over the last couple of decades, which has gone hand in hand with the cult of self-esteem. These principles have been largely accepted uncritically into schools and parenting manuals, putting pressure

on parents to raise children with high self-esteem who are completely sorted emotionally. It's worth remembering that we all have fluctuating confidence. It's not a totally fixed quality – and in any case it has been shown that having a high level of self-esteem (whatever that means) does not improve grades, career achievement, reduce alcohol usage or lower violence of any kind. Esteem-building praise has been shown to cause grades to fall further for those who are struggling in class. Meanwhile, one study done on a prison population found that inmates had a high EQ (Emotional Quotient, as the measure for high emotional intelligence is called). Not all good, then.

The idea that children need bucketloads of praise came initially from America, but research from over there is now indicating that we got it wrong. Praise was supposed to build self-esteem but in fact it can do the opposite. This makes sense. You can't slap a label on someone and expect it to stick: simply calling someone kind, brave or clever doesn't make it so. Too much praise comes across as reassurance: the more you try to build a child up the more she wonders why she needs this constant level of assurance.

One study was carried out with schoolchildren in New York who were given a non-verbal IQ test in the form of a series of puzzles, and subsequently praised for their results. One group was praised for innate qualities (smart, brainy, intelligent, clever) and the other group was praised for effort. For example:

- 'You really worked hard on that.'
- 'You made a big effort.'
- 'You really applied yourself to the task.'
- 'You kept going and you didn't give up.'

The results were conclusive: those praised for innate qualities subsequently chose easier tests, afraid to take the risk of failing, and their results became steadily worse. The group whose actual behaviour was acknowledged went on to choose more difficult tests and their results improved. It was the latter group who gained in confidence, not the group who were praised (whose confidence decreased). A child whose actual behaviour is acknowledged and described knows that his success is a result of his own actions, which he is capable of repeating and improving. That's doable. He has no such

power over an innate quality. It's either there or it isn't, and possessing it also means you can lose it. That's just chance, over which the child has no control, and it's this fact which creates the insecurity which can result in low self-esteem.

If you over-praise your child you have to keep it up, otherwise they will experience a lack or withdrawal of praise and wonder what they have done wrong. You, as the parent, set the normal rate and if you don't want your child to experience that awful approval-rating-going-down insecurity, don't set the level too high. This rule applies to thanking and appreciation too: don't over-thank when it's something they should do anyway. Save your effusive gratitude for when it really is something special.

There are so many instances of the actions of others for which we feel very grateful, while at the same time we would feel quite resentful or angry if they didn't act that way. Unless someone is doing us a really big favour we thank them and show appreciation but we don't go mad, do we? We don't want them to think that normal courtesy is in any way out of the ordinary. Our partner washes the dishes and we thank them, but we're careful not to go over the top and send the message that this is really special behaviour. And yet this is what we do with children. We effusively thank them for the slightest thing, our voices full of gratitude and admiration, obscuring the fact that their behaviour is normal and expected.

No wonder children grow up acting as if they are doing us a huge favour whenever they do anything for us: we think we are encouraging them in helpful behaviour but in reality we are encouraging the idea that they are doing something special. It's a much simpler issue with children than with partners, incidentally: children are not yet expecting effusive thanks so we don't have any attitudes to undo first.

Motivation Systems

Human beings are born with three innate motivation systems and it's helpful to know about these before you go ahead and try to instil a reward system to motivate your child, whether that is in the form of heaps of praise or a reward chart.

- The first is the biological drive to meet basic human needs. Human beings will do anything for the reward of food, water, shelter or sex. They will go to any lengths to make sure these needs are met, whatever

it takes, from violence and fighting at one extreme to trying to attract a mate by modifying behaviour according to socially-accepted norms at the other.

- The second is motivation to gain an external reward. We will do anything if the reward is tempting enough, even things we know are wrong or are unpleasant for us. We all vary on what will fire up our brain's reward systems. For some it is money, for others it is sex, for others drugs or food. For some it is prestige and for others it is security. We are even prepared to do things we dislike if we want our preferred reward badly enough. We will stay in an unhappy or even abusive relationship, for example, if our need for security is strong enough. Or we will stick at a boring, undemanding and unsatisfying job if the financial reward is great enough.
- The third is the motivation for intrinsic satisfaction: activity which is a reward in itself. This is the area where we do something for no other reason than the love of doing it. We need no persuasion because the act is fulfilling in itself: it gives us a sense of intrinsic pleasure, fulfilment and satisfaction and makes us feel good about ourselves. Hobbies and interests provide this: we can get lost in doing something we love to the extent that we lose track of time. But that's not all. We also get this sense from doing something helpful, something which we know is valuable, something which gives us the internal sense of being a good person or a sense of achievement. Social feedback may be the icing on the cake but we don't need it to feel good about ourselves.

Research has shown that this third drive is very powerful but quite fragile: it can be damaged by external rewards which take away and replace the feeling of internal satisfaction. In an attempt to encourage more people to give blood there was once a famous experiment in paying blood donors: it actually resulted in the number of donors falling dramatically as the sense of intrinsic satisfaction in doing the right thing was taken away and replaced with a financial incentive.

The motivation to do well and to do the right thing is very strong in children and yet we over-praise and reward the very behaviours which provide that internal satisfaction. Children really want to help us – try and stop them – and they really want to behave in socially acceptable ways, just for the satisfaction of getting it right and feeling grown-up. When they

behave in kind and considerate ways it's the warm glow inside which motivates them to continue that behaviour. They are born social creatures, remember?

Leaving aside the first drive (on the assumption that your children have enough food, water and shelter) we confuse children when we respond to the third drive as if it were the second. By rewarding behaviour which carries intrinsic satisfaction we change it in children's minds to something unpleasant or difficult which warrants a reward. In other words we change Motivation 3 into Motivation 2. All the various research in this area has demonstrated clearly that (for example) an effective way to discourage a child from reading four books is to reward him for reading three.

Children's Brains

In the area of moral behaviour babies are born with a kind of genetic moral architecture already installed in the hardware. We parents don't have to build it from scratch, but simply allow it to flourish and grow through experience. You only have to watch a baby's innate concern for another baby crying or the reaction of little children to an animal in pain to see that they already have empathy and are intrinsically motivated to be kind and helpful. 'It's nice to be kind' is not a lesson we need to teach them.

We humans would have had difficulty in surviving as a species if we had been born without the innate drive to be social and the ability to empathise. Early humans were too busy looking for food, meeting basic needs and trying to survive to also spend lots of time making their babies into full human beings by teaching them this stuff. Luckily they didn't know they had to.

When somebody tries to teach us something obvious we can feel insulted and patronised. Our thought process goes something like this: 'Do you think I'm stupid? Everyone knows that. It's so obvious, it goes without saying.' I wonder whether children feel the same irritation when we try to teach them things they already know.

If we want kids to continue wanting to be helpful and kind for the reason that it feels good, just as they do when they start off in life, we need to be a bit more careful about how much praise we heap on them for getting things right. If a child is kind because it makes him feel intrinsically good we can also be sure that he will continue that behaviour even when we are not there to say 'Good boy.'

Giving Rewards

About the only area where we can get away with giving rewards is the one that contains absolutely no intrinsic pleasure at all, and even there we have to be careful of setting up expectations which we are not prepared to fulfil indefinitely.

‘We got that Tesco shop done really quickly and easily. Let’s reward ourselves with a cake,’ I have been known to announce to whoops of delight from my children, who are not accustomed to being rewarded for anything. They are consequently much more grateful when it does happen.

There are exceptional circumstances where rewards can work well as a measure to kick-start a child out of a behaviour which is ruining family life, and I will give you an example of that here. I know a family with identical twin autistic boys (I know) who were taking around forty-five minutes each morning, with a lot of help, to get dressed. You can imagine. So the father one day told them that they would each get 10p every time they got dressed quickly by themselves, and it worked a treat. For that family in those circumstances it was worth it. Far better to sort that one quickly than to stick to principles about rewards, and I would always advocate putting the parents’ sanity first. When you have that level of disruption to family life, you have to have priorities. Interestingly, though, these boys began to forget about the 10p reward, and Dad had the sense not to remind them when they did. It seems that the intrinsic satisfaction of getting dressed quickly by themselves gradually overtook the pleasure of receiving a reward for doing it.

Otherwise, it is actually better to randomly, spontaneously and genuinely reward after the event so that we don’t set off on that path of bargaining which leads to children demanding ‘What will you give me if I do?’ whenever we ask them to do something for us. The natural consequence when my children behave really well is that it makes me feel more generous and giving towards them and they will benefit from that whether it’s sometimes a genuine willingness to spend more time with them, or at other times a back-of-the-net result: ‘You lot have been so lovely this morning. I feel like taking you all out to the park this afternoon and I might even buy you ice creams.’

Acknowledging and Appreciating

There are all sorts of ways we can acknowledge behaviour that pleases us, without falling into the trap of praising innate qualities. What children need, like all of us, is simply acknowledgement and appreciation. They like to be noticed and they like to have a witness. ‘I noticed you put your arm round him when he was crying and that really cheered him up’ we may observe happily at some point.

Really noticing what it is that our child is actually doing and simply observing that takes more effort to begin with, but becomes a habit very quickly. It takes more thought than automatically responding ‘You’re really kind’, but it’s less patronising: it simply lets a child know that we noticed his behaviour and we noticed the effects of his behaviour.

Seeing our child hugging his brother we could just observe the behaviour and pass on what we’ve noticed:

‘That’s cheered him up.’

‘Ooh... he likes that.’

‘You’re giving him a big hug.’

Our little boy, in his head, is then likely to put in the label for himself: ‘I’m kind.’ He gets to experience the inner warm fuzzy feeling which is the true motivation to behave in the same way again.

A more casual, matter-of-fact thanks or acknowledgement of day-to-day expected behaviour communicates trust – trust that your child does not need the reward of a positive label or a flood of gratitude to motivate him to behave appropriately. Rewarding, flattering, praising and making a huge fuss every time your child gets something right only communicates a lack of trust and an assumption that they don’t want to do this for themselves.

We can express appreciation in lots of ways that don’t involve labelling:

‘Thank you for clearing all that away.’

‘I really appreciated your help.’

‘Cheers.’

‘That really helped me. Thanks.’

Don’t forget that children are reading our body language loud and clear. They already feel our pleasure, whether we’re giving them a pleased smile or a hug. We don’t need to add too many words to what our body is already communicating.

Learning and Creativity

Another intrinsic motivation that we should assume our child already has in bucketloads is learning and being creative. A child does not need to be called a brilliant artist to encourage her to keep drawing and making things. When children bring a drawing or painting to show us they are not asking us for a judgement of their talent. They just want to show us. An over-effusive assessment takes away the intrinsic pride of achievement and makes it into some kind of test. We can show enthusiasm and give our opinion but we don't need to judge it as good or bad. An observation or affirmation is enough:

‘You’ve made a really dark painting and used lots of black.’

‘You’ve done lots of swirly squiggles all over the page. I love it.’

As children get older and we can genuinely see talent, what they need from us is accurate feedback rather than praise, especially if it's an area we actually know about:

‘I think you have a really good sense of colour and design.’

‘I think you’ve got a naturally strong voice and a good ear.’

If it's an area we don't know much about we don't really have the right to make definite judgements. I would not be able to say to my child with conviction ‘You're a brilliant musician’ but I can still give my opinion:

‘That was lovely. I’m really impressed with your playing. I love the sounds you get out of that guitar.’

In case this is all starting to sound a bit dry and academic, it doesn't mean that we can't congratulate, enthuse and express admiration:

‘Congratulations! Well done.’

‘I really admire the way you stuck at that.’

‘Wow... fantastic! You made it. Good for you.’

Our honest observations and genuine levels of enthusiasm are what our child needs from us as this is what gives him trust in us. Otherwise, when you do spontaneously exclaim ‘Oh wow! That's brilliant. You're a genius...’ how will he know it's true? Because of course there will be times when we just can't help ourselves. Let's be honest, we're parents... so we have to allow ourselves a bit of gushing sometimes, if only to embarrass our children. It is part of our job to embarrass our children.

Using labels is not against the law. We don't have to avoid them completely, and there are times when we are giving our opinion that we will use them: ‘I thought that was really kind what you did earlier when you let

him eat the last biscuit.’ We just don’t need to do it to create high self-esteem. That spoils it.

So, assuming that you sometimes feel approval towards your child and are not afraid of expressing it, you’ll be doing fine. Genuine, spontaneous, warm, loving praise is lovely and we all like a bit of that. It makes us feel good.

In the end it’s much more relaxing for you as a parent to let go of the idea that creating your child’s self-esteem is your job – that you can make a child into something just by calling her that again and again. True self-esteem and confidence are built in different ways, which I’ll be explaining later in the book. So let’s move on.

If you only take away three things from this chapter, make sure they are these:

1. Stop jumping ahead to subjective interpretations and notice the actual behaviour.
2. When your child does something helpful or kind respond in the way you would to your partner who has just washed the dishes. Pleased, but not gratefully indebted.
3. Remember that children like you to be a witness rather than a constant judge.

CHAPTER FIVE: YOUR CHILD'S FEELINGS

I am driving with a friend whose five-year-old daughter is sitting in the back. Suddenly the little girl says, sadly:

‘Oh, I wish I could have a Furby.’

For those of you who don't remember, Furbies were those awful dollcreatures who talked really annoyingly.

‘Well, you can't have one, darling,’ said her mother.

‘But I want one.’

‘I've told you: you can't have one.’

The little girl starts crying.

‘Why can't I have one? It's not fair.’

Her mother, embarrassed, changes tack:

‘Oh, darling, I know you're feeling really upset.’

The little girl sobs louder and wails:

‘I want one. You never get me what I want.’

‘But, darling, you've got lots of toys already. You don't need any more...’

‘You're a horrible mother.’ The little girl is screaming now.

‘Now stop that noise, please. You know it's not going to help.’

‘But I want a Furby.’

‘Right, that's enough. Stop that crying right now or we won't go to the park.’

The screaming continues for the whole journey and it's quite embarrassing. Poor parents... we try our best, but how are we supposed to manage all those intense feelings of our children?

I include a couple of chapters on children's feelings at this point in the book for a reason: they can set the emotional temperature of the whole

family, and the way we respond to them can create problems that didn't previously exist. Our responses to our child's expressed feelings can actually create an awful lot of difficult and challenging behaviour, so the way we listen to a child is a preventive skill which saves us a lot of stress.

We have lots of different ways of responding to a child's feelings, and none of them seem to be very effective. Camp A and Camp B see two very different things when children express negative feelings.

- Camp A views the expression of negative feelings as naughty behaviour which needs to be changed. So Camp A will minimise feelings by ignoring, dismissing or denying them – or threatening, ridiculing, blaming or judging the child in some way in an effort to stop the behaviour.
- Camp B takes the expression of negative feelings very seriously, viewing them as an indicator of problems which need to be solved. So Camp B will listen and attend, ask questions, reassure and try to help the child to resolve the problem.

There is an ideological basis for both approaches. The first is a personal-responsibility ethic, which may have an underlying disapproval of feelings as an expression of weakness and indulgence. The second represents a belief system rooted in a therapy model of listening, in which expressed negative feelings are viewed as a presenting problem (which possibly conceals a deeper issue).

Responding to Our Child's Emotional Hurts

The reason that we overreact to our child's emotional hurts is that most parents cannot bear to see their child in pain, and we will do anything to make that pain go away. Broadly speaking, the two parenting models do this in very different ways:

- Camp A denies feelings.
- Camp B indulges them.

Both camps may do this out of the best intentions: Camp A parents act out of a belief that the child needs to toughen up or learn a lesson and Camp B

parents act from a belief that children need support to manage their problems.

Both approaches run the risk of making feelings bigger:

- A child whose feelings are denied has to argue more fiercely to defend and justify the strength of those feelings and the reason for them, and he will try to convince you and get you to take him more seriously by exaggerating them even more. In the long term he may also learn not to trust in his own emotional responses and begin to deny them himself.
- A child whose feelings are indulged may also exaggerate them further – in this case in order to continue receiving lots of attention and concern. She can get stuck in her emotions, unable to move on. She may learn that she can manipulate others with her feelings, and begin to define herself by them.

When we respond to our child's feelings and they get bigger, we will take this as evidence that our initial belief was correct: our child gets angry when we deny his feelings and we think 'I was right: he really is a brat. I must get even stricter' or she gets more and more unhappy when we try to help and we think 'I was right: this really is a big problem. I must help her more.'

Both methods are an overreaction to the negative feelings which are simply a part of day-to-day life, and we give them far too much power with either of these responses. Neither method expresses trust and confidence that the child can manage her own feelings, but it's surprising how much they can – even when very young – if we give them the chance.

In reality, of course – irrespective of our beliefs – many parents will jump from one approach to the other out of desperation for the behaviour to stop.

The Culture of Feelings

We have moved, over the course of a few decades, from paying a child's feelings no attention at all to elevating them to the most important issue. We have gone from 'Your feelings are not important' to 'Your feelings are more powerful than you.'

Having looked at the 'Children should be seen and not heard' era and reached the conclusion that children are damaged and repressed for life if they are not heard, our answer has been to go to the opposite extreme and

insist on the benefits of talking through everything. Listening to children has become a crucial part of the parent's role and function.

In our culture today we have elevated feelings to the level of truth – in other words, if I feel offended then it is true that what you said was offensive.

I have noticed – over years of working with parents – the spread of this overwhelming emphasis on feelings. Now, when a child comes home from school and says angrily 'He stomped on my foot in the playground today' often the first question a parent asks is not 'What happened?' or 'What did you do?' but 'How did that make you feel?'

Therapeutic Listening

While it is true that a child suffering a trauma who is given no means of expressing it may internalise it and carry it into adulthood, we also need to be aware that therapy can also exacerbate and reinforce trauma for children. We rush counsellors and therapists along to any disaster where children are involved and yet there are many recorded cases of people who claim that the therapy they were forced to undergo when they were young had a more damaging effect than the original trauma itself.

The therapeutic listening model has nevertheless become a staple of recent parenting advice: parents are all expected to be counsellors to their children now.

This idea is based on the view that children are psychologically fragile, incapable of handling the normal ups and downs of life without our constant support. We are encouraged to listen as if there are layers of repressed feelings our child is hiding which need to be brought to the surface. While this may be very helpful for adults who have had years and years in which to repress feelings (and need some good listening to help reveal them) it's not true of children, who just haven't yet had the time to build up the layers of underlying issues.

Children are not mini adults. They have a very different emotional make-up and experience from us and they don't need the help that an adult in therapy needs. The danger in analysing children's feelings and looking for underlying problems is that you will find them, as children like to give you what you want and will search your face looking for clues to guide them in finding the correct answer for you.

We say ‘How did that make you feel?’ Our child then searches our anxious faces for some indication of what we are expecting and suggests tentatively ‘A bit upset...’ and when we pronounce ‘I’m not surprised. You must have felt really left out’ she nods, relieved that she got it right. Children always like to get the answer right.

We parents are told ‘Try to find out what’s causing it’ or ‘See if you can understand what’s going on behind the behaviour.’ No. Don’t. There isn’t anything.

This is a great way to create problems that did not previously exist. Constantly treating our child as if she is emotionally fragile and in need of our support is not healthy, and this approach gives her feelings power over our child rather than giving her the power to manage her feelings. Managing feelings is not the same as repressing them.

How Children Experience Feelings

Children live in the present moment and express only what is going on right here, right now. The reason that children’s feelings are so intense and explode so rapidly out of nowhere is that for them what is happening right now is the whole world, outside of which nothing else exists. The feeling in the moment is overwhelming and all-encompassing, until the next present moment comes along and the whole world suddenly becomes one of joy and excitement for some other reason. That’s how a child moves through the day: from one present moment to the next, having positive and negative feelings along the way. Once a feeling has passed it is gone and normally forgotten – unlike adults, who will carry a feeling around with us all day, dwelling on it and fuelling it. Children’s feelings are intense, but transient.

Children have a much better time of it than us, really, when it comes to feelings. We could learn a lot from them about letting them go.

What children will do is save up the bad stuff for us. If something upsetting happens at school (as it invariably does), they will file it away, carry it home with them and deliver it to us like a gift. As adults we do this, too: we save stuff for our partners and tell them when we get home in order to get it off our chests. When a child comes home and shares some sadness, anger or frustration they experienced at school they may in fact have had a brilliant day – except for that one bit when they got kicked in the playground at lunchtime – but it sounds to us as if their whole day was awful. All your child needs you to be is a witness to the one bad thing that

happened to him in an otherwise happy day, but if it happens a lot we turn it very quickly into ‘He’s unhappy at school.’

The Neuroscience of Feelings

Those feelings that your child expresses so dramatically every day arise from the primitive brain, and as your child grows up she will learn to manage them using the frontal brain. This is a bit simplified: in fact the two parts of the brain will work together to experience, express and manage feelings. There is no definitive split between the thinking brain and the feeling brain.

We can say, however, that a part of the primitive brain – the amygdala – houses our most primitive and instinctive emotional states, such as fear, jealousy and threat, and that this is where your child dwells for much of the time. This bit, in other words, is sorted: it doesn’t need any help to function; it does its job very well without interference. It’s so good that it’s automatic and unconscious. Remember from [Chapter Three](#) that your child’s primitive brain is fully developed and firing on all cylinders from the off?

What your child is learning throughout childhood – as her prefrontal cortex is developing and making new neural connections – is how to use this frontal or executive brain to manage the feelings of the primitive brain. So, as parents, our job is to help to facilitate this process.

If we remember that language is a product of the frontal brain it’s clear that when children are in an emotional state they are not going to employ its developing skills (like words) very well, and their expressions of feelings are going to be raw and unadulterated by such things as accuracy and clarity. The words that come out are likely to be the first ones that spring to mind: the amygdala reacts with immediacy, not reflection. These words will be likely to be exaggerated and emotive, and if we interpret them literally we will invariably be getting the wrong message.

If our child comes home from school and tells us angrily ‘I hate my teacher’ and we assume that he means it, we’re going to think that something truly awful has happened. We may automatically assume that our child did something wrong and say suspiciously ‘Well, what did you do?’ Or we assume our child’s innocence and react with anxiety and concern. ‘What happened? What made you feel like that?’ Either way we’re off on the wrong path, which will probably lead to even stronger feelings.

If we think about times when we feel very emotional, we often do exactly the same as a child. We will use strong emotive words and exaggerate things – even tell lies – to get across the seriousness of the message, and only when we calm down and our executive brain regains functionality can we admit to this. If even adults have a problem with being strictly accurate with our words when we are overwhelmed with feelings, imagine how much more difficult it is for children. They are not lying deliberately (that particular skill comes from the executive brain: it takes thought and intention) but their words do not necessarily represent the truth.

Mirror Neurons

Feelings are contagious: when faced with someone expressing feelings, even subtly, we easily take them on ourselves. This is because our brains contain billions of mirror neurons which do exactly what they say on the tin: they literally mirror the feelings another person is expressing. In fact mirror neurons mirror everything. When you take a sip of tea the brain of the person with you also sips tea: exactly the same circuitry is activated in her brain as yours. All the same tea-sipping neurons are firing off in exactly the same way – the only difference being that her tea-sipping motor neurons are suppressed, so she doesn't actually copy you physically. You can see why modelling the behaviour we want to see in our child works so well.

When the human species was roaming the savannah it made absolute sense for us to instantaneously feel others' feelings as if they were our own. If a member of our tribe screamed with fear it helped to feel exactly the same emotion immediately, as it was that feeling that motivated us to run for our lives. This helped our species to survive because in those days a scream probably did signify imminent danger: it probably was a tiger. A scream of terror without the accompanying feeling-contagion would have left us pondering about what could have caused it just long enough for us to be eaten for lunch. Although as our children grow up there are situations in which this reflex is still very useful – busy roads, for example – in most of the day-to-day situations we encounter with our children it's probably safe to say that it's not a tiger, so our instinctive response amounts to a huge emotional overreaction. A scream, a wail or an outpouring of tears could just as likely be the result of a young child's frustration with the jigsaw puzzle she is attempting to solve.

Mirror neurons also give us empathy. The ability to identify with what another person is feeling makes us nicer to each other, and this is another huge factor in our survival as a species. Human beings roaming the wild could not survive alone. We needed the protection of the group, so we had to care about each other – and we depended on others caring about us, so that we would willingly help to keep each other safe. Children are born with the capacity for empathy already installed. It's not an add-on.

The Child's Path to Independence

Parents are easily infected with their child's feelings: the same process of mirror neurons firing off is happening but magnified a thousand times, especially for mothers. This is because mother and baby start off literally as one unit, and during the first year of life it makes sense for a mother to feel her baby's pain as if it were her own: it's nature's way of ensuring we look after our babies. As parents we learn to interpret our baby's screams and cries: we know the difference between the hungry cry and the cry of fear, for example. We are totally in tune: we feel our baby's joy and we feel our baby's pain. It happens the other way round, too: you feel down and your baby starts to cry. Feelings between mother and baby are super-contagious. The challenge for mothers – and, to a lesser extent, fathers – is to separate emotionally as their child grows up and to allow an emotional independence in their child, so that she can mature.

We are generally, as parents, pretty good at encouraging a child's physical independence. We know that a child who is always held back from exploring his physical environment is likely to develop fear and timidity. If we take the example of a baby starting to walk, what do we do? We set up a safe environment – a soft carpet, no hard edges of furniture too near. We maybe sit down with another adult a few paces away, hold our child for the first step or two – and then let go, so she can take a couple of steps unaided before falling into the arms of the other person.

Or consider the path to riding a bike without stabilisers. We run alongside, holding the bike steady, and then we let go. We know they may fall and hurt themselves, but we take that risk (and when you've got four children you take the risk earlier with each one, trust me).

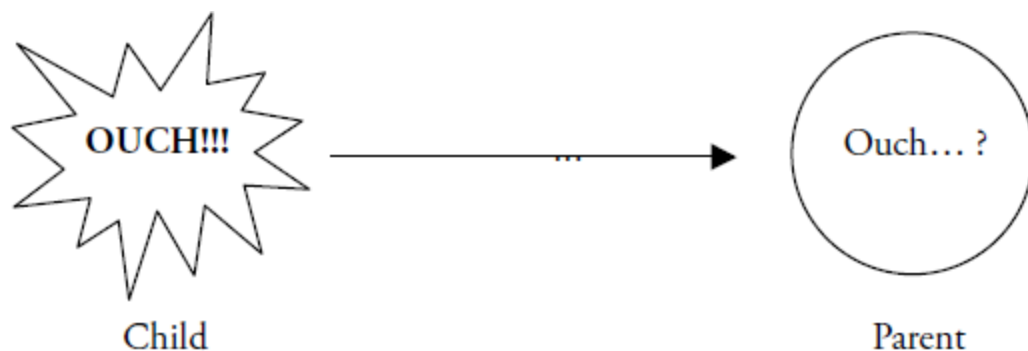
Without the letting go bit, our children would never learn to walk or ride a bike. Well, actually, they would, as they are so fired to travel that path of

independence they would manage it somehow – but the point is that we know that being overprotective will only hold them back.

Physical Hurts

When our child falls over in the playground and scrapes her knee and she comes running to us screaming and crying, we know not to overreact (as long as it's not a serious injury). We may give her a hug and soothe her and stick a plaster on if necessary, but we neither dismiss it entirely nor rush her off to A & E. We know that throughout her childhood she will experience many knocks and scrapes and we know that she needs to be resilient enough to pick herself up, brush herself down and get going again. We don't take on her physical pain and feel it along with her (unless there's blood involved, of course. Then we're allowed to faint). We try to remain calm so that we can help her. We take a step back.

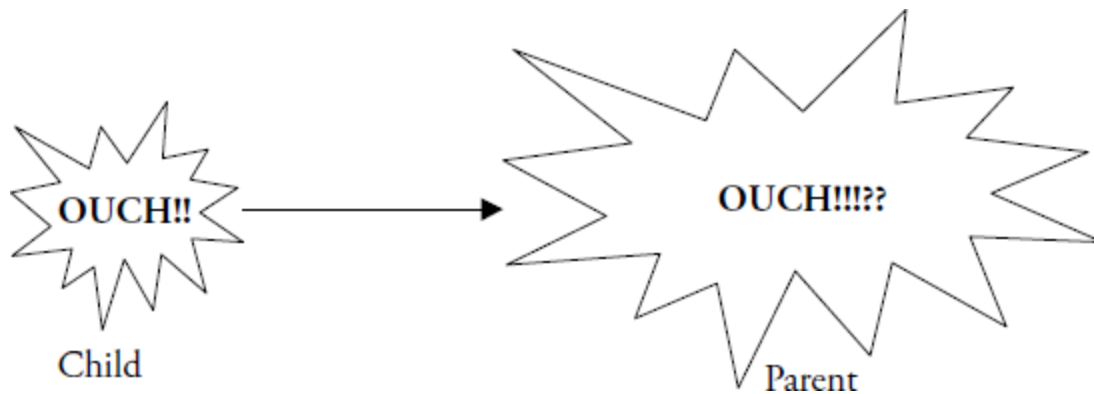
Fig. I. Physical hurts



Emotional Hurts

It is when it comes to emotional independence that we're not so good at doing the letting go bit. If she falls over and hurts herself emotionally we find it more difficult to deal with, as we are more overly-identified with our child's emotional pain than their physical pain... and so we take on her emotional problems as our own. We feel her pain, and it's harder to separate. We may find ourselves inadvertently rushing her off to the A & E of emotional hurts.

Fig. II. Emotional hurts



But a child needs to be resilient to the emotional knocks and scrapes of life, too. She's going to get a lot of those along the way and she learns a lot of very important skills through experiencing them, so we parents need to take a step back when it's an emotional ouch – just as we do when it's a physical ouch.

Relationship Issues and Bullying

The area of emotional hurts that we are most likely to over-identify with will be our child's relationship issues: this is the arena where feelings will be hurt and confidence knocked in ways that we can all recognise and relate to. The word bullying is bandied about a lot these days and the media certainly does its best to fuel parents' anxieties in this area. The definition of true bullying is behaviour which is sustained over a period of time and designed deliberately to cause hurt to someone. Most playground behaviour does not fit this category.

Unless you know that your child is actually being bullied, a parent has to accept that a child will experience her fair share of being left out, teased, called names, pushed over and all those other careless and unsociable things that children do. She will also play her part in dishing them out. Children try on all sorts of behaviours and roles as part of their social learning and it can be the most negative experiences that facilitate the greatest growth if we allow them to just be, and resist jumping in and taking over.

When I was at primary school there was a boy in my class who used to lie in wait with his mates, and every afternoon as my sister and I walked home from school they would jump out and beat us up. I remember my mother being worried one time when we arrived home and there was evidence of blood, but I also remember feeling that it wasn't any of her business. My sister and I certainly didn't expect any help from parents or

teachers. I can still remember the triumph we felt the day we set the local friendly neighbourhood dog on those boys and they ran off screaming. They never beat us up again.

I also still feel ashamed when I remember the time at primary school when I was handing out sheets of paper around the classroom, and when I got to the unpopular girl in the class I deliberately crumpled the corner of the sheet as I handed it to her. I felt instant shame and I remember desperately feeling that I wanted to make it up to her, but I have no recollection of whether I apologised to her or not. Nothing could have taught me better how horrible it is to be deliberately nasty to someone. I still want to say sorry.

So without intending to minimise the effects of real bullying, those (let's call them) negative social interactions can also be great facilitators of learning and growth and the development of inner resources.

Incidentally, children are just as careless as we are with the definition of bullying and they are likely to use this word to cover a wide range of minor upsets, accidents and misunderstandings. If we are not alert to this fact we are likely to react with disproportionate anxiety when our child comes home and tells us 'He's bullying me.'

Staying Separate from Our Child's Feelings

When children express strong negative feelings – and we manage to recognise that those feelings belong our child and not to us – we can resist the emotional contagion and take an emotional step back, just as we do when it's a physical hurt. This does not mean that we act coldly: it actually enables us to express empathy rather than sympathy. Empathy is simply putting ourselves in another's shoes, whereas sympathy is close to pity. It suggests that the situation is serious and the other person is helpless. Sympathy for normal day-to-day upsets can infantilise a child into a learned helplessness, where problems seem insurmountable.

If we are caught up in our child's feelings and respond from that place we create a big muddle of feelings, and then – as feelings are contagious – our anxiety passes back to our child, who now has an extra emotion to deal with on top of the initial one. That creates a huge emotional burden for the child.

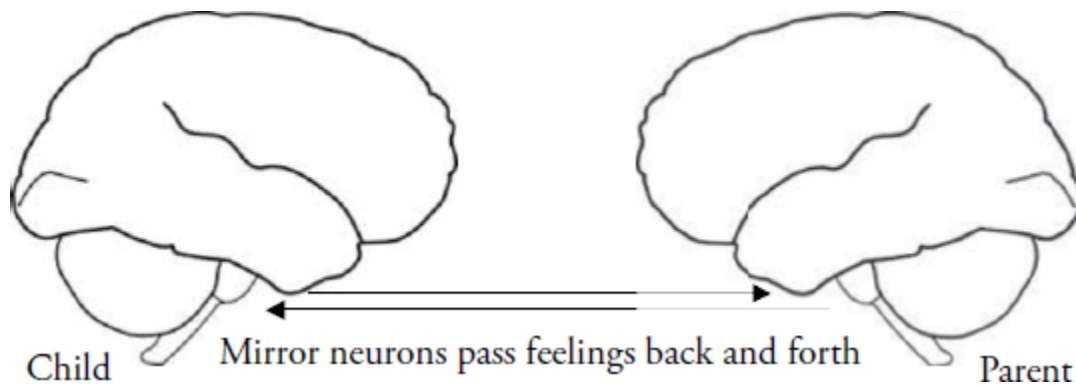
Separating emotionally – resisting the contagion – simply says 'This is where I end and you begin.' It's a simple message of respect towards the

child as a separate human being.

Remember that your child will be acting from her amygdala. If you instantly react from yours you are joining your child in a swamp of primitive emotions, which is not very helpful. Your child really does not need you down there in the amygdala with her: when two primitive brains get muddled up together they are not very good at working things out.

The diagram below shows what is happening when we take on our child's feeling and react instantaneously: two primitive brains pass strong emotions back and forth. This is not a very good way to help a child manage feelings.

Fig. III. Feelings contagion



If you can stop for a minute and take a deep breath this allows time for your prefrontal cortex to kick in, which gives you the ability to consciously act rather than unconsciously *react*. As you inhale and exhale, visualise the space this creates between your child's feelings and your own.

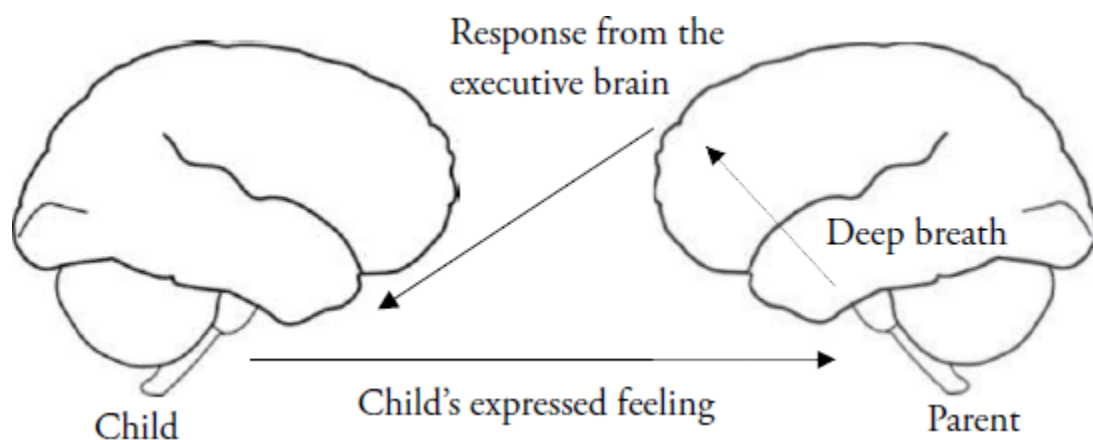
Imagine you're at a party and another guest lays in to you with some unfounded harsh criticism. Feeling insulted, your reflex amygdala response will scream 'Punch him in the face' (or something similar) but generally you don't carry out the amygdala's demands. You know that it's not socially acceptable behaviour, and you might lose friends. So you pause just long enough for your prefrontal cortex to come in and say 'Hang on a minute. That action would not serve me well... probably best to ignore him and walk away with dignity. I'll go and talk to someone else.' See how quickly that reaction kicks in? You can use this practised response when your child wails, cries or expresses sadness – when you know she is in no danger –

and in so doing your response will come from your executive brain, which is cleverer than the primitive one and far more sensible.

Remember that feelings are contagious? Well, it works both ways. If you can recognise that your child's anger or upset belongs to them, not you – and you respond in a fairly level unfazed way – you are passing back to her a feeling of being calm and in control. In modelling the management of your own feelings you are helping your child to employ the services of her prefrontal cortex and flex that muscle herself. The more practice your child gets the more she begins to master her own feelings, rather than allowing her feelings to control her.

The diagram below shows a conscious response from the executive brain of the parent to the emotions expressed from the primitive brain of the child.

Fig. IV. Responding consciously



The challenge for parents is to manage our own feelings of fear, anxiety, worry and pain that our children's upsets provoke in us, rather than helping our child to manage her feelings. In so doing we don't have to teach our child anything. She learns all she needs from just observing and imitating us. It makes no sense to pour all our energy into fixing our child, while making no effort to control our own feelings and manage our own discomfort. If we manage to do that we can just let mirror neurons do the rest.

In other words, when a child is upset she doesn't want you to be like a sapling that blows about in the storm with her. She wants you to be the oak tree that stands firm.

We could try simply allowing our children to have negative feelings as we allow them to have positive ones, and recognise that the feelings belong to the child and that they are not ours to manage. A feeling is just a feeling, nothing more and nothing less. We all have them. There is no problem to solve.

Accepting Feelings Without Trying to Change Them

When my youngest boys were aged five and three we went down to the local park with a friend of mine and a football. My older boy was wearing a short-sleeved football shirt and my younger boy a long-sleeved rugby shirt. On arrival, my younger son suddenly burst into tears.

‘I want a football shirt,’ he wailed.

My friend tried to cheer him up.

‘But your shirt is lovely, too.’

‘No, it’s not! I want a football shirt.’

‘Yours has got brilliant stripes on it, though, and his hasn’t.’

‘I want a football shirt!’

‘Ooh... well, look. How about you roll your sleeves up? Then it would look like a football shirt.’

‘No, it wouldn’t.’

He screamed and sobbed louder.

‘You’re missing all the fun. Look, your brother’s having so much fun.’

(Desperate sobbing).

‘You’re not going to have any time to play if you just stay here crying.’

‘I want a football shirt.’ He was looking around wildly now.

‘Your brother’s going to think you’re a baby... ’

By this point I was desperate. I intervened.

‘You wish you had a shirt like his...?’ I ventured.

He stopped crying immediately and stared at me.

‘Yes,’ he said simply, and ran off to play.

My friend looked at me.

‘How did you do that?’ she asked.

I remember this occasion with such clarity because it was the first time I had tentatively tried out just accepting one of my child’s feelings without trying to change it in any way. It turned out that that was all he wanted. And from that moment on, my life became easier.

Mishearing Our Children

‘I don’t want to go to school today.’ Thus starts the day in many happy households across the country, to the delight of all parents. It’s amazing, though, what different things we hear – and how differently we respond – when our child makes that one simple statement.

Sometimes we respond ‘Well, you have to go.’

(As if they have just said ‘I won’t go to school today.’)

Sometimes we respond ‘Why not? Are you having problems at school?’

(As if they have just said ‘I’m unhappy at school and I haven’t been able to share that with you.’)

Sometimes we respond ‘Don’t be silly. You love school.’

(As if they have just said ‘I hate school.’)

Sometimes we respond ‘Don’t worry. You’ll have a lovely time when you get there.’

(As if they have just said ‘I’m really worried about what’s going to happen at school today.’)

Sometimes we respond ‘Well, if you don’t go to school you won’t learn anything.’

(As if they have just said ‘Why do I have to go to school?’)

Sometimes we respond ‘I don’t want to go to work sometimes, but I know that I have to.’

(As if they have just said ‘How do you feel about going to work?’)

Sometimes we respond ‘Everyone feels like that sometimes, but you have to just get up and go.’

(As if they have just said ‘Do other people sometimes not feel like going to school, and what do they do about it?’)

Sometimes we respond ‘Well you can’t stay in bed all day.’

(As if they have just said ‘I’m not getting up.’)

Sometimes we respond ‘Well, you’re bloody going – whether you like it or not.’

(As if they have just said ‘I don’t like school. I’m not going and you can’t make me.’)

I could go on and on. I’m sure that’s not an exhaustive list. The point is that we mishear what our children say, so we don’t respond to that. Instead we jump ahead into our own assumptions of their meaning and respond to what’s inside our own heads.

If I think about the times I have said ‘I don’t want to go to work today’ my meaning is just that: I don’t feel like it. It’s raining and cold outside. I don’t want to get out of my warm bed. I am still fully intending to go, obviously. I am just having a present-moment feeling, the kind that our children have all the time. For so many children the issue is not even about the subject they are mentioning, but about the difficulty of managing those change times when you move from one activity or place to the next.

If anyone was around to hear me say ‘I don’t want to go to work today’ I would expect them to say – with some understanding – something like ‘Ugh. Yeah... ’ or ‘Mmmm... nice warm bed... ?’ or ‘Mmmm... ?’ or ‘No... ?’ or ‘Don’t feel like it... ?’ or maybe just wrinkle their nose and nod with understanding, and then go about their own business. I would expect some empathy, but I wouldn’t expect anyone to take it too seriously: after all, we all feel like that sometimes, don’t we? I certainly wouldn’t be happy if anyone tried to fix me.

When it comes to children, though, we often don’t allow them to experience common human feelings – not when they are negative ones, anyway – so we jump in.

- We assume that a negative feeling is a problem.
- We make an assumption about the child’s intended behaviour.
- We see negative feelings as a teaching opportunity.
- We think we have to do something about it.

All we actually need do is be in the present moment with our child and respond to the feeling being expressed in that moment only. We need to remember that a child will express feelings in a way which makes the situation sound worse than it actually is. Nine times out of ten ‘I don’t want to go to school today’ – if expressed accurately – would be ‘I wish I could lie in my nice warm bed a little longer.’

In all the examples of responses I have listed above we have assumed the opposite: that the strength of feeling and the seriousness of the problem are bigger than they sound. If we assume this every time it won’t be long before we believe that our child is having real problems at school.

When our child says ‘I don’t want to go to school today’ we could just say ‘Uh-huh... ? Don’t feel like it... ?’ with understanding, and then continue about our own business on the assumption that they are obviously

still intending to go. In other words, we could simply trust them. Trust that they are bigger than their feelings: their feelings are not bigger than them. Trust in their good intentions: treat them as if we believe they are capable of acting in positive ways despite feeling negative. Our trust is so powerful: our child imbibes it as the truth and naturally begins to act in that way.

So how would I have responded to the child at the beginning of this chapter who wished she could have a Furby? I may have just said:

‘Yeah..?’

I may have said:

‘Mmm..? You like them..?’

I may have spoken quite carelessly, I would have shown either mild interest or warm empathy depending on the circumstances. I would have assumed that my child was simply sharing something with me, and I would not have jumped to the assumption that she was making a demand of me. We’ll be exploring a range of responses to negative feelings in the next chapter, but before we finish here, let’s look at a similar example of a child assumed to be making a demand, but this time by happily expressing a positive feeling.

Positive Feelings

We mishear expressed positive feelings, too, when they are inconvenient for us: we jump ahead and respond to our own assumptions instead of to the feeling being expressed.

Here’s a typical scenario, which I observed in a shop:

A mother with a buggy and a baby is struggling to push the chemist door open and get out of the shop. Meanwhile, her three-year-old’s attention has been caught by a tower of lovely glittery hair bands – one of which she picks out, her eyes wide.

‘Mummy,’ she says. ‘Look at this.’

‘Come on, darling. You’ve already got loads of those at home.’

‘This one’s so pretty, Mummy.’

‘Yes, it is, but you don’t need another one. Come on. We have to go.’

‘It’s lovely.’

‘Yes, but I’ve told you that you can’t have another one. Come on.’

The little girl seems rooted to the spot, unable to let go of the lovely hairband. The mother becomes impatient.

‘Darling, come on. Now, please. I’m not buying that for you. You’ve got enough.’

We have all had experiences like this with our children in shops, haven’t we? There are always so many lovely colourful things around to distract our child, and we do what we can to get them out of the shop as quickly as possible. But when we jump to assumptions about our child’s motives and intended actions, as the mother above did, we actually make it more difficult. The assumption that the little girl wants the hairband introduces the possibility to her that her mother might buy it for her, and now she has something to hold out for. We actually make it almost impossible for her not to. At no point in this exchange has the mother genuinely acknowledged the only thing her daughter wanted to communicate to her, which was ‘Isn’t this pretty?’

I remember one experience like this with my daughter which well and truly ruined a whole afternoon.

What I learned to do was respond to my child, and stop responding to my assumptions. I may have had to say something like ‘Ooh, it’s pretty’ and ‘Aaah, lovely’ a couple of times (genuinely and warmly) before letting her know we were leaving the shop, but the whole process was so much quicker. Knowing that you have seen what she wanted to show you, a child is much more willing to let it go and run to join you when you tell her it’s time to go.

It is so much simpler than we make it.

I’ll stay with feelings for another chapter, and then we’ll move on to the business of how to leave the shop from [Chapter Seven](#) onwards, because we don’t want to be stuck in there forever, do we?

If you only take away three things from this chapter, make sure they are these:

1. Children’s feelings come from their primitive brains. They always sound a lot worse than they actually are, and their words will not be accurate.
2. Respond to your child’s present-moment feeling and not to your projected assumptions.

3. Get into the habit of taking a deep breath before you respond to your child's feelings so that you are able to respond consciously rather than react unconsciously.

CHAPTER SIX: RESPONDING TO NEGATIVE FEELINGS

My oldest son, when he was about twelve, returned home from school one day looking ashen-faced.

‘Oh, Mum. Something terrible happened at school today,’ he said, quietly. He looked shocked.

‘What? What?’ I responded with shock and concern.

‘Someone was being given birthday bumps and they dropped him, and an ambulance came and everything.’

‘Oh my God,’ I exclaimed, horrified. ‘Oh no. Oh, how awful. Oh, his poor parents. Was he OK? What happened? Oh, that must have been so shocking for you to see. Are you OK? Are you all right?’

‘Mum,’ he said. ‘Please stop. I am OK but you’ve just made me feel much worse.’

He walked off and I felt terrible. I knew by then not to take on my children’s feelings, and I had just done it. In fact I hadn’t only taken them on, I had added much more to them.

My son, of course, had felt shocked and anxious – but he was dealing with it, and was back to his cheerful self very quickly. He felt bad, forgot about it and moved on. I not only took on his feelings but also those of the boy involved, those of the boy’s parents and possibly the feelings of the whole school authorities, too.

This experience and his reaction made me realise that if I had been in the habit of overidentifying with his feelings throughout his childhood he probably wouldn’t be sharing anything with me by now. Still, everyone’s

allowed to make mistakes – and the birthday bumps boy was fine – so I got over it.

I use that as an example of what can happen to any parent, but it is so much worse when your child is expressing an emotional hurt that they themselves have suffered. If you are a parent of young children, wait until your fifteen-year-old is dumped by his first girlfriend. Then you will really know what emotional overidentification means.

It doesn't get any easier in that sense but it does help to have years of practice behind you in terms of being able to take a step back, manage your own feelings and develop a trust in your child that he will be fine.

Adult Feelings and Child Feelings

When we adults have emotional issues we can't help but bring all our amassed experience, wisdom and knowledge to our problems, and our feelings are multilayered: we may feel down, guilty about feeling down, impatient with ourselves for always feeling like this and helpless that we will always feel this way. We have problems and then we feel bad about having problems. In other words, we easily add the past, the future and all sorts of interpretations to any feeling we experience. Children don't do that, and if we assume that they do then we approach our children's feelings from an adult perspective – and we create adult problems.

Turning Feelings into Problems

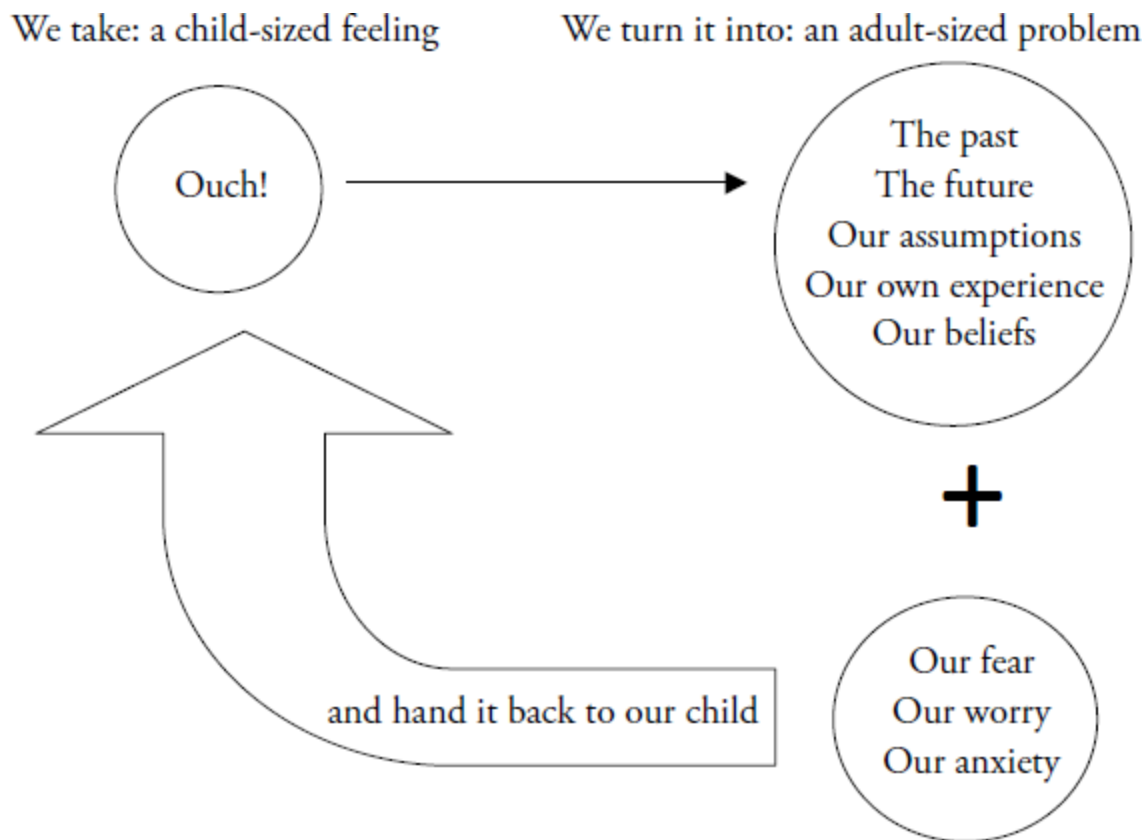
We take a child-sized feeling and in our minds we add:

- The past: 'He's done this lots of times before.'
- The future: 'She'll never learn to stand up for herself.'
- Our beliefs: 'It's my job to fix it.'
- Our assumptions: 'He's incapable of dealing with it.'
- Our own experiences: 'This happened to me when I was a child and it damaged me so it's going to damage him' or 'This is a huge issue for me so it's going to be a huge issue for her.'

We mix that well with a large dose of our anxiety and fear, and hand it back. In other words, we make a child-sized feeling into an adult-sized problem. If we assume that our children are experiencing the depth of feeling that we

do when we are wailing broken-heartedly, we're going to be very worried about them a lot of the time.

Fig. I. Child-sized feelings



Whereas the child can move on from negative feelings and forget about them completely we are not so lucky, and if we allow them to be transferred to us we are likely to hold on to them and carry them round with us for much longer.

Let's have a look at the most common ways we do this in our responses to a child who is expressing negative feelings.

Typical Responses to Negative Feelings

There are twelve typical responses to feelings or problems which are not very helpful. None of these responses are terrible in themselves, but let's have a look at them and see why they don't help as a first response to a child's expressed feeling:

- Ordering/instructing: ‘Stop that noise’ or ‘Don’t moan’ or ‘Stop crying’ (as if that’s going to work).
- Warning/threatening: ‘If you keep on crying you’re going to make yourself sick’ or ‘If you don’t stop moaning we’re not going to the park’ (I can’t think of anything less likely to cheer a child up).
- Moralising/lecturing: ‘You’re a big girl now. You shouldn’t be crying’ or ‘Think of those worse off than you. You ought to think yourself lucky’ (Nobody likes a lecture. It doesn’t make anyone feel better).
- Advising/giving solutions: ‘Why don’t you just tell him how you feel?’ or ‘If I were you I’d just stop talking to her’ (Yes, but I didn’t ask you. You don’t know what you’re talking about).
- Arguing/disagreeing: ‘Ever thought that she might feel the same?’ or ‘But you’ve got lovely hair. Fuzzy hair is beautiful, too’ (We are always arguing with our children and we don’t understand why they are always arguing with us).
- Criticising/judging: ‘I’m sure you were at fault, too’ or ‘You just don’t know when to stop. That’s your problem’ (Another contender for the most-likely-to-escalate-negative-feelings category).
- Analysing/interpreting: ‘I think that’s because you lack confidence’ or ‘Maybe you’re too sensitive’ (It’s really irritating to be analysed, especially by someone who wasn’t actually there).
- Praising/agreeing: ‘You must have felt really hurt’ or ‘You’re such a friendly little girl. They’re just being mean’ (Agreeing with a child’s negative assessment of a situation – which is probably inaccurate, anyway – reinforces her blamelessness and helplessness).
- Reassuring/sympathising: ‘Oh, don’t worry. You’re going to have a lovely morning’ or ‘Oh, you poor thing. That sounds awful’ (This one communicates clearly the anxiety of the parent, adding an extra burden on the child).
- Questioning/probing: ‘What happened next?’ or ‘How did you feel about that?’ (This fact-gathering is usually a prelude to offering advice. A child has to come up with the right answers to direct questions, which could lead anywhere (and not necessarily to the truth)).
- Labelling/name-calling: ‘You’re just being a baby’ or ‘Don’t be silly’ (Being called names never helps).
- Distracting/diverting: ‘Sounds like you’ve got the problems of the world on your shoulders – ha ha’ or ‘Let’s not think about that now’ (Ouch).

These twelve responses are very common. Our parents used them. We use them. We all have our favourites and we use them with the best of intentions. They are not inherently bad or wrong and I will be explaining at the end of this chapter how some of them may be useful at times, but for now we are looking at how they may make things worse as a first response to an expressed feeling. Or as a second or third response, in fact. Remember the magic three times I introduced in [Chapter Three](#)? The principle applies here, too: more of that later.

We very often don't just use one of these typical responses. We'll put a few together:

- Advising, criticising and moralising: 'Why don't you just ignore them when they say that? Anyway, you do tend to be a bit bossy. You need to learn to be a bit more accepting of others and their viewpoints... you ought to listen to people more. Nobody likes bossy people.'
- Ordering, arguing and analysing: 'Calm down. It's not as bad as it seems. You're overreacting... he probably didn't mean it. You get upset too easily... you take things the wrong way.'
- Questioning, praising and reassuring: 'What happened next? How did you feel about that? I'm not surprised you were so upset. They were really nasty to you. You did nothing wrong – they're just bullies. Poor you... don't worry. We'll get to the bottom of this and sort it out.'

Our responses are generally well-intentioned: we really want to help. The first example is an attempt to help a child see things from both sides but it ends up making her feel bad about not just her behaviour, but her understanding of the situation, her personality and her attitudes. The second tries to give a child a different perspective and an explanation of the part he has played, but again it just makes him feel worse about himself as well as misunderstood. The third example is an attempt to empathise and support, but digs the child deeper into a hole of helpless victimhood.

We'll look at that last one in a bit more detail because it's often that combination which parents use in a genuine attempt to understand and support a child, without realising how much it can actually create more problems.

Praising and Agreeing

I once worked with some parents who had kept their ten-year-old daughter off school because of bullying.

I asked her parents how they responded to her when she came home complaining of being bullied and they told me that they listened to her and tried to support her, so I asked them if they would role play that for me to show exactly how they did this. One parent took the role of the child, the other took the role of the parents – and they demonstrated for me a typical conversation with their daughter. They used a combination of questioning, praising and sympathy in response to her original complaint of being bullied by one person, which then – over the course of the conversation – she exaggerated more and more until by the end she was claiming that every child in the school was joining in and bullying her, too.

If you remember that a child's first complaint is likely to be an exaggeration you can see how, if this is taken too seriously, a child may be compelled to exaggerate further in order to justify that level of concern in her parents. Concerned and attentive sympathy from parents can be quite seductive for a child: she may well enjoy it so much that she produces more and more evidence just to keep it going.

And, of course, once you start you can't stop. It's impossible to retract a false statement at a later date. You really don't want to make fools of your parents, so you dig yourself into a deeper and deeper hole.

Reassurance

Something that we instinctively want to do when our child is expressing pain, fear or some kind of upset is to reassure them – 'It's going to be OK. There's nothing to worry about.' The problem with reassurance is that it can so often take a child into the future, when all they are concerned about is the present moment. Reassurance can jump to an assumption of the child's meaning: a future fear which is not yet there in her mind until we put it there.

Let's take as an example another perennial favourite of parents: the three-year-old who is clinging to your legs and who doesn't want to let you go as you take her in to nursery. Let's keep in mind your aim, which is to get her in as painlessly as possible for the sake of you both. You know she enjoys it once she's there and you trust the teachers to take care of her. This is an area of Parental Authority which we'll get to in the next chapter, but

for now let's look at the typical reassurance response which parents hope will make things easier:

'Don't worry, darling. You're going to have a lovely time this morning.'

In her present moment the child is not yet thinking about her morning at nursery or whether she will enjoy it or not. All she is feeling is 'I don't want to be separated from Mummy right now.' Our reassurance takes her into the future and actually raises the possibility that she might not have a lovely time, something she was not yet questioning until we put the idea into her head. She now has two things to worry about.

Incidentally, the dismissive denial of feelings 'Don't be silly. You know you always have a nice time at nursery' does the same.

While there are times when a child may genuinely need reassurance from us, all too often we rely on it in an attempt to change feelings – which inevitably makes them stronger as a child tries to justify them. That's why it can be better to say nothing at all, or just an empathetic 'Oooh' and a hug as you take her in. In so doing you are sending a strong message of trust that although you empathise with her feelings right now, you are confident that she will manage those feelings and go in anyway. When we try to change feelings we send the message 'You're right. This feeling is so big and scary that even I, a big adult, am frightened by it so much that I need to try and change it.'

What about those times when our child is genuinely scared, though? Isn't it our job to reassure her? Absolutely – and we may need to – but as a first response to a feeling we still run the risk of making things worse. The more we reassure the more we send the message that this is a huge issue – which a child needs adult help to deal with. While this may sometimes be the case, unless we leave a little space for our child's own wisdom and resourcefulness to show we don't know for sure.

When my daughter was about four years old she was in bed one evening when I heard her crying and shouting 'Mummy' and I ran up to the bedroom to see what was wrong. I sat down on the bed and hugged her, and this is what she told me, frightened and sobbing:

'Mummy, I'm so scared. I keep thinking that some bad men are going to come in the house, and they'll come through the living room and shoot you and Daddy, and then they'll come upstairs and they'll find me... '

'Oooh,' I said, hugging her tighter. 'That's horrible.'

‘Yes,’ she said, still sobbing. ‘And I think they’re going to be like robots, all silver and marching, like machines, and they’ll just come through the house and upstairs...’

‘Oooh... scary.’

‘Yes.’

Her crying eased off as I hugged her, stroked her hair, and made more ‘Oooh’ noises. Then she peered up at me with a slightly embarrassed look on her face.

‘Mummy...?’

‘Yes, lovely?’

‘Of course I know it’s not true.’

‘No.’

She giggled.

‘That could never happen.’

‘No, of course not.’

And we both giggled together and had a longer cuddle before I said ‘Night night, darling. Sleep well, now’ and left her snuggling down happily. The whole thing took about ten minutes, and I was amazed.

Of course I would have reassured her had she continued crying but I was so glad that I didn’t jump in with the reassurance right at the start, as she got the chance to draw on her own wisdom and knowing. She never got scared again at night, and I do wonder whether that experience of moving from fear to self-reassurance had enabled her to deal with any subsequent fears by herself before they really took hold. In other words, she had been able to draw on inner resources which had not previously been there. It is this inner resilience which is so valuable for our children, and maybe we don’t give that a chance to develop if we always reassure them as soon as they are afraid.

The problem with all the typical responses to negative feelings is that they are reacting to a problem to be solved or a feeling to be changed, and they all assume responsibility for doing this job. It may be – and usually is – the fact that your child just has a feeling and expresses it simply to share it with you. He is not asking you to solve anything, and he is not asking for your judgement of it. It’s just a bit of steam that needs to escape from the pressure cooker: your child needs to let it out to feel better. Expressing the feeling is solving the problem.

What we don't realise when we use one of these responses is that we may be creating a problem for the child – a problem of not being believed, feeling misunderstood, ridiculed, dismissed or criticised on the one hand – or suddenly feeling the burden of our care, anxiety or fear on the other. The child's resulting escalation of feelings are misinterpreted by us as confirmation that the first expressed feeling was indeed a problem, and it may be further compounded as we continue to explore it and try to solve it.

Active Listening

A currently popular alternative to the twelve typical responses is Active Listening. Its principle of leaving feelings with the child – accepting them and not trying to change them – is a good one, and reflects much of what I have discussed here. In fact I used to teach this form of listening when I taught P.E.T. courses for parents. I began to modify my own teaching of this skill very early on, however, as I learned through experience with my own children that it was rarely necessary – and that in fact it was in itself an overreaction to most normal day-to-day feelings (which could easily exacerbate them, in a similar way to the response of questioning, praising and reassuring).

The premise of Active Listening is to accurately reflect back to a child the feelings he is expressing, using both words and body language which match the child's, and the idea is to help a child reveal the real problem behind the presenting problem, thus facilitating his own problem-solving skills. This is the kind of therapeutic listening which I introduced in the last chapter. It works well for adults in counselling, but is a rather dangerous model to be transferred to parents with children.

Its first premise that a feeling is a problem sets us off on the wrong path from the start, as a child's feeling is just a feeling and is not likely to be covering up any deeper problems which need to be revealed. Just by approaching our child's feelings in this way we are jumping ahead to assumptions. Attending and matching the child's body language just puts us right down there with him in his primitive brain where he doesn't want us – he's already managing quite well in there by himself and he doesn't need our help. I have never known a child who needs this amount of encouragement to express his true feelings if he really needs to, although this is exactly what an adult in therapy needs. The emphasis on a child's

feelings gives them too much power over the child, who can then easily get stuck in them.

A typical Active Listening response may be:

‘So you were feeling really left out... ?’

‘You felt really frustrated when he took your toy... ?’

‘You’re feeling really sad you can’t go... ?’

What I noticed, both with my own children and those I worked with at the school, was that this kind of response didn’t really help, and children just didn’t like it. It so often seemed to provoke anger and irritation, maybe because it can feel like being counselled – which is really irritating when you’re not ill. Having your feelings reflected can also feel intrusive, and it can be disempowering to have feelings emphasised, especially when using emotive words like lonely, sad or hurt, which only serve to reinforce self-pity.

But, above all, it feels like a technique, a heavy-handed and unnatural response to what are – 99% of the time – fleeting feelings, which sound a lot worse than they really are.

Acknowledging Your Child’s Feelings

At primary school my daughter was often left out of the group of girls, a situation which was very triggering for me as it brought back all the feelings I had experienced as a child when excluded from the group I so desperately wanted to belong to. So when she came home from school one day and said ‘Mummy, none of the children in my class like me’ my stomach turned somersaults. It wasn’t quite as simple as that, though. I also knew that she could be very difficult to get along with and I really wished she would just be an easier child.

So I had two conflicting automatic responses to her statement going on in my head at the same time. One was an anxious and pitying ‘Oh, darling, you poor thing. You’re lovely. How could anyone not like you?’ The other was a rather self-satisfied I-told-you-so ‘Well, if you weren’t so bossy, maybe people would like you.’ I would like to claim that it was my superior parenting skills that stopped me from using either of these responses, but it wasn’t. It was confused paralysis.

So I just grunted ‘Uhh... ?’

‘Yeah,’ she said.

I was stumped, trying to think of what to say next, when she corrected herself.

‘Well, actually, Beth likes me. And Sarah... she does... ’

‘Uh-huh... ?’ I said.

‘Mmm. And Carl likes me. And Jo likes me sometimes... ’

‘Yeah... ?’

‘Yeah. And, actually, I think Freddie likes me half the time. And Sammy likes me half the time too... ’

The conversation carried on in this vein until she reached the conclusion that there were only a couple of children she felt really didn’t like her and, having decided that, she ran off happily.

In allowing and accepting her initial judgement and continuing to simply acknowledge what she was saying all I had done was allow her the space to think and process her thoughts as she was speaking, and in so doing her statements had become more and more accurate (the opposite process to the example I used above of questioning, praising and sympathising).

This situation taught me a lot. I realised that my own two conflicting feelings – one pitying and the other reproving – had cancelled each other out, which meant that I had responded from a genuinely feelings-neutral place. Because this situation had demonstrated to me so clearly that my daughter was quite capable of handling something which I would have previously considered devastating I felt a genuine trust in her resilience, which I had had to fake previously.

My research and experience has convinced me that the most important thing about responding to children’s feelings lies not in our ability to help them with *their* feelings, but to manage our own. When our child’s pain is communicated to us we have to give a nod to our mirror neurons, thank them for alerting us, and let them go. We have to take a deep breath and allow time for our executive brain to come in and remind us that those feelings belong to our child and they are not ours to manage. In so doing we will respond with genuine empathy without taking it too seriously. The actual words we use are less important than our ability to leave the feelings with the child, together with our trust that they can manage them.

If we can accept the feeling we can simply acknowledge it without adding anything on. We can respond in a serious, fairly matter-of-fact tone

of voice and facial expression: we are simply receiving some interesting information about our child which they want to share with us.

Remembering that most of your child's expressions of feelings throughout the day are instant in-the-moment affairs with no deeper meaning, an accepting acknowledging response can be very simple. You don't even need proper words. A wrinkled nose and a 'Tch' or 'Duh...' or 'Oooh' or 'Doh...' is enough to convey empathy. A 'Yeah... ?' or an 'Oh, wow...' or 'Uh-huh... ?' or 'Mmm... ?' will do.

Doing nothing to help when your child expresses upset is a counter-intuitive skill, but in fact you're helping in the best way possible when you take feelings seriously but not too seriously. You are neither dismissing nor indulging. You are allowing a space for your child to share negative feelings with you, just as you allow her to share positive ones. You are not directing the subject into your own agenda. And you are helping to dissipate intense feelings for both your child and yourself.

I didn't know it then, but the process I saw in my daughter that day was an example of her executive brain managing the emotions of her primitive brain. The primitive brain goes into action, full of feeling and not very accurate with words: each time those feelings are expressed a little steam escapes from the pressure cooker and the executive brain comes onto the scene bit by bit to set the primitive brain straight. We think we have to teach our children this stuff, but really we need to simply allow space for it to happen naturally: it is how our brains work.

We can help facilitate this process in our child by responding with a simple acknowledgement. As a rule of thumb, remember to keep to the magic three times before you give in to the temptation to fix it. That's usually enough for most day-to-day feelings to dissipate.

Different Ways of Acknowledging

There are lots of ways of acknowledging our child's feelings. We will all do it in our different ways according to our personalities, but if you find it difficult not to jump in with a judgement or a solution, a simple initial response to give you time is a negative acknowledgement, such as 'Don't you... ?' 'Wasn't it... ?' 'Couldn't you... ?' etc.. This is not voiced as a demanding question but in an empathising, questioning tone of voice.

If you've acknowledged two or three times and your child then changes the subject or skips off to play, then problem over. Most day-to-day feelings

dissipate quickly. If it's going on for longer, you have a choice. You know your child best and if you can see that it's not really that big a deal you can bring it to a close yourself by changing the subject or directing your attention elsewhere. Or you can use a generalised empathic statement such as:

‘Yeah... situations like that can be difficult... ’

‘It can be hard to know what to do sometimes... ’

‘It can be tough when things like that happen... ’

These are useful if you're uncomfortable with the conversation trailing off and you're feeling frustrated that it hasn't been resolved, because what these musings communicate is an understanding of your child's specific issue but at the same time the fact that it's a common problem and he's not alone. In other words, it's just life.

Very often, though, it doesn't take much for a child to reach her own solution very quickly.

My daughter, when younger, was in the habit of screaming in the car. When she was about seven we had set off for school in the morning one day when she suddenly started wailing and screaming in the back, and my heart sank in expectation of a whole journey of this behaviour.

‘I forgot my book,’ she wailed. ‘I promised Marion I'd bring it in to show her today.’

‘Aaargh,’ I said, trying to concentrate on the road.

‘Can we go back and get it, Mum?’

‘No. We'd all be late then.’

Screams of fury.

‘But I promised I'd bring it today.’

‘Doh... ’ I said, with empathy.

She carried on sobbing angrily.

‘I remembered to bring it downstairs and I put it on the table ready and then I forgot.’

‘Oh, no... ’ I could understand her frustration.

A few minutes later I noticed that it had gone quiet in the back, and then her little voice piped up:

‘Mummy, would it be all right if I brought it in tomorrow, instead?’

‘Yes, of course it would, lovely. That would be fine.’

‘Thank you.’

And she was quiet and happy for the rest of the journey. I know exactly what her response would have been had I offered her that solution myself, and it really doesn't bear thinking about. But because it was her idea, she was very happy with it.

I learned through many situations like this that it didn't matter if I was a little bit distracted. In fact it seemed to be better if I was cooking, or washing the dishes, or busy with something else and didn't have the time to be too concerned. My responses were genuine and natural and totally unskilled: grunts and noises seemed to do.

To get a bit more sophisticated than just grunting, reflecting feelings can be fine as long as we don't use overly-emotive words and we can manage to stay separate and keep it simple.

'Disappointed... ?'

'You didn't like that... ?'

'That was tough... ?'

'Frustrating... ?'

'Not happy about it... ?'

If you think about reflecting a child's experience or the situation he is in, rather than focusing on his feelings, you are less likely to exacerbate emotions or add ones that weren't there to begin with.

'Having problems... ?'

'Couldn't work out what to do... ?'

'Finding that hard... ?'

'Not going your way... ?'

'Bit tricky...?'

An acknowledgement is not a direct question which demands a correct answer, but a questioning statement of empathy which allows a child to keep talking, processing his feelings as he does so.

Responses to Avoid

An acknowledgement is a You-message. Your response is directed towards your child:

(You're) 'Not sure about that... ?'

(You) 'Don't like that... ?'

(You) 'Don't feel like it... ?'

If we try to acknowledge by using an I-message we are getting the subject back to ourselves, not to the child:

- ‘I hear you.’ (It’s not about you).
- ‘I understand.’ (No, you don’t. How could you? You’re not me).
- ‘I know you’re angry, but... ’ (Like a red rag to a bull, this one. To be avoided at all costs).

We also have to avoid acknowledging another person:

- ‘He was really mean to you... ?’ (It’s not about him).
- ‘She’s been bullying you... ?’ (It’s not about her).
- ‘They’re all really nasty... ?’ (It’s not about them).

These acknowledgements reinforce in our child’s mind the behaviour of another child, but we don’t know if it’s true yet. All we have heard is our child’s perception and strength of feeling. Reflecting back an accusation about someone else’s behaviour gets dangerously close to the praising and agreeing response in its affirmation of the child’s perception of the situation. No matter how strong your child’s feelings are about another child, be very careful in making assumptions that your child is right – and be very cautious about judging your child’s friend. Inevitably, the next day, they will be best friends again.

You remember that time when you were younger when you confided in a girlfriend that you were thinking of ending a relationship and you listed all your boyfriend’s faults? And she said, ‘Oh, yes. I’ve always thought he was a bully. Dump him.’ And then you stayed with him and felt awkward about ever meeting your girlfriend again because now you knew what she really thought of him? Well, it’s like that.

The Teenage Years

There’s nothing like the self-doubts our children express in their teenage years to get us jumping in with our anxiety and overidentification. That’s because their concerns and experiences start to feel more like our own: they are growing up and entering the adult world, which we know can be cruel. They are beginning to have a wider perception of their place in the world and we desperately want to protect them from its hurts, especially in areas where we ourselves have suffered or continue to suffer.

If we react from our own insecurities out of the fear that our children are experiencing the same, then we can end up by magnifying the very

issues in which we want them to have confidence. But our children have their own scripts and their own life paths: just because we have struggled with an issue all our lives does not mean that they are condemned to experience that too.

Just be aware that overidentification is likely to happen more between a parent and child of the same sex, because we have lived experience in the issues involved with becoming a man or becoming a woman.

Let's take the area of body confidence in teenage girls as an example. We are overwhelmingly advised to help our daughters with body confidence issues through constant reassurance:

- 'But you're not fat.'
- 'But you're beautiful. True beauty comes from inside.'

We need to remember that constantly arguing with our daughter, and in effect telling her that her perceptions are incorrect, does not give her confidence. It just makes her feel misunderstood. It is also true that we do not give constant reassurance to those we feel have no need of it. We don't do it to people we truly feel are beautiful or clever, although we may admire them.

Overreassurance can simply reinforce the crucial importance of the quality we are addressing. We don't insist that our sons have inner beauty, and if we don't want our daughters to judge themselves so much in this area maybe we should be a little less invested in this quality in them ourselves.

Pre-teens and teens are emerging out of total present-moment existence into the wider perspective of adults and although they may have mood swings we still need to be careful of adding our adult depth of meaning to their issues. We are all allowed to have occasional insecurities and crises in confidence, and they are not necessarily indicative of wider problems.

Mothers help their daughters far more by being a role model in how they themselves deal with these societal expectations of women, and fathers help their sons through demonstrating themselves how they manage the pressures men face.

So if your daughter comes home from school complaining that she's really fat, or she hates her hair, or she's really ugly, we could just respond with a wrinkled nose and an empathetic grunt, or acknowledge:

‘Having an off-day... ?’
‘Don’t feel good... ?’
‘Bad hair day... ?’
‘Urrgh... Having one of those days... ?’
‘Bit of a confidence dip... ?’
‘Not happy about it... ?’
‘Tch... not a nice feeling... ’

The underlying message in responses like those above is empathy and understanding – at the same time as confidence that your daughter can deal with it – but also, crucially, that not feeling confident sometimes is a fact of life and not a huge deal.

Remembering that feelings generally sound worse than they actually are – and that our child’s words may not be accurate – it’s better not to jump ahead to wider assumptions so that we don’t help to create what we are trying to avoid. Let’s look at another example of an older child who is doing his homework and who suddenly exclaims:

‘I am so stupid. I’m just rubbish at Maths.’

Our instinct is to jump in with reassurance:

‘Oh, but you’re really good at Maths. All your teachers say so. You just need to believe in yourself.’

If we can stay in the present moment and reflect what is actually going on for our child there and then, we are less likely to set in stone the lack of confidence expressed:

‘Having problems... ?’
‘Tricky one... ?’
‘Can’t work it out... ?’
‘Having difficulties... ?’
‘Up against it... ?’
‘Can’t figure it out... ?’

Remember from [Chapter Four](#) that slapping a label on your child does not work to give them confidence? We can easily forget that in the teenage years, when our child may be expressing doubts and insecurities that really worry us, but it's especially important in those years that we keep our confidence in them and express that confidence in the way we respond to their negative feelings about themselves.

And, of course, just as when they were little, it's still part of our job to sometimes gush about how gorgeous, clever and brilliant they are, because it's really important to sometimes embarrass our teenagers.

When the Typical Responses May be Helpful

Acknowledging in a neutral way a few times is enough to give a child the space to manage his feelings, and this is so often all a child needs. If, after this, it seems like your child is actually having a problem he needs help with you can ask questions at this point – or give your advice and suggestions, or your analysis of the situation, or give your reassurance – because your child is more likely to hear you, and it's irritating if someone just keeps acknowledging you. But don't forget this skill, even when you are giving your advice or your viewpoint. It's useful at any point in a conversation, as it helps you to stand back again if you are starting to feel too invested in your own solution and your child is resisting it.

There are inevitably still times when we need to jump in and rescue a child: times when we feel she really does need adult help with an issue she cannot resolve by herself, or times when a child is so overtired and out of control that we just need to sweep her up and put her to bed.

There are also times when an instant distraction is the easiest response to a child who is hurt or stuck in feelings she can't control – when we need to take charge – and there are also times when we may need to instantly reassure a child who is very frightened. We know our own children best and we need to go with our instincts in situations like this.

So the typical responses are not always baddies that we must avoid at all costs, but they can simply create further problems if we jump in with them immediately whenever our child expresses day-to-day negative feelings. Hold off until you feel they are really necessary and you will be surprised at how often they are not needed at all. And although this is not an exact science, three acknowledgements generally seem to be enough to dissipate feelings and allow the child to move on.

You Don't Have to Listen Every Time

Of course, as the parent, you know your child best. You can sense if her feelings are real or if she is putting them on in order to gain something or to get attention. (Incidentally, she won't do this so much if you don't go overboard with the concerned attention or the brisk dismissal when her feelings are real). When you feel uncomfortable or manipulated by your child's expression of feelings it is always best to be honest: faking empathy when you're feeling irritated never works.

And in fact there will be many times when you can't acknowledge your child's feelings: times when you're tired, really busy, or feel no empathy – and that's fine. Children don't need their feelings acknowledged every time. When you listen a child learns that his feelings are relevant and important. When you don't listen he learns that his feelings are not always the most important thing and that other people have needs, too. So it's all good.

Having said that, responding to your child with a simple acknowledgement will inevitably gradually become your habitual response as you experience its miraculous effects not just on your child's behaviour but on your own stress levels, as you learn to trust him to manage his own feelings and know that they are not yours to resolve.

Feelings and Behaviour

There are also times when our child expresses her feelings in a way which is unacceptable to us: it crosses our line. We need to make a distinction between feelings and behaviour:

- Feelings are the motivation for the behaviour: most behaviour is to a greater or lesser extent feelings-driven.
- Behaviour is the way in which the feelings are expressed. Behaviour, as we know, is physical action that we can actually see or hear.

When our child is expressing his feelings in a way we don't like – kicking us, shouting and screaming at us, refusing to do something, moaning and whining incessantly, for example – we need to make our boundary clear and to challenge the behaviour rather than listen to the feeling.

I was once going for an evening walk with my daughter when she was about six years old. She was asking me if she could have some roller blades and I had explained to her that they were too expensive and that I would get

her something like that for her birthday or Christmas, but not just as a treat. She went on and on about it and her whining was spoiling my walk. I felt really irritated by her behaviour so I didn't acknowledge her feelings. I said, grumpily, 'Look, I've already told you. And your moaning is ruining our walk for me. I don't like it. I want a nice walk.'

She reduced the intensity of her whining a little but not enough for me, and I walked along angrily, thinking she was a spoilt brat.

When we got home I started on dinner and then went upstairs, where I found her sitting on the landing sobbing quietly to herself. At that point I found the way she was expressing her feelings entirely acceptable. She was not bothering anyone else or trying to get attention: she was just expressing her sadness. So I sat down next to her and put my arm round her.

'You really want those roller blades...' I said.

'Yes,' she sniffed.

'They're really important to you...'

'Yes.'

She stopped crying.

'Mummy?'

'Yes, lovely?'

'Would it be OK if I got them for my birthday?'

'Yes, of course. I can get them for your birthday.'

'Thank you, Mummy.'

And we had a hug and everything was right with the world again. Her birthday wasn't for three months but she didn't complain once about not having roller blades in all that time (so no spoilt brat, then).

The point here is that it would not have worked had I tried to listen when her behaviour was irritating me. She would have sensed it and it probably would have caused more problems.

If we want our children to grow up to be able to express their feelings – but not in spoilt, selfish, harming, disrespectful or unsociable ways – then it's important that we are authentic in our responses.

- If we listen to feelings when they are expressed in ways that are acceptable to us, then we are a sounding-board.
- If we listen to feelings when they are expressed in ways that are unacceptable to us, then we are a punch-bag.

Being a sounding-board for your child is a great help to him in managing life. Being a punch-bag teaches him all the wrong things. No human being has the obligation to be a punch-bag for any other and it's best that children know that.

It can be difficult to know whether a child's behaviour is acceptable to us or not in the moment, so ask yourself the question:

- Is this behaviour interfering with my needs in any way?
- Is it causing me stress?
- Is it preventing me from doing what I want to do or inconveniencing me?

So, for example:

- You switch the TV off and your child cries.
- You switch the TV off and your child screams at you, and pulls you back as you try to leave the room.

In the first example he is expressing his feelings in a way which does not inconvenience you, but in the second he is expressing his feelings in a way that does. When our children are unhappy with us we really don't need to fix it: they are not obliged to accept every decision we make and be happy about it.

So if our child refuses to get his coat on, that's a problem for us. If he moans and complains while getting his coat on, no problem. As long as he is doing what we have asked him to do, he's allowed to feel any way he likes about it.

We've spent two chapters on children's feelings so let's now move on to their behaviour, specifically the kind that bothers us... because that's why you're really here, isn't it?

If you only take away three things from this chapter, make sure they are these:

1. A child's feelings belong to the child, not you. Manage your own feelings, not your child's.

2. Know your own trigger points. If it's an area that really worries you, you are more likely to overidentify and take it on as your own problem to solve.
3. It matters how a child is expressing feelings. Be a sounding-board but don't be a punch-bag.

CHAPTER SEVEN: PARENTAL AUTHORITY

When I was a new mother I often observed parents managing situations in a way that I could see seemed to make things worse, like the harassed mother in a campsite washroom who was trying to wash her little girl's hair as she sat on the washbasin squirming and screaming loudly as the shampoo bubbled everywhere. In exasperation (and probably embarrassment) the mother said furiously 'If you don't stop screaming we're not going to go and see the ponies.' If you had wanted your daughter to scream louder, I couldn't think of a much better way than that.

Some scenarios quite upset me, like the enraged father I saw in a shop calling his three-year-old boy over with the words 'You're going to get a hard smack if you don't do as I say.' The father's face was red with anger and the little boy was paralysed, rooted to the spot in fear, rendered completely incapable of obeying his dad.

And then there was the little boy – who lived across the road from us when my oldest two boys were small – who screamed and threw tantrums whenever he was required to do anything he didn't want to. The mother would respond to his demands by gently and patiently saying things like 'You're feeling really angry... ?' She would placate him by trying to negotiate an option which would please him, and the more she tried the worse his behaviour became. We once spent what felt like hours trying to get through a gate into a playground when he kicked off about not going through first. My boys and I meekly trooped out again to allow him through, but that wasn't enough to pacify him. This little boy's behaviour was so out of control that even my boys weren't keen for him to come over to play, and children will usually put up with anything.

I didn't want to be one of those threatening, punishing parents. Sometimes I would see horrible situations like the little boy in the shop and I would feel really sorry for the child, and at other times I could see that it just didn't work. I wanted to be nice and lovely all the time but the problem was that I could also see that the nice parenting techniques didn't work, either.

I muddled through for years before, bit by bit, I found a role of Parental Authority with my children which felt about right. All my children had to push me into it: they all made it obvious what they wanted from me. I remember when my first son started to ask me 'Am I allowed to do this?' and taught me, to my amazement, that I had the power to allow and disallow things. I think he learned that from other children. I will be forever grateful to his nursery school who taught him to say 'Please may I get down from the table?' after a meal – a habit which he introduced into the family, where it remained throughout all my kids' childhoods. That saved me a job. Most of the time I got away with being a little bit incompetent, until it came to my daughter, who absolutely demanded that I stepped up into my true authority. She would accept nothing less

Different Types of Authority

We all have different understandings of the word authority, which come from the way we experienced it as children ourselves from our parents and teachers and throughout our adult lives in our jobs and daily lives. For some it's a negative word and for others it's a positive necessity. There are different types of authority, so let's define them so that we have more understanding about what kind of authority works and what doesn't.

The first kind may be what some of us automatically think of when the word authority is mentioned in relation to the parents' role. It's an authoritarian approach to discipline which may conjure up an image of bossy, controlling, autocratic behaviour: a dictatorship. It may be experienced as inflexible, strict, uncompromising, possibly even arrogant and cruel. It is characterised by anger, shouting, shaming, humiliating and threatening, and is based on a punishment and reward system – star charts and the naughty step for example. This is Camp A Authority.

This was the generally-accepted method of discipline in my parents' generation. What happened next was an information explosion, from the sixties onwards, which led us to question the previous wisdom. We began to

understand a lot more about children and their developmental needs, and that spread of information informed the gradual change in parenting practices up to the present day.

Parents gradually became afraid of using Camp A Authority for fear of damaging their children and repressing their individuality and natural development, but this has left many parents with a lack of confidence about how to use or exert their authority over their children. Replacing it with a weak or hesitant authority is confusing for a child, who expects you to be the grown-up in the relationship. A lack of confidence – or a belief that the child needs to be consulted on everything in order to learn how to think – can result in unclear, unsure, apologetic and timid parenting, which is characterised by pleading, placating, requesting and negotiating everything. This approach is typical of Camp B Authority.

We live in a culture where this kind of authority is presented as a positive model in some parenting advice: it was born from the premise that children are our equals and need to be involved in decision-making and rule-setting in order to develop their intelligence, individuality, questioning and thinking skills. In reality children have so much opportunity to develop these skills, just through normal life, that adding a shared responsibility in parenting duties amounts to an overload that many children just can't cope with.

The Authoritarian Model

The problem with Camp A Authority is that it can so easily create rebellion and defiance as the child resists control and – even in the case of those children who submit – their obedience does not stem from an internal willingness to behave well, but a fear of external consequences. The punishment and reward model also takes an awful lot of policing, which is exhausting, and a child may not feel very close to the parent who is always in parent role.

Consistency

A punishment and reward system depends on consistency. In order for this approach to work we have to punish the unacceptable behaviour every time it happens – and reward the pleasing behaviour every single time, too. That is impossible for human beings: for one, we are not always there when the behaviour happens but – more importantly – we cannot respond

authentically to the same behaviour in the same way every time because there are certain factors which influence our tolerance levels:

- It depends on how we feel ourselves. I may be fine about my children running round making lots of noise at ten o'clock in the morning, but probably not at 7pm when I'm exhausted. If I have had a good night's sleep I will feel far more tolerant than when I haven't – and if I had just won the lottery I wouldn't mind anything. So how we respond to behaviour changes, depending on what's happening for us.
- It also depends on where it's happening. I am less tolerant of certain behaviour when I'm in the supermarket, or with friends or grandparents – in fact, anywhere in public where my parenting skills are being observed. I have lower tolerance of unsociable table manners when we're out in a cafe or pub. I'm fine with my kids kicking a muddy football around in the park but I wouldn't be too happy if they did it in the living room.
- And it also depends on the child. I would accept certain behaviour from my three-year-old which I wouldn't accept from my nine-year-old. I feel less and less accepting the more times a child does the same thing. I feel more accepting when it's a child who is normally fairly easy, and less accepting if it's a child who is continually challenging.

It would be impossible for me to respond the same way every time unless I was a robot who had been programmed to do so, which I am not.

A punishment and reward system is invariably advocated in the name of consistency – but as this is humanly impossible we must find another way of being consistent, which brings us back to honesty. If we respond authentically to our child's behaviour he learns to trust us. He knows where he stands: he knows we'll be straight with him. Children are quite capable of accepting that at times we are more tolerant than at others, as long as we are honest and direct in how we communicate it to them.

Sharing Our Feelings With Our Children

We don't want to be self-indulgent and moan about every time we feel a bit tired. It's still our responsibility to manage our own feelings but we could let our children know more about what's going on for us, as withholding this information puts them at a disadvantage in terms of knowing how to

behave. Owning our feelings and sharing this information with our children is very different to dumping our feelings on them. In fact, if we are not straight with our children we are more likely to eventually blow up and take out our feelings on them.

When my three boys were small I was preparing tea for them one evening, before going out to run a course. My boys were all bathed, pink and glowing, and the last thing I wanted to do was to leave the house and go out into the dark, cold, rainy night. I was also nervous, as I always was before the start of a course. So as I was getting their food I said:

‘Oooh, I really don’t want to go out tonight.’

‘Do you have to go, Mummy?’

‘Yes, I do. But I feel nervous because it’s the start of a course.’

‘Don’t worry, Mummy. I bet everyone will be lovely.’

‘Yes, I know. They always are, but I always feel nervous beforehand in case they’re not.’

The conversation went on and my children were helpful and supportive, and ate their tea like little angels. I realised later that had I not told them about my true feelings I probably would have been banging plates around, yelling at them and taking it out on them. Given the relevant information by me, though, they just knew how to behave.

I learned something more the next morning. When I got up my second son, who was about five at the time, called me:

‘Mummy... Mummy.’

I went into his bedroom. ‘What’s up?’

‘Did you have a good course last night, Mummy? Was it all OK? Were they nice?’

By sharing my real feelings with him the night before I had given him the chance to think and care about me, and I was amazed that he cared so much that it was his first thought when he woke up. We need to give children more opportunities to show how much they care about us. Otherwise, how will we ever know?

I include that story here, in a chapter on Parental Authority, to demonstrate that a true authority can admit to human vulnerabilities – and also because I think that it’s a good example of how our honesty and authenticity can be preventive of the behaviour we don’t want.

Punishment

I have already outlined the dangers of rewards and praise in [Chapter Four](#), but let's take a closer look here at punishment as a means of discipline. The effect of punishment is shame – and obviously some forms of punishment are more shaming than others – but shaming a child as a means of discipline is not very effective, as shame paralyses. If you think about a time you felt shamed, you can probably conjure up that overwhelming hot embarrassment and humiliation fairly easily. We remember those times as unbearable, and this is especially true for children who don't have the means to manage and reframe those feelings as we do.

Shame is really a state of being rather than an emotion, and we will do anything to avoid it. Feeling ashamed is very different to being shamed. Feeling ashamed of our actions produces regret and this motivates us to make amends and try to remember to get it right next time (not that we are always successful). When we shame a child we overrule the feeling of being ashamed and give it no space to be experienced.

When we label a child and angrily send her off to the naughty step, ordering her to think about what she's done, we don't realise that we are creating a situation where this is the last thing she is able to do in her overwhelming state of shame.

Think about a time when your child has just hit her little brother, who bursts into tears. If you stop and notice the immediate expression on your little girl's face it is very often an instant reaction of shock and regret, which we then turn into anger towards us when we shout at her. We give her something to react against rather than experience the regret, which gets buried. It is this instinctive regret which is the true motivation for her to not want to do it again, because it's an uncomfortable feeling which she does not want to repeat. (She will repeat it, of course. She doesn't learn this from only one experience).

The same is true of other naughty behaviours which our child naturally regrets because, innately, he wants to please us. In punishing him we communicate mistrust in his desire to be reasonable and get it right, and we also set up a bargaining, combative, tit for tat dynamic with our child. If this becomes our normal pattern of relating then we really have to watch out for the teenage years, when he will start winning the fights (if he hasn't already). Children tend to be far more tenacious than us when it comes to trying to win a battle. They have so much more energy.

So with a punishment system we not only create resistance and anger at the time but we also make it almost impossible for a child to be willing to behave well in the future just because it feels good and because he genuinely does want to consider our needs, too.

Punishment, or the threat of punishment, doesn't make a child want to obey and – although we may all resort to it sometimes – as a system it is likely to make life a lot more difficult for the parent because it replaces a child's natural willingness to behave with a resentful, grudging obedience.

Often we confront a child's unacceptable behaviour in a way which will inevitably escalate things and set us off down a path that leads to punishment. So if we don't want that we need to start off with communication which takes us down a completely different path.

Weak Authority

The danger of having nothing with which to replace Camp A Authority is in ending up with a weak authority or no authority at all. If there is a vacuum in authority it will invariably be filled by your child – and inevitably in a Camp A way.

Camp B Authority consults with children, negotiates rules and gives children lots of choice – but too much choice is stressful, even for adults. A child may play up and rebel, not against authority but against a lack of it. A child may get frustrated and scream at you because he just wants you to tell him what to do and make it easier for him, although he will not be able to understand or articulate the reasons for his frustration himself.

When parents are hesitant in establishing authority a child doesn't know where she stands, and she is likely to spend an awful lot of time trying to find out. Her behaviour gets worse and worse as she pushes to find the boundary that will make her feel safe and secure. She feels confused, insecure and angry with the parent as she is forced to shoulder too much responsibility in decision-making (of which she is not yet capable).

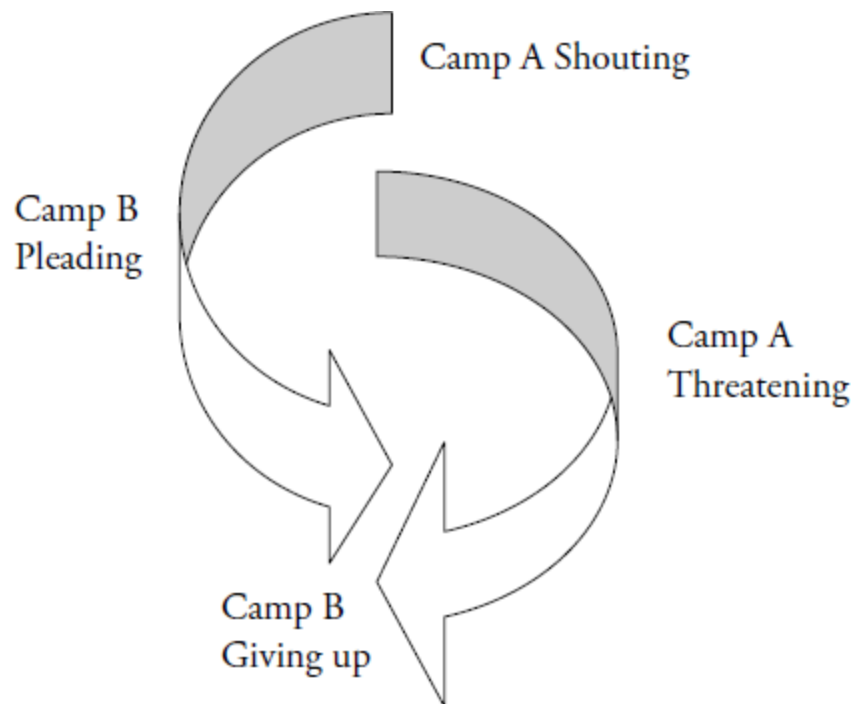
If this pattern of relating is continued into the teen years a child's lack of respect for the parent will become very clear, as she continues to expect the parent to try to please her above all others.

Camp A and Camp B are the two extremes that parents typically swing between in daily life with children. We may start with a strict policy and give orders or threats, and when that doesn't work we give up and appeal to their better natures with negotiations, requests, pleading or flattery. Or we

do it the other way round and start off with nice, polite requests and when that fails we lose patience and blow up.

Swinging from one approach to the other can lead to a downward spiral in the relationship as the child gets confused about where she stands and the parent swings between feeling either powerless or guilty about being too hard:

Fig. I. Swinging between Camp A and Camp B Authority



Neither of these methods is a true authority in the sense that both are based on an underlying fear and mistrust.

- Camp A is afraid of losing the power and control, and expresses no trust that the child will obey without the threat of unpleasant consequences.
- Camp B is afraid of authority and expresses a lack of trust in the child's desire to behave well without being consulted and asked really nicely.

These two models, in essence, are a demonstration of either a bully or a victim persona. Bullies make us want to run away, resist, or get our own back in subtle ways – we are locked in a fight dynamic. A victim persona, on the other hand, can bring out the aggressive in us: we feel irritated by the

indirect transference of power and responsibility for the victim's feelings. When we are being overly nice and polite, the implicit message comes across as 'Please be nice to me' which feels needy and weak (and makes the other person want to punch us).

Neither type of authority is very effective but they are not the only options: what we need is a different model altogether.

Legitimate Parental Authority

Luckily there is another definition of authority, which comes from an earned position or occupation. If you think of any job you have done where you are in a position to give orders, it's that. It's your job authority which, in the case of parents, simply describes a legitimate Parental Authority. Parental Authority comes with the job. It's a given – there's no one else qualified to do it who occupies your position as parent.

Parental Authority is characterised by an unapologetic confidence, clarity and trust. It is honest, respectful, direct and authoritative. It doesn't need to manipulate with threats or pleading. It is sure of itself without being overbearing, and it can be flexible and humorous. It is clear about its legitimate right to be expressed and takes the corresponding responsibility not to misuse that right. The underlying message of Parental Authority is trust:

- 'I trust you to get this right.'
- 'I expect you to do this because I've told you to.'
- 'I assume you will obey this instruction.'

The pilot of an aeroplane speaks in this way to the co-pilot when giving instructions and orders: there is a mutual acceptance that the position of pilot has earned her the right to do so. So the pilot says matter-of-factly 'Engine on' (or whatever it is they say) and the co-pilot automatically carries out the instruction. The pilot would never use Authority A and shout angrily, 'Now switch that engine on now. If you don't switch it on this minute you'll lose your job.' Neither does the pilot use Authority B and hesitantly suggest, 'Erm... could you switch the engine on now, please, if you don't mind...?' That would be ridiculous.

The pilot has an absolute assumption that the co-pilot will carry out her order: the co-pilot has absolute expectance that the pilot will give it. A child

has the same assumption that the parent will unapologetically exert his legitimate authority and clearly give the orders – but if parents don't trust in that they will threaten or plead instead, and that's as confusing for the child as it would be for the co-pilot.

Authority in Your Expertise

Parental Authority also includes the authority which comes from knowledge, experience or expertise in an area. We might say 'She's an authority on Ancient Rome' for example, or 'He speaks with great authority.' Parents automatically possess this type of authority just by the nature of the fact that they are far more experienced and know a lot more than their children.

True authority is comforting: when we are unsure about something we feel relieved and reassured when someone speaks about it as if they know what they are talking about.

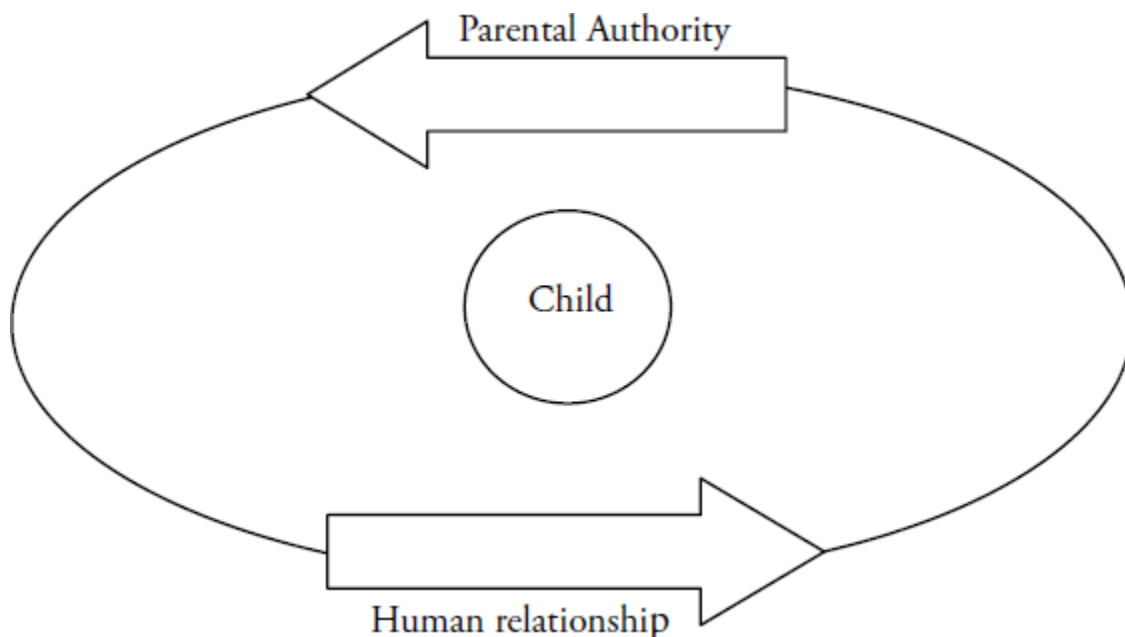
Speaking with authority inspires confidence in others and negates the need for threatening or cajoling children to do something – cleaning their teeth, for example. If you think of all the other areas where you have more experience and expertise than your children: health, safety, the importance of eating vegetables, life – and you use your Expertise Authority tone of voice on these matters – you are far more likely to be listened to. Expertise Authority is confident, fairly matter-of-fact in its knowledge, expects to be heard and doesn't need to persuade or convince. It just states the facts. The underlying message, again, is trust.

I have expertise in the area of communication skills, so I am writing this book in a state of cheerful expectation that you will be paying attention. I would not try to lecture you or persuade you to believe me by threatening you. I will not write 'Now this is really important stuff and you really should pay attention, otherwise it's your own time you're wasting.' I don't think you would read much further if I did that. I also wouldn't write 'Please could you read the next bit carefully, if you wouldn't mind. I think you'll find it really helpful.' I think you might lose trust in the validity of what you are reading if I wrote that. Because I am confident in my knowledge I don't need to be arrogant: I can be honest and admit my mistakes, laugh at myself and accept disagreement or challenge. I assume your intelligence and I feel no need to justify my right to write this book. I think that's what you'd expect of me.

Children expect the same from us. The problem is that it doesn't look like it a lot of the time so it's easy to forget, which is why we can't always be in this kind of confident authority. It's only human to do a bit of the others sometimes. We get tired, stressed and overburdened ourselves and we are not machines. But if we understand the principles and know some simple skills we can learn to put ourselves there more often when we need to be, even when we don't feel like it.

If we can replace the Camp A and Camp B methods with a confidence in our legitimate Parental Authority, together with an awareness of the human relationship we have with our child, these two factors work together to both enhance the relationship and improve behaviour.

Fig. II. Parental Authority and the human relationship



Our Parental Authority builds the structure which holds a child safe and secure and within which she can grow, learn, explore and discover the world and herself. If you can get yourself into Parental Authority in the structure areas – the day-to-day routines, the rules, the non-negotiables and your personal boundaries – life just runs more smoothly. Daily routines become painless for everyone and run on automatic.

There's another good reason to make the rules clear, which is that a child who has respect for the rules and knows the basics of being polite is

generally well-liked by others – and you don't want to be sending a child out into the world who won't be welcomed round to play by other parents. And if that wasn't enough, a child who is fairly cooperative and willing to follow the family's rules is so much easier and nicer to live with. They are happier and you as a parent get to enjoy it more.

As a living example of somebody with an easy confident authority who doesn't need to bully or wheedle to get what they want you are also a brilliant role model for your child, and it makes life so much less stressful for you. To get that genuine confidence it's helpful to know what children are really doing when they challenge your authority.

Your Child's Social Brain

Children are born social creatures. At birth their brains are undeveloped but prepared for learning social rules. As they grow it is the specific social rules of their own culture that they absorb and achieve specialisation in, and the rules of a completely different culture begin to seem odd or unnatural. As a child's first experience of the social group, the parents and family have a big influence in the initial socialisation of a child. If we accept that our child is born expecting this, it is easy to see why a child would be confused when faced with a parent who was either unwilling to provide it, or felt the need to impose it using fear. Neither of the approaches above allows a child to demonstrate his innate willingness to accept and cooperate with a legitimate authority.

Following the rules of the daily routines of family life builds the child's social brain, giving her an internal structure she can use throughout her life – so when you are clear and direct you are working with your child's developing brain and not against it.

Your Child's Scientist Brain

In a sense it's easy. All parents have to do is live the family rules themselves and, by osmosis and a bit of help from mirror neurons, your child will simply imitate you until it becomes automatic for them. We all know it's not as simple as that, though. Your child is also busily doing another job, which is being a scientist and checking the evidence – experimenting, testing it and seeing if it holds tight. That bit can be challenging.

Have you ever noticed how children will perform some behaviour – let's say crying and screaming at you – and then stop and look at you curiously? That's true research in action. 'What will happen if I cry and scream at Daddy? How will he react? What impact will my behaviour have on the world?' The result will be stored away for future reference, and statistics will be built from it.

Children are little scientists with amazing brains that are constantly observing, computing, collating information and forming theories. Children are brilliant at the theory but not so good at putting it into practice. They want to get it right but they get it wrong again and again. Children are better scientists than adults because that part of the brain is in full operation in early childhood, but we lose that cognitive ability to a great extent as we grow up. In balance we start behaving better, so it's swings and roundabouts.

Every good scientist knows that you don't get an accurate result from one small study and that you need to do lots of studies and finally carry out a meta-study of all available data before you can reach a firm conclusion. That's why children will push you again and again on the same issue. So every time you say to your child 'Time for bed now' your child's scientist brain goes into action – sometimes you can practically see the cogs turning – and the process looks something like this:

'Hmm... Let's see... When Mummy says 'Time for bed'... ' (reaches into database)... 'Hmm, let's look at the stats... OK. Looks like it's 25% of the time she's serious. That makes 75% of the time she doesn't really mean it.. OK. Pretty good odds. I'll go for it.'

'No. I don't wanna go to bed.'

It shows why it's important to know where your non-negotiables are and stick to them. When the odds drop your child is not stupid. He will go with the evidence, whereas if we continually negotiate these areas it will take him a much longer period of collating the conflicting evidence to reach a firm conclusion.

It can be a challenge for parents, though, especially if you have a really thorough scientist who believes in exhaustive research.

Confidence in Your Authority

It is having confidence in your own authority which makes such a difference in this area. If your child resists, rebels or plays up frequently, it

may not be that she has a problem with authority but that the way it is expressed is either too overbearing and inflexible or too hesitant and weak. So she is either in a fight with you to trust her a bit more, or pushing you to exert a bit of authority she can respect. We need to be confident in our Parental Authority so that we can simply help the scientist to do her job rather than obstruct her.

The first step is to trust that this is what your child needs, wants and expects from you (even when it doesn't look like it) and to have confidence in your own legitimate right to be in this position as a parent, and I hope that the information in this chapter will help you to gain that genuine trust in both yourself and your child.

When we first become parents it can be difficult to manufacture confidence as we haven't experienced anything like this before, but as adults we know of ways to build our confidence in other areas of inexperience and we can use our body language to fool our brains that we are confident in our Parental Authority (as outlined in [Chapter Three](#)).

Why is the message of trust so important? Because a message – even implicit – of mistrust sets you up for a fight and starts you off on that path towards threats and punishment and everything going horribly wrong. That's because we all feel resentment – however subtly – when we are mistrusted, but particularly when the mistrust is unwarranted. Then we also feel frustrated, irritated, indignant and annoyed.

An expression of trust, on the other hand, sets you on a completely different path – one of willing cooperation and goodwill. A message of trust makes it much more difficult for your child to disobey you simply because it's not a nice feeling to betray someone's trust in you, and your child will want to avoid that unpleasant feeling.

The Body Language of Authority

So before we look at words, let's go back to those other three areas – tone of voice, facial expression and body language – and see how we need to act to fool both our own brains and our child's that we are confident in our authority and that we trust them absolutely. There is of course a range of expression in all areas, from softer and gentler at one end to stricter and harder at the other, and we can dip into this range depending on the situation.

Our tone of voice needs to convey an absolute assumption and expectation that the child will listen and do as we say. There is a range from calm, clear, even, level, neutral, trusting through matter-of-fact, goes-without-saying, businesslike, brisk, authoritative, to stern, annoyed, sharp. If necessary we can raise our voice to be heard, but if we descend into hysterical shouting we have lost it.

Our words may be perfect but if we express them in a hesitant, questioning, pleading or apologetic tone then that tone becomes the stronger message received by the child. A warning, threatening tone or one heavy with disapproval or suspicion also comes across very clearly.

We all naturally use a sing-song voice with babies, but this can sound patronising and infantilising if we use it to give orders or instructions as children get older, as can a sugary overly-nice polite voice. This doesn't mean to say that we should never sound bright, friendly, warm, humorous or even light-hearted and casual in our authority, but this sounds very different when it comes from a place of confidence in ourselves rather than a manipulative technique born out of a lack of belief in our authority.

A parent once said to me 'Yes, but that all sounds a bit... robotic.' My reply was that children like robots. And, assuming that you are not robotic with your children at all times, it also makes the distinction clear between normal, muddled, easy-going life, and 'These are the rules which you have to obey' times – and that makes it easier for your child to understand. He will think 'Daddy means it now,' as soon as he hears your matter-of-fact order-giving voice.

A trusting facial expression ranges from smiley, happy, friendly, neutral, serious, open and direct through to raised eyebrows, furrowed brows, a strict expression or a stern look of admonishment. It is worth perfecting your look – the one that says unequivocally 'Enough' – because it is very useful, especially in public (when it can be fairly secret, and it helps your child save face in situations where they would feel humiliated to be told off like a baby).

I have a wide-eyed, raised eyebrows, outraged, indignant look, which communicates very clearly to my children 'I can't quite believe you just did that' far more effectively than words.

Your words may be very clear but they will be betrayed if they are accompanied by pleading eyes, a look of desperation or helplessness, an apologetic or questioning expression or searching looks. At the other

extreme thunderous heavy brows, angry eyes and a tight-lipped expression communicate repressed rage.

Finally, body language should be relaxed, centred, open and breathing, with calm hand gestures and a nodding head.

Gesticulating wildly, towering over your child with hands on hips, slumping, a drooping head and shoulders or shaking your head in disbelief or disappointment all communicate a lack of trust.

Using Your Body Language Consciously

When there is a lot of energy in the room (which could mean physical or emotional) and we storm about gesticulating and pointing we are only adding to it and stirring it up further. We often do this when we feel angry with two siblings fighting, but the best way to help your children calm down is to make your own body language calm and slow and let those mirror neurons do their work. Difficult, I know. But next time your kids are screaming and shouting at each other just try entering the room slowly and stand in front of them. Raise your arms out in front of you, palms down, and bring them downwards slowly. Feel that wild energy drain away. If it doesn't work on them, it certainly helps you.

The biggest challenge comes in stressful situations when you're in a rush, like getting out of the house in the morning. I discovered one day, when I was a bit ill, that my lowered energy – together with the fact that I couldn't really be bothered about anything other than moving as slowly as possible – seemed to work wonders in making my children calm. We really don't consciously use body language nearly enough in our communication with our children. We focus almost exclusively on our words when in fact our bodies can send out the most powerful of messages.

When it comes to our Parental Authority we need to fake it to make it: I used to think that I needed to be confident in my authority before I would be able to act confidently, but I learned that in fact it works the other way round. The more I acted confident, the more confident I felt. It's much easier that way round, and quite good fun to use your body to trick your brain.

It may at times be helpful to make eye contact or get down to the same level as your child, but it is not always necessary to make such a big job of it. If you think about the power of modelling, it is always wise to move in the direction you want your child to go or to do the same thing you want

your child to do. So even if you do get down to their level to talk to them initially, your body language sends the clearest message of trust when you then stand up, disengage, and move away – towards the front door, for example, if you are going out.

Children's Feelings and Parental Authority

To end this chapter let's put together the two areas we have been looking at so far in this book: responding to our children's feelings and being in our Parental Authority, because sometimes they bump up against each other in alarming or confusing ways. I'll illustrate this with another common scenario for parents: the child crying at the school gates.

When my first little boy attended nursery school I stayed with him there for a very long time, probably to the huge annoyance of the teachers, because he cried and didn't want to let me go. My middle two boys went in happily but when my fourth child, my daughter, was even more distressed than my first son when I took her in to nursery I left her there. OK, I stood on tiptoes outside the classroom peering in through the very high window, just to make sure she was OK before I left the premises, but I knew to let her go. What had changed over the years, apart from my exhaustion and tolerance levels?

I had noticed that the children with parents who displayed the most anxiety about them when they didn't want to go into school seemed to stay stuck in that pattern, whereas those with parents who displayed the most confidence in them developed a confidence in themselves fairly quickly. I had also learned two important things:

- Parental Authority.

With my first son I wasn't sure whether I had the right to make him do something he didn't want to do, so I was unclear and unconfident of my authority. By the time my daughter came along I had reframed the whole getting-your-child-into-school scenario as a part of my Parental Authority and responsibility, so I was clear that this was my job and that it was non-negotiable.

- Responding to Feelings.

I had allowed my first son's fear and anxiety to transfer to me so that now we were both scared, and we did a good job of reinforcing that fear in

each other. With my daughter I had learned not to do that so I was able to separate myself from her feelings and leave them with her, without adding my own. I had learned to simply acknowledge, and I also knew about the power of mirror neurons and that my confidence would transfer to her.

I understood that the underlying message we send when we stay with our child, listening with concern and anxiety on our faces as they cry is: 'You're right. School really is too difficult and scary for you today' a message which communicates clearly 'I don't trust that you are able to manage these feelings. I don't trust that you're going to be OK.'

When we are able to acknowledge our child without losing the confidence in our authority to take her in and leave her at school we communicate a very different message: 'I trust that you're capable of managing those feelings, and I'm confident you can do it.'

It wasn't long before my daughter had taken over her nursery class, established herself as the boss, and was practically running it – to the consternation of the teachers, who would have liked more of a say in the matter.

Whether it's getting our child into school, leaving her with a childminder or sending her off to school camp for the first time, the more anxiety and concern we express as parents the more insecure our child will feel, because she believes us. The less fuss we make, the less fuss our child makes.

My daughter – now older - tells a story of the family she babysits for. The mother is going out for the evening and her two-year-old boy screams and cries as she is leaving the house, sounding for all the world as if he is in great distress. The mother is firm, calm and matter-of-fact. She says goodbye and closes the front door. Her little boy turns to my daughter, giggles in delight and then runs off joyfully to find some toys to play with.

Children's feelings are intense but transient. If we allow them to derail our Parental Authority we teach our children to hang on to those feelings for longer and we create the very anxiety in them which we are trying to assuage by giving them our focused attention.

We do not have to go to the Camp A extreme of threatening, ridiculing or dismissing our child's fears, but nor should we go to the Camp B extreme of indulging them. The longer we spend listening, reassuring and comforting our child at those times, the more difficult we make it for our

child to manage their fears and the longer it takes them to develop the courage to face difficult situations in life.

If our child is expressing anger and rage – screaming, shouting at us, kicking us – and we capitulate, then we are being a punch-bag rather than a parent. Our child will get angrier and angrier with us until we step up into our Parental Authority, take control and make things easier for them.

Of course, as parents, we feel worried about our child sometimes – but if we recognise that our confidence in our Parental Authority sends out such a clear message of confidence in our child then that is a strong motivation to perfect the art of acting ‘as if’ and using our bodies consciously to help us.

Feeling confident yet? OK. Shoulders back, head up. Tap into your inner Mary Poppins, and in the next chapter we’ll look at the most effective words to go with this body language so that the message is clear and unequivocal.

If you only take away three things from this chapter, make sure they are these:

1. Be consistent in your honesty and integrity so that your children know where they stand with you.
2. Perfect your matter-of-fact, goes-without-saying tone of voice and facial expression.
3. Your child wants, needs and expects you to have Parental Authority. If you don’t feel confident in it, cheerfully act as if and get your body to do the work for you.

CHAPTER EIGHT: THE LANGUAGE OF PARENTAL AUTHORITY

Bedtimes were constantly a battle with my daughter.

‘Come along, darling,’ I would say, sweetly and politely. ‘Up to bed now, please.’

She would blow up.

‘Why do I have to? The boys don’t have to go to bed yet. It’s not fair.’

‘Come on, darling, please. It’s your bedtime. Could you go and get your pyjamas on now, please...’

‘No. I’m not going to bed. It’s not fair.’

‘Get to bed now. I’ve asked you nicely. Now just go.’

‘You’re horrid.’

It actually went on a lot longer than this.

Creating a clear structure for our children requires us to confidently be in our Parental Authority, and I clearly wasn’t.

Daily Routines

The rules and routines of daily life are the parent’s business to set: this is the area where the parent gives the orders and the child obeys, so it is important that we understand how to give those orders in a way that makes it easy for your child to obey, rather than making it more difficult. That just makes life easier and less stressful for everyone.

Let’s take the Camp A and Camp B models first, look at the language they typically use to communicate instructions, directions and orders and see why they may not work very well. Remember that a large part of the message is communicated through body language so when you read these

examples imagine an angry, threatening, warning or disapproving tone for Camp A, and a pleading, hesitant, questioning or nice voice for Camp B.

- Camp A language is typically based around some form of threat:
‘If you don’t get your coat on now we’ll be late for school and then you’ll get into trouble.’
‘Get your coat on now or you’ll get a smack.’
‘If you don’t get your coat on now Mummy’s going to be very cross.’
‘Look, we’ll be late if you don’t get your coat on now.’
The threat may just be implied in an ‘or else...’ or ‘I’m warning you’ tone of voice:
‘Now. Get your coat on now. How many times do I have to tell you?’

- Camp B’s approach is typically to phrase an order as a request or to sugar the pill by being really nice and polite or by using flattery:
‘Come on, darling. Get your coat on now, please. There’s a good girl.’
‘Can you get your coat on now please, sweetheart...?’
‘Please, darling. Get your coat on for Mummy now.’
‘I need you to get your coat on now, please, sweetie.’
‘Come on, darling. Please could you get your coat on now?’

Note how important tone of voice is in these examples. We may get away with saying ‘Coat on now, or we’ll be late’ if we say it in a matter-of-fact sharing information way, and ‘Come on, darling. Coat on now, please’ can work if we say it with brisk authority.

But if the message is sent in either a threatening or pleading way, neither of these approaches make it easy for our child to obey. In fact they make it more difficult.

- A threat will invariably be resisted: we have batted the ball over the net and our child’s instinctive reaction is to bat it back (if not outwardly then in his mind).
- Pleading sets up an emotional obligation for the child to not only obey us, but to be nice and polite back. The child resists being manipulated, and it can make a parent even angrier with a child who disobeys after we have asked nicely.

Both methods give your child something else to think about, other than getting his coat on: ‘Does she mean that threat?’ ‘Do I allow myself to be threatened?’ ‘Can I get my own back?’ Or ‘What does she want from me?’ ‘Why is he being so nice?’ ‘Do I have a choice about this?’

Both methods create feelings in the child. Threats are quite simple: they generally provoke angry, combative and resentful feelings. Pleading is more complicated: a child may sense that he is being manipulated, that something is being subtly demanded of him which he doesn’t understand and – as pleading comes across as needy and victim-like – he may also experience confused feelings of aggression towards us. There’s nothing like a victim to bring out the bully in us. He knows he is not being given a real choice but is expected to respond as if he is.

Both approaches send the underlying message ‘I don’t trust you to do this just because I’ve told you to and you’re a reasonable person’ and it is the underlying message that your child picks up most clearly. So both approaches set us off on the fight path and to start off on a different path (the path of willing cooperation) we need to say something which communicates the underlying message ‘I trust you to do this because I’ve told you to and I know you are a reasonable person.’

Giving Clear Instructions

Remember in [Chapter Three](#) how important it is to use simple clear words when it is really important that your message gets across? This is the time. You want your message to be unambiguous and easy to understand to give your child the best chance of getting it.

From the examples above, let’s take one threatening and one pleading message, and see how they both obscure the real message using superfluous and misleading words to cover it up. If we cross out the unnecessary words within which the instruction is buried, this is what we have left:

~~‘If you don’t get your coat on now we’re going to be late’~~

~~‘Come on darling, please, get your coat on now there’s a good girl’~~

‘Coat on now’ or ‘Get your coat on now’ is all the information your child needs to hear in order to know what to do. You may feel more comfortable using the word ‘please’ but you don’t have to because it’s an order not a request, and if you do say ‘please’ it should be in a brisk or matter-of-fact tone of voice to make that clear.

There are plenty of other opportunities to use the word please with your child if you want to model politeness and manners, but omitting it in framework areas clarifies for a child that this is a non-negotiable area and makes the message – and your authority – clearer.

Incidentally, if your child questions this – ‘Daddy, you didn’t say please...’ all you need do is cheerily give him some honest information:

‘That’s because I’m the parent, and parents don’t have to when it’s an order and there’s no choice.’

If you want to send a clear instruction, send a clear instruction. All else is diverting, misleading and confusing for the child as it takes your communication off into a whole different area, giving your child extra information to compute (‘Does she mean it?’ ‘Shall I do it or not?’ ‘Is he serious about this?’)

‘Thank you’ on the other hand, are great words to use. Thank you implies an assumption that the child is already doing it. You are communicating absolute expectation and trust in his obedience. Words can be very powerful. Saying ‘Thank you’ gives both you and the child more confidence that he will obey.

‘Coat on now. Thank you’.

‘Thank you’ also finishes the conversation. It says ‘That’s over; moving on...’ and in order to send the same message with our body language we then need to disengage, move away and get on with what we need to do to get ready. If we send our instruction and stay with the child or maintain eye contact we are sending the message ‘I expect you’d like to discuss this further’ or ‘I’m expecting you to argue’ or ‘I don’t trust you to do this unless I watch you.’ Body language sends the clearest of messages, and in disengaging and moving away we are saying ‘I don’t even have to watch you. I know you will be doing what I asked you to do. I trust you to get on with your business while I get on with mine.’

Remembering the power of mirror neurons, this is the time to be getting our own coat on and moving towards the door.

‘Coat on now. Thank you’. And disengage.

The Difference Between Obedience and Submission

We want our child to obey our orders, but we don’t want them to be submissive, do we? A child may jump to do as we say out of fear, and it doesn’t feel good. This is submission. When a child obeys, on the other

hand, he grows up a bit and feels good about himself. He sees himself as capable and able to follow the rules. When a child obeys he does so consciously. He takes part in the transaction; he makes the decision to obey. Understanding and obeying rules is one way a child builds self-esteem.

Incidentally, I've noticed that even as an adult I don't jump immediately to obey an order or a request. Waiting even just half a minute keeps my pride intact, almost as if I am saying 'I'm willing to do it, but I'm not your puppet.'

So to respect and allow a child's part in the transaction we should be aware that he may need time. Remember the magic three rule. It applies here. If we give our instruction, disengage and get on with our own business, we still (of course) have eyes in the back of our heads and we can see whether our child has moved or not. If not, this is the time to hold on to that attitude of trust and authority. Remember that your child is a scientist and will sometimes need to check a couple of times to see if you are serious. Resorting to threatening or pleading at this stage – just at the point when your child is gearing up to obey you – blows the whole thing.

Give her a chance – and be prepared to send the instruction again twice, at intervals, maybe with slightly different wording and perhaps with a little surprise in your voice that she has not yet obeyed. The whole transaction may look like this:

'Lucy, coat on now. Thank you.' And disengage.

'Lucy, coat.' And disengage.

'Now, Lucy. Coat on. Off we go.' And disengage.

There is no emotion in this approach, as there is in both pleading and threatening – and in case that sounds cold... it isn't, really. You can still be warm. Just remember that your child will be much happier with this than either of those other two alternatives. Those feelings confuse her.

Responding to Resistance

Remember that feelings are contagious? Well, this is the time to pass your feelings to your child, not the other way round. If she cries or moans about getting her coat on those feelings belong to her, not you, and there is no reason to engage with them. You can leave them with her. Continue to be clear, authoritative and self-controlled and your matter-of-factness will pass to her. Stick with your agenda – getting coats on – and don't let her emotions divert you into her drama.

Ignoring her feelings may seem harsh but if you respond to them you validate them as a reasonable and acceptable response to your instruction, and your little scientist adds to her positive statistical odds in the ‘If I cry and scream does it make Mummy listen to me and forget what she’s told me to do?’ study. Holding out and showing her you are serious about this issue – and will not be distracted from it – helps her to learn this lesson much quicker, saving both of you many more painful times of wrangling and negotiating. Every scientist likes a quick and unequivocal result.

When we’re in the area of the necessary routines of daily life it is so much easier when it becomes fairly automatic for everyone. It frees up our energy for everything else.

The clear simple language illustrated above is best for any situation where you are giving the orders and your child has no choice: it is direct, honest and an expression of legitimate authority which children expect from you and therefore generally accept. Threatening or pleading just doesn’t give them the chance to accept your authority, as they are busy responding to something else entirely.

Words can be very powerful and just as the body language of authority makes you feel authoritative, so do the words you use. When you give a clear instruction without any superfluous words around it you convince yourself as well as your child that you have the authority to do so. The most difficult part of this may be to stop after the instruction, and resist adding a softener like ‘OK... ?’ or ‘All right... ?’ which can blow your authority right out of the water (in your own eyes as well as your child’s).

Varying your language of authority is important, though, because everybody becomes immune to the same thing said over and over again. So let’s look at some other things we can say within our authority.

Julian from *The Famous Five*

I learned my language of Parental Authority wherever I could find it, and one of the best sources I found was a series of children’s books. When my daughter was younger I read Enid Blyton’s *The Famous Five* books to her at bedtimes and we gradually built up almost the whole series. The oldest child in these stories is called Julian and he would often make suggestions like “*I vote we have some ginger beer!*” or “*Let’s go and buy ices!*” but when he wanted to assert his authority he would simply say something like “*We’ll stop at the next village. We’ll see if there’s a shop where we can buy*

ices’. Or *‘We’ll clear everything away before we go for our swim. You girls will wash up, Dick will collect some more wood and I’ll gather some blackberries for later.’* That sort of thing. Nobody questioned him.

I hoped that my daughter wouldn’t notice that Julian had far more natural authority than I did. I began to sneak in a bit of Julian language into non-negotiable situations with my children and was amazed at how effective it was:

‘We’ll get our coats on now.’

‘We’ll do the shopping quickly now and then we’ll get home.’

‘I’ll get my purse and the car keys. You’ll get yourself ready and we’ll meet at the door.’

‘We’ll clear up now. I’ll do the books and you’ll do the toys. Off we go.’

I built up to the big one, the scenario that required real confidence – and when I felt ready, I popped my head into the living room one evening and said this to my daughter:

‘OK, time for bed. You’ll go up and clean your teeth and get into your pyjamas and I’ll go and fill your hot-water bottle and come and read you a bedtime story’ (and I disengaged).

Like a little lamb she jumped up to obey me, and my daughter’s bedtimes were transformed from that day forward. Her relief that I finally knew what I was doing was palpable. She never did realise I was being Julian.

I think it worked so well because I had practised in not-so-important areas enough first to have confidence in myself, and for this language to be effective you do need conviction.

When we confidently state what is going to happen next – as if it’s certain and already decided – we make things very simple for our child, who does not have anything to compute. Even the clearest instruction involves a decision to obey or not to obey, but a statement of information about what’s coming up doesn’t even need that. All it takes is for your child to believe you, and because you are the grown-up and know things, he likely does. It is very reassuring for a child to be told what is going to happen. He doesn’t know: he likes the fact that you do, and he doesn’t think to question it.

Spoken with a matter-of-fact, even cheery, authority ‘We will... ’ ‘I will... and you will... ’ statements are clear, authoritative and invite no

resistance. They work well because they give your child no choice to make, which is a rest from all the decision-making he has to make constantly as he negotiates his world.

Trust and Expectation

If we want to express trust and clear expectations of behaviour, it doesn't do any harm to state those things directly sometimes:

‘I think you can manage this by yourself.’

‘I'm confident you can do it.’

‘I trust you to remember next time.’

‘I expect you two to work out your problems without hurting each other.’

‘I think you guys are quite capable of sorting this out together without my help.’

‘I expect you to listen when I tell you something.’

And, in answer to what you've been thinking, if your child doesn't get his coat on after three times, try a statement like one of these in your ‘Frankly, I'm getting annoyed now’ tone of voice:

‘I trust you to do what I tell you.’

‘I expect you to get your coat on when I tell you it's time.’

‘When I tell you to do something I expect you to do it.’

Even if you are impatiently and ungraciously throwing his coat at him at this point, these words will provoke less resistance than a threat. Some parents feel that they should not get angry with their children, and have failed if they do so, but it's fine to express anger. We are only human, and children are really not that delicate. It feels so much better, though, if you are in ownership of it and express it with an I-statement rather than a You-statement (which is likely to be judging, blaming or criticising).

Speaking from I rather than You is less likely to create resistance, as it cannot be perceived as an attack. You are not batting the ball to your child for her to return with a volley – as you run the risk of doing with You-directed statements such as ‘You'd better do what I tell you’ or ‘You should have got your coat on by now’. ‘I’ invites a child's attention towards you, whereas ‘You’ pushes it away.

An Alternative to Threats

The problem with threats is that they trip off the tongue easily. We make them almost unconsciously, but they are really not very effective because they draw attention to the undesired behaviour followed by an unpleasant consequence.

This is a classic ‘Don’t think of a lemon’ case: it is a fact that telling your child what you do want is far more effective than telling him what you don’t want, because stating the undesired behaviour reinforces a picture of it in his mind. The same thing happens if you state the desired behaviour – you create a picture or a vision in his head which he couldn’t see before, and he is drawn unconsciously to the picture you create. Words are very powerful when we create pictures with them.

So we need to retrain our brains to say the same thing but turned around, so that rather than challenge a negative behaviour followed by a negative result we state the desired behaviour followed by a positive result.

‘If you don’t get to bed by seven there won’t be time for a bedtime story’ is a very negative statement. It all feels like doom and gloom in the bedtime scenario tonight. Turn that around to ‘If you’re in bed by seven there’ll be time for a bedtime story’ spoken cheerily and confidently, and just feel the difference. The first sentence communicates mistrust: the second communicates trust – and yet the message is essentially the same.

Making a statement using two negatives (the undesired behaviour plus the undesired result) lowers positive energy for both you and your child, and we expect the child to then manufacture the positive motivation to jump up and obey us. Replacing the negatives with two positives (the desired behaviour followed by the desired result) lifts energy and makes it easier to obey.

‘Get your coat on now and we’ll be on time’ sounds like a positive affirmation of an expectation, which is much easier to hear than a negative threat. You can even say it cheerfully because it makes you feel good to hear a positive outcome, too.

You can turn a threat round into a positive statement of intention, a kind of ‘If you do this then I’ll do that’ deal:

‘If you get to bed on time I’ll read you a bedtime story.’

‘When you’ve cleaned your teeth I’ll come and tuck you in.’

‘If you take care of my things then I’ll let you use them.’

There’s something pleasingly logical and fair about statements like that, and children do generally like logic and fairness even if they are not always

capable of acting in that way themselves.

Note that these statements put together two related actions, and not the promise of an unrelated reward. So instead of:

‘If you two fight I’ll put you in separate rooms... ’

We might say:

‘If you two can play together safely and share the toys I’ll allow you to stay in here together.’

And instead of:

‘I’m not going to listen while you’re shouting at me... ’

We could say:

‘I’ll listen to you when you speak to me in an ordinary voice.’

Turning threats around into positive statements of behaviour and intention is emphatically not the same as ‘If you help me with the shopping I’ll buy you some sweets’ – which is blatant bribery. And you should only use blatant bribery when you’re desperate, not as a normal part of everyday life, otherwise you will always have to do it and you really don’t want to go down that route.

Watch out for adding ‘OK... ?’ or ‘All right... ?’ after a positive statement of intention. It changes a simple sharing of information into a request for approval. It sounds like ‘Is that all right with you... ?’ and implies choice, which is dishonest – as there is no choice. You might say ‘OK’ in a ‘Right. Let’s get started’ way, or you might say ‘Let’s go’, ‘Off we go’ or even just ‘Go’ if you find it difficult not to add anything. When we start to give clear information or clear instructions it can be hard to stop there and not go in to our habitual ‘All right... ?’ endings to soften it. Sometimes it’s not so much what we say but what we leave out.

One day out of the blue, when my oldest son was about seven, he said to me ‘How come you’re such a lovely Mummy now and you used to be so horrible?’

I was a little taken aback. ‘What do you mean, I used to be horrible?’ I asked indignantly.

‘Well,’ he said. ‘You used to say such horrible things sometimes.’

‘Like what?’

‘Like... you remember the time on holiday when we were on the motorway and we were fighting in the back of the car, and you threatened to put us out on the hard shoulder and drive off without us?’

‘Erm... did I say that? Oh, yeah. I think I remember now. You’re right. I never say things like that any more, do I?’ I said, brightly.

As that one had slipped my mind I assume that it was probably just a normal part of my parenting language. It obviously hadn’t stood out for me as a particularly bad example of the threats I used to make. When my son made that comment I realised that I generally no longer used threats at all, because I didn’t need to. It was interesting that he thought I was much nicer, when in fact I had become a lot stricter and more uncompromising. Being more honest about what was OK and what wasn’t OK for me seemed to have made it no longer necessary to descend to being quite so horrible at times.

Consequences

Threats are generally used as a part of a punishment and reward system: we threaten either to impose an unpleasant consequence or to take away something the child wants. We also use threats to inform the child of a natural consequence of the behaviour for them: ‘You’ll be late’, ‘You’ll fall’, etc., to which the inevitable answer is ‘No, I won’t.’

I hear the phrase natural consequences a lot, and often I can’t see the difference between that and punishment. I once heard a parent say this to a teenager:

‘I can’t trust you, so the natural consequence is that I’m taking away your mobile phone for a week.’

It is quite unnecessary to jump straight to a punishment (or, ahem, a natural consequence) if you consider what true natural consequences are and state those clearly instead. So let’s be honest, give our children some accurate information, trust them and give them a chance. You can either do this every time, or threaten punishment every time, but your child will learn far more about the natural social consequences of his behaviour if you do the former: you are giving him a chance to feel ashamed and regret his behaviour, rather than diverting his feelings to anger with you for punishing him.

Some true natural consequences for me over the years have been:

‘If you keep doing that I know I’m going to start to get irritated, and I don’t want to end up being really angry with you.’

‘I don’t really feel like helping you when you don’t help me.’

‘It’s much more difficult for me to be a nice Mummy when you shout at me when you want something.’

‘I can feel myself getting angry. It’s harder for me to stay patient when you ignore what I’m saying.’

‘It’s more difficult for me to feel generous towards you when I don’t get help when I want it.’

‘I don’t feel like giving to you so much when I don’t feel you’re bothered about me.’

‘It’s harder for people to keep feeling friendly when they feel like they’re being used.’

‘I know you want to go to the park later, but it’s hard to feel like making the effort to take you when you don’t make an effort for me.’

‘It’s much harder for me to be nice to you if you’re not nice to me, because I’m just human.’

I have even been known to say:

‘I know you’re going to ask me for ice creams later on and I already know that I’m going to be feeling resentful and not feel like getting them if you carry on behaving like this. I know myself well enough.’

All these statements are made seriously and not in a wheedling, lecturing, sarcastic or threatening voice. They are not pleading ‘Please be nice to me’. They are not trying to teach the child a lesson, and they are not exaggerating anything to scare him. They are just giving information as honestly as possible. They are strong direct statements of fact and when I used them I was generally feeling annoyed or irritated, which I did not try to hide. The underlying message is simply ‘I trust that you are intelligent enough to know what to do with this information, and I trust that you are reasonable and will get it.’

We all know honesty when we hear it, don’t we? Children seem to respond really well to honesty and directness and it’s not surprising, really. It just makes things simpler when people are honest.

The other important factor in the statements above is that they are all natural social consequences of unacceptable behaviour. If people don’t help us we don’t feel like helping them, but we do not take away their mobile phones. Responding honestly teaches our children a lot about how other people out in the world may feel about their behaviour and react to it, too.

Making Deals

Children also love fairness: if they perceive something as fair they are far more likely to willingly go along with it. That's why children respond well to deals.

A deal says 'I will allow you to do this, but only on these conditions.' As the parent, you have the right to make the conditions and expect your child to follow them, and a child generally recognises the legitimacy of that.

Deals don't work, though, if we don't make it clear that a deal is what we are striking – if our language is more of a request, or asking a favour:

'Let's remember to play safely, please, boys – like we agreed.'

'Just one hour on the computer, please. No longer.'

'You can watch TV, but please tidy up your room first.'

None of these statements make it clear that what you are asking for is actually non-negotiable, which doesn't give the child the correct information he needs. What happens when we go in too soft is that we inevitably then come down too hard when they don't do it:

'Right. I'm taking those sticks away as you can't keep to the deal.'

'OK. You didn't keep to your part of the deal, so no more computer time for you this week.'

'Switch that TV off now. The deal was that you tidy your room first.'

That's a good example of how we switch from Camp B to Camp A, and we probably feel angrier because we said it in a reasonable way to begin with.

How to Make Effective Deals

We need to make deals using our Parental Authority from the start. That's just being honest and straightforward and leaving no room for doubt:

'OK, boys. Here's the deal. I will allow you to play with the sticks as long as you can play safely so nobody gets hurt. Do you both understand? Good. We have a deal, then.'

'You can go on the computer, but the deal is that you come off after one hour, and you don't complain to me about it. Got that? OK. Those are my terms.'

'You can watch TV but the condition is that you tidy your room first. That's the deal. If you agree to that you can put the TV on when you're finished. Agree? Great.'

Those are proper deals. No room for misunderstanding there. Children would really prefer that you make deals in this way: first, you are being

honest and direct – and second, you are not infantilising them by being soft and nice, so they feel more grown up and thus more motivated to keep to the deal. But children don't always get things right, so what if they don't keep to it?

First, it's important that you don't watch them to make sure that they do. Leave them to it and trust. Second, keep to the same principle as when you give clear instructions: make the deal, disengage and give it three times.

If the deal is made with two or more children, you'll find that they police each other. So you leave them playing and go and get on with your own business – but you can hear if things are starting to go wrong, so you come back in. You may not need to say anything. One child will hiss to the other 'We made a deal' and the other one will stop crying. Out you go again – and if this happens once more you step in a second time, give them a nod when they start working it out together and leave again. If you do want to say something it need only be a simple 'Boys, we have a deal' or 'I trust you to remember the deal' – something which continues to communicate your trust in them. The same principle applies if you happen to find yourself walking past the child who hasn't started tidying her room yet, or if you notice that your child is still on the computer.

It is worth making this effort to allow for three messages of trust, as you want your child to be able to stick to his part of the deals you make with him – because this way he gets practice in doing so, even if he's not perfect. Keeping to his part of the bargain makes him feel grown up and responsible, and that is his motivation to try hard next time. Just make sure the deals you are making are age-appropriate and doable, and don't forget that he is willing but will inevitably get it wrong sometimes in practice.

My daughter used to scream in the car. Journeys to school were a nightmare, and I spent a long time trying to deal with her behaviour as it happened before I thought of making a clear deal. One morning I got everyone out of the house early and lined up my four children in the drive, from tallest to shortest – a bit like the von Trapp family in *The Sound of Music*.

'OK,' I said, brightly. 'Who wants to drive with me in my car?'

'Meee,' they all chorused.

'Right,' I said. 'This is the deal. These are my conditions for anyone who wants to drive in my car with me: no screaming, no fighting, no loud noises of any kind, no distracting the driver while vehicle is in motion.'

Quiet, calm, friendly behaviour at all times. Otherwise it's not safe and we might crash... so those are my conditions for everyone who wants to drive with me' (I really did spell it out that clearly).

I then asked each child in turn, starting with my oldest son:

'Would you like to drive with me in my car?'

I could see that the boys knew what I was doing, and they played their part very well, each saying 'Yes, Mummy,' till I got to end of the line and asked my daughter.

'Yes, Mummy,' she said meekly.

'Brilliant,' I said. 'That's the deal, then, and that's how we'll drive to school every day.'

That put an end to my daughter screaming in the car. As we were leaving the house I could see that she was in a bad mood a couple of times over the following weeks, so I called out to everyone as we were heading for the car, 'Remember the deal, everyone who wants to drive with me,' and that was enough to snap her out of it. I really don't know why I didn't make it clear earlier.

Using your parental responsibility as a reason or explanation for a deal also works well because it's fair and unequivocal. So for example:

'OK, but if I let you watch telly this morning the deal is that you come out for a walk this afternoon without complaining. It's my responsibility as a parent to make sure your TV time is balanced with exercise and fresh air. So that's my condition.'

That is much easier for a child to accept than 'But you've got to come out for a walk later because you need to get some fresh air and exercise.'

More Natural Consequences

If the deal really isn't doable – say, your children really can't do the playing with sticks thing safely – then you can take the sticks away because really that's your only option, and that's fair enough. You can concede that it was asking too much of them but you gave them a fair chance so you don't need to be grovelling and apologetic about it, but nor do you need to be angry with them if their failure was a result of being unable to take on too large a responsibility.

At the school where I worked the *Star Wars* craze was in full swing and some of the children were bringing lightsabers in to play with during lunchtimes. A couple of younger kids got hit with them in separate

incidents, and there followed a discussion about whether to ban the bringing in of lightsabers altogether. What we did instead was to gather together the children who wanted to play with them and inform them very clearly about our conditions for use: that we had to see that they could play with them safely, and that if they could show us they could do so without anyone getting hurt we would allow their use. The children were thrilled to be shown this trust, and were eager to show us that they could keep to their side of the deal.

For two weeks the children policed each other very strictly, but inevitably there were a couple more incidents of children getting bashed – not seriously, but enough for us to reconvene the group and tell them that we had seen what an effort everyone had made, and the level of responsibility that had been taken... but that we had no option but to ban lightsabers, as we could not risk a more serious injury to a child. The children not only understood, but actually agreed with the decision. As one of the older boys said, ‘It was getting really difficult to stop the younger ones from getting a bit wild, and playtimes weren’t fun any more.’

When deals are clearly made and it becomes obvious that it is impossible for children to stick to them, this is an example of a true natural consequence – which children accept because they can see you have no other option. The taking away of the right was not seen as a punishment because it wasn’t a punishment. It was a regretful decision. In the end the children were relieved that the adults took control and made that decision for them, as they had found their part in the deal too difficult to sustain. But they had had a great experience of taking responsibility through trying.

Jumping in with a punishment immediately when your child gets it wrong is counterproductive. If you want him to be motivated to try his best next time it’s far better to say ‘I trust you to get it right next time’ or ‘I expect you to remember your part of the deal next time.’ And before the next time you make a deal you remind him ‘You didn’t keep to your part of the deal last time, but I’m trusting you to remember this time.’ You may have to do this more than once, but it’s a choice between that and punishment every time, and he will learn far more quickly this way.

Your Expertise Authority

You’ll remember in [Chapter Three](#) (in the bit about sharing toys) how to simply give accurate information, like you do when you are giving

directions to a stranger. That was an example of using your Expertise Authority. Just imagine how you would react if that driver who had stopped to ask for help had questioned your authority on the subject:

‘Yes, but why do I have to turn left at the lights?’

You would probably be a little nonplussed, surprised and confused. Your eyes might widen. You might shrug your shoulders, grin quizzically and say:

‘Well, because that’s the right way.’

If she frowned and replied ‘But I don’t want to go left at the lights’ then we may raise our eyebrows and say good-humouredly:

‘OK, but you’ll need to if you want to get there.’

You would keep it polite, but you would probably then move away and leave it with her: after all, you’ve done your bit and really that’s all you can do. Expertise Authority doesn’t try to convince, persuade or cajole – and it doesn’t need to get angry.

Although you can’t always have such equanimity – sometimes you’ll be tired yourself and just feel irritated and impatient – if you bear in mind this principle and use it whenever possible you will probably find that your child accepts what you are saying. Remember that she expects to hear your authority on issues such as cleaning her teeth, eating her greens, getting enough sleep, not watching too much TV, wrapping up warm, not eating too many sweets, washing her hands and all those myriad daily issues. In fact she believes you know everything, so act as if you do when it’s important. If we threaten or plead in this area we undermine our own authority and confuse her.

Be clear that this is a non-negotiable area if you want these sorts of issues to become automatic unquestioned behaviour. Act as if it’s obvious. Perfect your goes-without-saying voice and give short, simple reasons with a sharing information attitude, rather than in a patiently explaining and justifying way. You can always give more detailed explanations at other times, but the moment when you are actually dealing with a child who is resisting cleaning her teeth is not the time to get engaged with her train of thought and allow yourself to be derailed. Remember that the scientist needs to make sure you mean it, so the more matter-of-fact you are the more confident she feels in you.

We have been looking at rules and routines and non-negotiable areas in day-to-day life, but there's another part of the secure structure we create for our children, which is in the area of respect and our own personal boundaries. So in the next chapter let's take the focus off the child's behaviour and put it on to ourselves.

If you only take away three things from this chapter, make sure they are these:

1. Give simple, clear, direct instructions. Disengage and remember the magic three.
2. Replace threats with confident clear statements of the behaviour you do want, followed by the positive result.
3. Make deals using your Parental Authority right from the start so that it's clear that you are making a deal. There are lots of other areas where you can be as woolly as you like, but not this one.

CHAPTER NINE: YOUR PERSONAL BOUNDARIES

My daughter screams when I tell her she can't have anything to eat before dinner. Screams and screams. She's pretty good at it.

'You're horrible. You never let me have anything,' she shouts.

'Don't talk to me like that, please,' I say.

She is furious.

'Don't you talk to me like *that*.'

'Look, I've told you once. Stop that noise.'

'*You* stop! Idiot.'

I'm getting angrier.

'Don't you speak to me like that. I've had enough.'

'You idiot!'

She screams more and more until I scream back 'Stop.' I am exhausted. I think it's really important that I stop letting her get away with behaviour like this, but I'm not sure how: she is much tougher than me.

Your own personal boundaries are the other key area of the safe structure you create for your child – and I learned that the hard way, by not being clear about mine. Sometimes it felt like I didn't have any at all. You will not get far with feeling confident in your authority in the daily routines if your child knows they can treat you however they like and you can't do anything about it.

Knowing Our Boundaries

We all have our own personal boundaries in the way we are treated by other people, and sometimes it takes us time to know where those boundaries are.

We put up with behaviour and kid ourselves that it's OK until we reach a tipping point and realise it's not. It can happen the other way round, too: you can be very strict and uncompromising about some aspect of behaviour and then realise one day that it really isn't that important to you. So our personal boundaries are not fixed. They can change as our beliefs change, and that's all fine and human: the important thing is that we act with integrity to our beliefs at the same time as being open to changing them.

We have to try to be true to ourselves, if only because if we put up with something we don't like we are likely to take it out on our child anyway. We are often unsure where our personal boundaries are until they are crossed, and children are very good at doing that.

Children behave in a lot of ways that we are unsure about:

'Is this OK or isn't it?'

'Should I be accepting because she's a child or should I challenge her?'

'Every other parent I know seems to allow this sort of behaviour. Maybe I should, too.'

'Am I just being too hard on him?'

These may all be useful questions which help you to think about what kind of parent you want to be and whether your response to your child is reasonable, but we also need to balance that with a trust in our own instincts and just go with what feels right to us.

I remember coming out of the house on one occasion and finding my children climbing all over the car in the driveway. I stopped. I had seen all my friends' children climb over their family cars many times and I had always thought 'I'm glad my children don't do that.' And here they were doing it. All the other parents thought it was fine. Should I allow it, too?

'Off the car,' I bellowed (it didn't take me long to reach my decision).

'But, Mum,' they all complained immediately. 'Everyone else's parents let them do it.'

'I'm one of those boring parents who doesn't.'

'But why, Mum? We won't damage it.'

'Because it's my car and I get to say how it's treated,' I said, and went back into the house (thus showing my trust in them, obviously). They never tried to do it again. It can be tough when you want to be a fun easy-going parent, but it's so important to be boring in the areas that matter to you.

Being in Touch With Our Own Feelings

The example above was fairly easy. It didn't take much for me to gauge my true feelings about the issue, and I didn't have a problem in trusting my own reaction. But sometimes it's harder than that, when situations are a bit more subtle and we are not as confident in our own judgement.

One way of getting in touch with ourselves is to listen to what our bodies are telling us. Even though we can fool our minds that we are OK with something, our bodies don't lie. We all have a physiological response somewhere in our bodies to unpleasant or challenging circumstances, which can be a tightening of the forehead, a restricted feeling in the throat, a heavy feeling across the shoulders, a tight feeling in the chest or a feeling in the pit of the stomach. This is our primitive response system on automatic and it works very well – so well in fact that we are often unconscious of it in the moment, although we may realise it later. If you've ever had the experience – when it only dawns on you the next day – that your feelings were hurt by something somebody said you'll know what I mean.

The process of getting to know ourselves seems to run on a cycle of ignoring or pushing down our body's warning signals over time – which we may justify with good reasons – until something triggers a strong reaction and our body shouts 'You can't ignore me any more.' Then we realise that we have been putting up with something we don't like and we challenge it and change it. Then the whole process starts again – perhaps in another area, perhaps in the same area. Each time we get a revelation about ourselves we get to know ourselves a little bit more and move a little closer to being connected in the moment, when it matters. Every time we do this we feel more confident and trusting in our own instincts. This process happens in life and it happens with children. We are learning and growing all the time.

So a useful technique – if you are unsure of yourself and your responses, when faced with a child's behaviour – is to stop, say nothing, notice what your body is feeling and take one deep breath. Breathing in some space and then exhaling creates a boundary between you and your child, centres you in the present moment and makes it more possible for you to consciously act rather than unconsciously react.

This is your two brain systems at work: your amygdala sends an instant warning sign down to whichever part of your body expresses it for you most clearly, and if you stop at this point you are more able to recognise it and then give your prefrontal cortex a chance to step in and have its say.

Rather than instantly pushing down an uncomfortable feeling it has been shown that simply naming it for ourselves calms down the amygdala, just as acknowledgement helps to calm down a child.

Self-Respect

Feeling disrespected is possibly one of the more uncomfortable feelings we experience in life. It can feel as if we don't matter or don't even exist, so it is a real tangible existential crisis. No wonder we feel so angry when our child acts towards us in a way that feels disrespectful.

Say your child has just screamed and shouted at you and called you an idiot (just pulling that one out of the air). There are two classic ways we respond:

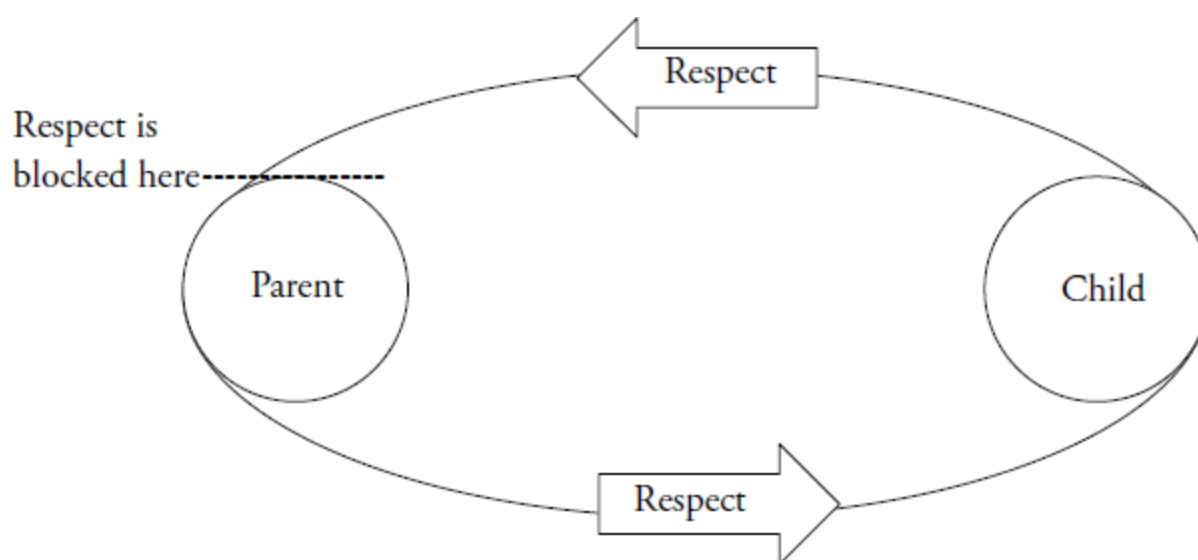
- Camp A: 'Don't you talk to me like that. That's really rude.'
This only compounds the disrespect. In fact it validates your child's means of expression, as you have just copied it. You are fighting disrespect with disrespect. Your child has batted the ball over the net and you have lobbed it straight back. It is probably not going to be a game you will enjoy.
- Camp B: 'Darling, please don't talk to me like that. It's not nice. I know you're angry, but...'
This response tries to counter disrespect with respect shown towards the child – who doesn't need it, as she's not the one lacking in it. That's you. There's something very provoking about someone who is extremely polite to us when we are angry – almost as if they are putting themselves on the moral high ground, especially if their body language is screaming rage.

The Camp A response fights back. It battles disrespect with disrespect, and when disrespect battles itself you really don't want to be around. It can get ugly. You have also allowed your child to influence your behaviour, which gives power to her expression of disrespect towards you (and you don't want to be feeding that).

The Camp B response is accepting of the disrespect and tries very hard to respond respectfully towards the child, which is an honourable intention but which sends the respect in the wrong direction. It is you who is lacking, not her.

So, assuming that you would like your children to treat you with respect, how do you react when they don't? Let's look at respect as something that flows around every member of your family and between you and your child – something that you would like to keep flowing. When your child treats you disrespectfully the flow coming towards you is blocked, and the only person who can get it going again is you. Your child can't do that. As you are the one missing out on respect, you need to put it back for yourself.

Fig. I. Respect



Both the reactions above are directed towards the child, but when respect is not flowing towards you – and you feel the lack – you have to replace it by a healthy dose of self-respect and give it back to yourself. When you speak from a place of self-respect your words come out very differently from how they are expressed when you instantly react before thinking. In reacting you can very easily compound the disrespect which has been created by your child, as your response is likely to be either disrespectful back or lacking in self-respect.

So it's a time to take a deep breath before responding – to put some space between you and your child and give your executive brain a chance to regain functionality, because you will have lost that: there's nothing like a child's disrespect to fire up strong primitive emotions in your amygdala. I remember very clearly the very first time I stepped back from my

daughter's rage and thought 'Wait a minute. It's her who's angry, not me. I don't have to take on her anger. I really don't want it.' Such a relief.

It takes a bit of practice to step back. Obviously, you won't always be able to manage it, but the more you do it the more it becomes just an instinctive response and you don't have to try any more. You will begin to consciously respond to your child, rather than unconsciously react.

The Language of Self-Respect

Once you've stepped back your response needs to come from I rather than be directed to You. You are then making a strong statement of self-respect by putting the respect back where it is missing, and its underlying message is 'I have a right to speak and I expect to be listened to.' An I-message draws your child towards you and gives her nothing to fight, as you are not returning the ball over the net. A statement of self-respect simply starts with I and tells the truth. Depending on the severity of the situation you have a range of possible responses, from softer to harder, so remember to vary your response and don't say the same thing every time.

The most important thing is to be simple and direct and deliver your message clearly, firmly and unapologetically. So at the softer end of the scale, it could just be something simple like:

'I don't like being spoken to like that.'

'I'm not happy about the way you're talking to me.'

'I don't like to be called names.'

'I'm not OK with being ignored.'

'I don't want to be shouted at.'

These are all short, simple, to-the-point statements which give your child all the information he needs. They require no further elaboration or explanation. Your child is intelligent, after all, and quite capable of understanding the required behaviour without you spelling it out for him. If you offer any further explanation you weaken the statement, so leave it there.

Note that I have not included a statement beginning 'I feel' – for example 'I feel sad when you hit me' – partly because feeling words can sound victim-like and manipulative, but also because it isn't true. I may feel many emotions when my child is disrespectful to me but sadness isn't one of them.

More serious behaviour requires a stronger, more deliberate, unequivocal statement, matched by tone of voice, facial expression and body language:

‘I don’t accept being shouted at.’

‘I will not put up with being spoken to like that.’

‘I don’t allow people to speak to me in that way.’

‘I won’t tolerate swearing.’

‘I never allow people to treat me with disrespect.’

When you think about the power of words you can see that simply expressing a statement like that makes it feel true, so you build your own self-respect by your choice of words. Spoken with conviction, you trick your brain into believing it. You also make it much more difficult for your child to continue treating you with disrespect. You know how it is when you meet someone who clearly has true self-respect. You can’t help but respect them. It’s impossible not to. This was what I learned slowly and painfully over many years in regard to myself and my children – that it wasn’t about them. It was about me. I wanted to become one of those people you can’t help but respect.

A statement of self-respect doesn’t explain, justify or ask permission. It simply says ‘This is the kind of person I am.’ It’s important that you then stop, otherwise you’ll be tempted to say something like ‘OK... ?’ and ruin it.

A statement of self-respect doesn’t engage with the content of what your child is saying. It only addresses the way they are saying it, otherwise you are giving him permission to communicate it in this way. But at the same time a statement of self-respect is – by its nature – always respectful to the other person, because it’s not a statement about them but about you.

Disengaging

If your child immediately says sorry or responds respectfully then you’re done and it needs nothing further, but if your child continues with the same behaviour this is the time to disengage. Disengaging after speaking reinforces the strength of the message and your seriousness. Your body is confirming your words. ‘Look. I really don’t tolerate being shouted at.’

Turn away and get on with doing something else and pay no attention to her, otherwise you have just lied. Hold out for as long as possible because she will probably stop soon, out of boredom or feeling a little bit stupid. But

if not, keep to the three times rule. If your child continues to shout or scream, remember that the scientist is testing you to see if you really do respect yourself, and she would really rather you did.

‘I think you heard what I said.’

‘I really don’t allow it.’

‘I think you understood.’

‘I meant what I said.’

Keep your responses short and sweet: simple matter-of-fact confirmations of what you said previously or expressions of trust in her intelligence – and disengage. It’s not always going to work, but it’s amazing how often three times seems to be enough for a scientist to be satisfied.

So we were in the kitchen one day and my daughter was screaming at me, red in the face, and shouting ‘You idiot.’ I faced her.

‘I never allow anybody to treat me with disrespect,’ I announced as if I believed it, and turned away to get on with cooking the dinner.

She continued to scream louder.

‘Idiot. Idiot!’

I waited a minute and then turned round.

‘I think you understood what I said,’ and I turned back.

‘You’re horrible. Horrible. You never listen to me!’

She continued screaming, and I turned round again.

‘I meant what I said and I think you got it,’ and I turned back again.

She screamed a bit longer and then stormed off, ran upstairs and slammed the door on the way out.

I made dinner and then called out to my children ‘Time to set the table,’ and to my great surprise my daughter came hurtling down the stairs into the kitchen, and said, ‘I’ll set the table.’ She did so. I thanked her and she said sheepishly, ‘Sorry about before, Mummy.’ I smiled and said ‘That’s OK’ and then with mock severity, ‘Just never do it again,’ and she said ‘No,’ and giggled, shamefaced. We hugged and all was well with the world again.

I realised that the setting of the table had been her chance to make reparation for her previous behaviour. There was no need for me to teach her anything. She knew her behaviour had been unacceptable and she wanted to make up for it. My expressing my own boundaries clearly and directly, rather than challenging her behaviour and getting in to a fight, had allowed her the space to experience all the natural feelings of regret. Because I didn’t shame her, she naturally felt ashamed of herself.

The great thing about expressing your own boundaries is that it is enough. You don't need to teach, lecture or devise complicated strategies to manage your child's behaviour. You just need to look after yourself. Your child learns much more – and much more quickly – from experiencing your self-respect in her interactions with you than in you trying to manage her disrespectful behaviour.

If your child does not apologise later, wait until a time when you are both feeling friendly towards each other again and then you only need say simply and matter-of-factly:

‘You know what happened before when you did that shouty, screamy thing at me? It's not OK. Don't do it again.’ Or something along those lines.

What a statement like that communicates is ‘I know you've got a brain and I don't need to explain why it wasn't OK.’ And then it's finished.

Note that all of the communication outlined above sends an underlying message of trust: trust in your child's intelligence; understanding and willingness to get it right. The messages from you are tough and uncompromising, but at no point belittling or shaming.

Sibling Fights

Your personal boundary also encompasses how other people treat each other in your presence. Say you were in the pub with a couple of friends and the other two started an argument with each other. How far would they have to go before you felt that their behaviour was disrespectful towards you in the progression from disagreement, irritation, goading, heated argument, to punches thrown... ? At what point would you think ‘Hey. I'm here, too,’ and feel a bit insulted that your needs are not being considered? We are all different. It doesn't matter if someone else would accept it: it is our own personal boundaries that are important here if we are to live with integrity.

Speaking from our own boundaries gives us a different starting point for understanding and dealing with sibling fights. If you look at it from the point of view of being disrespectful behaviour towards you and make an authoritative self-respecting statement you have a way of responding which does not focus on, or reinforce, their unacceptable behaviour.

We are always advised not to focus on the bad behaviour and to make sure we praise our children, too. In fact, there are lots of ways of challenging the behaviour we don't like without focusing on it (all coming

up in this book) which negates the need to balance it with lots of manufactured praise.

The first way is to speak from self-respect. Say your two children are starting to argue and fight as you are trying to watch TV or relax in some way. Instead of telling them off for their behaviour or trying to help them sort it out (and giving them lots of attention for it in the process) you could just state clearly and unequivocally:

‘I am here, too. I don’t like loud shouty angry voices in my living room while I’m trying to relax.’

‘I have a right to relax in our house and I can’t with that noise going on.’

‘I don’t accept that behaviour. I want a peaceful atmosphere in the evening.’

‘I am trying to read.’

Make those statements in a loud (you have to be loud if they are shouting at each other), clear, authoritative and perhaps slightly indignant voice and matching facial expression, and they will carry far more authority and self-respect than a statement directed towards the children themselves. You are stating clearly that their behaviour crosses your line, without giving them the message that what they are doing really interests you. In other words, you are not engaging with their behaviour at all. You are staying out of it and simply standing up for yourself.

Tantrums

My daughter used to throw mega tantrums, and I wasn’t used to this kind of behaviour because my boys had not really done that – they got angry and fought with each other and would scream and get upset, but they never did that out-of-control thing when a child throws himself on the floor and screams and screams. My daughter did. Anything would set her off, and it didn’t matter where we were – at home, in public, in the car... anywhere. Life was very stressful.

I dealt with it in different ways depending on how I was feeling, but underneath I was worried and I wondered what the cause of her behaviour was. I imagined that it was her position in the family. I thought it must be difficult for her to be the youngest – and not only that, but a girl in a family of boys. All the advice I heard just confused me more:

- Camp A sees tantrums as naughty behaviour to be corrected.
- Camp B interprets them as an indication of problems a child needs help with or a healthy way of discharging feelings.

I wasn't sure which of them was right.

This belief that children need to get feelings out – better out than in – has become more and more prevalent, but in fact if you watch a child throwing a tantrum you can see that they are not happy to be out of control and overwhelmed with huge feelings they can't handle. Accepting the behaviour or implicitly approving of it and allowing it – through a belief that it is somehow healthy – doesn't help your child learn to manage those feelings, which are generally born out of frustration and expressed as rage. Your (often unconscious) acceptance of that behaviour, for whatever reason, only serves to validate it.

In our culture we are quick to look for reasons behind a behaviour and seek to interpret our child's feelings so that we can help them solve the assumed problem. In doing so we are joining our child down there in his drama when what he needs us to do is remain separate from it and give it no fuel.

Reframing our Beliefs About Tantrums

A child's angry feelings generally come from frustration: frustration that she can't get what she wants; she can't change things in the world; she can't understand something. Children all express frustration in different ways, and throwing a tantrum is just one of the more extreme ways. The problem may be the same: it is only the intensity of the reaction which is different.

In [Chapter Six](#) I talked about the importance of being a sounding-board but not a punch-bag. A rule of thumb is not to acknowledge and accept angry feelings expressed in unacceptable ways. We all know how irritating it is when we are feeling angry and someone says 'I know you're feeling really angry.' It makes us feel more rage, and the same happens for our child when we treat him in a way that sends that message even if we don't use those exact words.

Every time we implicitly accept or approve of him getting out his anger by flying into a rage we keep him stuck in his primitive brain, where he is helpless. Anger just generates more anger as his amygdala goes into a sort of feedback loop, which is when a child may start hyperventilating and

panic. What he needs to learn is to use his frontal brain to master those strong emotions, and he will do so little by little as he learns that throwing tantrums is actually a bit boring and tedious for everyone.

One day it suddenly struck me that my daughter was, in fact, an extremely privileged child. The fact that she was born into a loving family in one of the safest countries in the world – with enough to eat and drink, shelter and access to good education and opportunities, already put her up there in about the top 3% of children in the world. Billions of children before her had survived being the fourth child and the fact was that she had three lovely big brothers who were extremely patient with her, all things considered.

It hit me that I had been (largely unconsciously) justifying her behaviour, and overnight I reframed my beliefs about her tantrums – which I suddenly saw as abusive behaviour for which there was no excuse. I realised that throwing a tantrum was a great way of gaining all the power (a power children don't actually want to have) and that people who blow up whenever anything doesn't go right for them are simply very difficult to live with. You end up tiptoeing around them, walking on eggshells, for fear of their anger. The person who uses their anger in this way manipulates everyone. It is a form of bullying.

Getting angry with a child doesn't help. That just fuels his anger. But trying to hide our feelings of anger or irritation doesn't work, either. When we are calm, patient and understanding it's just irritating, and our child picks up our real feelings anyway as our body is busy communicating them loud and clear. If, however, we channel our feelings into a strong authentic expression of self-respect we take the spotlight off the child's behaviour and shine it on ourselves instead. The great thing about messages of self-respect is that you don't have to be perfect and calm and nice.

When we do this we are inviting our child to look outside himself. We draw him away from his overwhelming feelings in a non-threatening way which does not either fuel his anger or indulge it.

If we see tantrums as normal frustration expressed in an extreme way we naturally stop worrying about our child so much, and feel more confident in our own right to refuse to engage with them. As our child experiences our demonstrations of our own self-respect he respects us more and wants to be like us. We are leading him out of the primitive swamp of emotion emanating from his amygdala and modelling the engagement of

the executive brain to manage feelings. If we manage to react in this way most of the time a child begins to be bored with tantrums, too: they are not useful in either provoking us into an interesting loss of control or in gaining our undivided attention, so what's the point?

When I learned to take the focus off my daughter and her behaviour and put it onto me and my boundaries instead, it transformed our relationship. She was so relieved not to have to throw tantrums any more. It was as if she had been trying to force me to step up and take control for all those years, and she was so happy when I finally did.

Most children grow out of tantrums eventually – although we probably all know adults who never did – but the point is that children are happier not to have them, and responding by expressing your personal boundaries makes it easier for them to stop.

In all the awareness these days about children's needs there is one important one we forget, and that is the need for a child to experience frustration; a need to not have all his needs met. A child does not need to throw tantrums and scream and shout. He needs to learn to manage frustration, and luckily normal life will give him plenty of opportunity.

You'll notice that the responses to disrespectful behaviour outlined in this section contain no orders or directions, apart from the odd 'Don't do it again' after the event (when necessary). It is this lack of any instruction in the message which communicates the strongest trust in the intelligence and understanding of the child, as well as making resistance less likely, as it offers nothing to resist. There is another important aspect to self-respect, which is in the expression of our own legitimate needs – and here again the greatest trust is expressed when we hold off on giving orders.

Our Own Needs

When my first son was not yet two I remember settling down to the Wimbledon final for the afternoon. Previously I would have given over the whole day to this and watched all the build-up, too, but I was a parent now and I knew that would be pushing it a bit. I was unprepared, however, for the shock of the realisation that it was impossible to watch the match at all. I had a baby who jumped on me, made a lot of noise, was constantly demanding of my attention, and did dangerous things that I had to jump up and rescue him from. I remember thinking 'I am never ever going to be able to do anything I want to ever again in my life.'

You may not define watching the Wimbledon final as a true need, but the fact is that we all need to continue our interests and relax in the ways that work for us as our children are growing up, otherwise we become one-dimensional childcarers and lose ourselves bit by bit. That's not good for us or our children.

Our culture emphasises children's needs, but we have to re-establish our own needs more and more as our children grow up. Otherwise, how are they ever to know that we have any?

If we don't take responsibility for our own needs – and let others know about them – we end up taking it out on those we love, so it's best to be clear rather than expecting our children to second-guess us. It's also great role modelling for them. How are they to learn to stand up for their own needs when we are not there if they don't see us doing it?

If we are to know our own boundaries we also need to hold on to an awareness of our own needs, which can get lost when we are looking after children. When a baby is born, mother's and baby's needs are so intertwined that it's hard to separate them. All being well, as long as we are not suffering some form of post-natal depression, our need to meet our baby's needs is a force of nature. But even then we still have to look after our own needs and balance them with our child's: if we are not getting enough sleep, for example, we are not going to function properly as a parent. Sometimes we need to put our own oxygen mask on first.

The Difference Between Needs and Solutions

If we express our own needs honestly and directly we give children a fair chance of behaving well, but we get the language wrong if we say something like this:

'I need you to be quiet.'

That's not a need, that's a solution. The real need is:

'I need quiet' (and my solution to that is 'You be quiet').

Our genuine need in this case may be:

'I need to concentrate on this.'

'I need to hear what she's saying.'

'I need to relax.'

'I need you to...' statements are generally used as a way to cover up an instruction, as in: 'I need you to get your coat on now' when 'Coat on now' would do. 'I need you to' is an example of those extra words we use to

soften the message – but they can create resistance because children are very good at spotting dishonesty, however subtle. Those statements also run the risk of sounding needy and pleading. If you think about your real need, it's probably something like:

'I need to know we're not going to be late.' This can be followed with 'So coat on now' if necessary.

However, if we state an honest need plus a simple reason we are giving children all the information they need in order to know what to do themselves, so we do not always have to follow with an instruction. When we hold off we see that our children are quite capable of understanding the required behaviour from them. Children really want to help us, and by not spelling it out we assume both their intelligence and their care about us.

'I need quiet so I can get on with my work.'

'I need fifteen minutes to read my paper without interruption now, to recharge my batteries.'

'I need to go out for the evening so I can spend some time with my friends.'

'I need to know you two can get on with this by yourselves because I've got to cook dinner.'

'I need to concentrate on this so I don't make any mistakes.'

'I need my evening time now otherwise I'll get grumpy.'

'I need to get home quickly now so I can start the dinner.'

'I need calm mealtimes so that I can digest my food properly.'

If we stop there children often know exactly what to do, and willingly offer their help.

Preventive Messages

It is so helpful to let a child know what is coming up in the future to prepare her for expected behaviour, and so easy to get her on board to help you by stating what your need will be. If you can manage to stop before giving an order and give your child the chance to offer help, it's amazing how often even very little children will automatically offer it:

'I'll need to get straight off when I pick you up later so we're not late with dinner.'

'OK, Mummy. I'll come as soon as you get there.'

'I need to work this evening so I can get my job finished.'

'Don't worry, Daddy. I'll get to bed on time.'

‘I’m going to need to relax for a bit when we get in because I’ve had a really busy day.’

‘OK, Mummy. I’ll play by myself for a while.’

‘I’ll need to get things done quickly tonight so I can get out on time.’

‘We’ll help you Mummy.’

If these all look like textbook examples of perfect children they are not: they are real-life examples of my own imperfect children. If you look at those exchanges, don’t the responses seem like the natural ones you yourself would give to the initial statements? They are all the kind of responses we would expect to hear from people whom we know care about us, and if we don’t directly state our needs then we don’t give our children the opportunity to demonstrate their care for us. The underlying message is ‘I trust you. I trust that you’ll get this, and I trust that you will want to help me.’

Forewarning children of a future need simply gives them the relevant information, without which they are disadvantaged in terms of knowing how to behave.

When my three boys were very young I once had friends over for dinner. Only the once did I get my act together to do this, so it was a pretty important occasion. I summoned my boys.

‘This evening I’m really going to need uninterrupted adult time so I can just enjoy being with my friends,’ I said.

‘Don’t worry, Mum,’ they chorused. ‘We’ll play by ourselves. And we’ll get ourselves to bed. We won’t come in.’

‘Aaah. Thanks, guys,’ I said ‘That would be brilliant.’ I thought about it. I knew that the youngest was very likely to come crying to me after being caught first in a game of It.

‘What happens, though, if he gets caught first in a game of It or something? You know how that happens sometimes... ’

‘Don’t worry, Mum,’ my oldest son reassured me. ‘We’ll make sure he doesn’t. We’ll give him a chance.’

‘We’ll play games so that nothing like that happens,’ offered my second son.

‘And, Mummy,’ said my youngest son, drawing himself up to his full height, and looking serious and proud. ‘If it does happen, I won’t cry.’

And they were as good as their word. You never know how brilliant your children can be if you never give them a chance to demonstrate it.

Time needs

There are three types of time needs that we all have, but in differing amounts:

- **Diffused Time**
This means social time when we are in a group of people, and it meets our need for social interaction and the feeling that we are part of a larger group or community. It can be fun time, when relationships are fairly superficial but enjoyable. This is our public face.
- **One-to-One Time**
This is time spent with one other person – a partner, friend or family member. Communication may be at a deeper level when we are with just one person – someone who knows us better than the crowd and with whom we can be more honest about who we are (and be more intimate).
- **Alone Time**
This is the time we spend with ourselves – a time to get to know ourselves better – when we can relax and fully drop the public mask.

We can understand where we are on the introvert-extrovert spectrum if we ask ourselves the question ‘Which one of these am I drawn to when I’m flagging and need to recharge my batteries?’ It will probably vary, but if you generally can’t wait to be alone again after spending time in others’ company you’re more of an introvert, and if you feel more stressed being alone and you are happiest in a group you tend towards the extrovert.

Children are the same. The more introverted child will become more easily stressed in a group and the more extrovert will always want friends round to play.

Being more of an introvert myself, and living in a large family, my children are used to hearing me say ‘I need some alone time now.’ They know what I’m like.

Balancing Needs

We are urged to give children lots of one-to-one time, which always used to make me feel guilty because that’s impossible with four children. Children do not have a bottomless pit of needs for our undivided attention, though, and there are lots of ways we can give it throughout the day without having

to set aside two hours of quality time. Eye contact, a hug, a high five: all are ways of giving one-to-one time. In fact physical touch is a very powerful communicator of our attention, which can satisfy a child's needs for the time being until we are able to give them more.

Children use the same language as we do, so if we use 'I need you to...' statements we end up fighting each other with our own solutions, while the real need remains unexpressed:

'I need you to play by yourself for a bit now.'

'No, Daddy. I need you to play with me.'

What we see there is the automatic response to that You-statement. Your child immediately bats it back to you: it's almost impossible not to. With an understanding that our child is asking for some one-to-one time we can easily balance our needs with hers by replacing our initial statement with a real statement of our needs:

'I need some uninterrupted alone time to finish this off.'

If your child responds with 'OK. I'll go and play by myself for a while' or 'OK, Daddy. Will you come and play with me when you've finished?' then you're done. If your child responds with a demand it is easy enough to balance your needs:

'Oh, but Daddy... I want you to come and play with me.'

'OK. You go and set up and I'll come as soon as I've finished. Want a hug first?'

Holding out for your own need to be met while doing your best to satisfy your child's need is about the nearest we can get to perfection as parents (not that we want to be perfect). We won't always be able to do it – and that's fine, too. That's how children learn to respect the needs of others and manage frustration.

Getting honest about our own needs and stating them unapologetically can be difficult for parents who are supposed to be unselfishly looking after their children's needs, but that makes for a totally one-way relationship and does not give children the chance to recognise that other people have needs too. By the time your child is a teenager she will think that her needs are paramount and continue to treat you as if you don't have any. And we really don't want to be doormats, do we?

So looking out for your own needs is a big part of expressing self-respect. Get your own boundaries right and express them clearly and confidently, and your children's behaviour falls into place.

Getting to Know Our Own Needs

Our own legitimate needs may be in the practical day-to-day issues but we have more abstract wider needs, too, such as the need to feel valued, be respected, feel like we are doing OK. Honouring and stating those needs is important, too: they are also needs that your child doesn't know about unless you tell her:

‘I need to feel like I'm doing a good enough job as a mother.’

‘I need to feel like I'm appreciated.’

‘I need to feel cared about, too.’

‘I need to feel that I'm looking after you properly and keeping you healthy.’

I remember once when my daughter was reluctant to come and bake a cake with me and said ‘Do I have to?’ She jumped up and ran to help me when I said this:

‘Yes, because I need to feel like I'm a lovely Mummy, and baking a cake together will make me feel that.’

We obviously make sacrifices when our children are very young and perhaps it was a little naive of me to expect to be able to watch the Wimbledon final when my son was still at the being-very-dangerous stage, but I did learn to honour my own needs regarding major sporting occasions as my children grew up. When my daughter was three it was World Cup year. I had bought the wall chart, made my predictions and whipped up the excitement in the family, and in the week before the first kick-off I said to my daughter:

‘The World Cup starts next week and I'm going to need to watch every match without interruption, so that I can concentrate.’

She nodded as if she had already suspected as much.

‘So that means two or three matches a day,’ I continued. ‘For about two weeks. Then we're through the group stages and it gets less.’

‘OK, Mummy,’ she said. ‘I'll play by myself while you're watching.’

‘Brilliant. Thank you,’ I said. ‘I'll come and play with you at half-time for twenty minutes every match.’

‘Thank you, Mummy,’ she said happily. ‘Then I'll go and play by myself again when it's the second half.’

She was as good as her word, and I got to watch every single match of that year's World Cup. Had I not stated my needs clearly at the start I imagine that I would have spent those few weeks being irritated with her as

she continually made demands on me as I tried to watch. I would have resented that and probably been bad-tempered with her, whereas in getting my needs met I was so happy to give her lots of attention in between games. We were both happy.

What I learned over the years is that generally-accepted parenting wisdom is directed predominantly towards the child: to change him, help him, teach him, mould him, meet his needs and build his character – and that most of this is unnecessary. We need to focus more on ourselves, on being true to ourselves – authentic, honest and direct. It doesn't matter that we are not perfect human beings. We just need to be the best that we can be, take responsibility for our own needs, forgive and laugh at ourselves when we get it wrong, and hope that our children are watching (which they are. Very, very closely).

If you only take away three things from this chapter, make sure they are these:

1. When it comes to respect: rather than teaching it to your child, cultivate your own self-respect and express it clearly.
2. You have a right to your own needs, and a corresponding responsibility to let other people know what they are.
3. State your own real needs honestly, directly and unapologetically, and then stop and be prepared to be amazed when your child knows what to do. Don't show your surprise, obviously.

CHAPTER TEN: LETTING CHILDREN THINK FOR THEMSELVES

I am sitting on the settee holding a cup of hot tea. My youngest son comes running up and throws himself onto the settee next to me, making me almost spill the tea all over myself.

‘Watch out,’ I shout. ‘Can’t you see I’m holding a cup of hot tea? It could have spilled all over me. Take some care before you throw yourself on me. Have a look first... Use your eyes. Just think before you act.’

My son looks shamed, angry and upset. He sits on the settee next to me and wriggles about – only a little bit, but enough to irritate me. It’s almost like he’s doing it deliberately to get his own back.

I want him to take care in situations like that for the reason that he cares about me and wants to do his best not to hurt me, but I can see that my reaction has created precisely the opposite feeling in him.

It’s not surprising, really, when you consider that the very obvious subtext to my message was ‘You idiot.’

You remember that I said that understanding and obeying the rules is one way that children grow in self-esteem? Well, the other way is by working things out by themselves, without depending on adults to always give them the answers (as I had done with my son in that example).

In the last chapter I outlined the importance of not always telling our child what to do when it comes to expressing our own boundaries and needs, and in [Chapters Five](#) and [Six](#) I talked about how to respond to our child’s feelings so that she develops the ability to manage those feelings and problems by herself without us always giving her the answers.

We should also hold off on the instructions much more when we are dealing with unacceptable behaviour. We need to stop telling our children what to do all the time, so that they learn to think for themselves.

Behaviour Within the Structure

In this chapter I will be looking at the various behaviours our children exhibit within the structure of parental authority: all the unacceptable behaviours that we would rather they did not do. We cannot make rules for all unacceptable behaviour. We would never remember them ourselves and our children wouldn't stand a chance. We also infantilise our children if we deal with unacceptable behaviour by always telling them what to do and giving orders and instructions: they would never learn to behave appropriately without our help.

So within that secure structure we are creating we need to let children work things out for themselves as much as possible. We want them to do things because it feels right, and not because they are scared of us or expect a reward. We know that when they are in the outside world – and we are not there to tell them what to do – they need to be able to make the right decisions by themselves.

We are quite good at doing this in some areas: for example, we know not to immediately jump in and finish a child's jigsaw for him just because he's frustrated. We try not to tell him how to do it, but let him work it out for himself first as much as possible. If we are reading with a child we don't immediately tell him what a word says or means. We leave a bit of space for him to figure it out first. We do this to give our child a chance to use his brain and to persevere in the face of difficulty, and we want him to grow in confidence in his own ability and feel pride in himself.

We know that children will get it wrong and make mistakes as they learn to read and we accept and allow that process so that we don't kill their desire and enthusiasm to get it right. We only need to extend this principle to general behaviour.

Having read this far I hope that you are beginning to feel a genuine trust in your child's willingness to get things right as well as an understanding that she is better at the theory than the practice. She will inevitably get it wrong many times as she is growing up, just as she will make mistakes when she is learning to read words.

Re-Phrasing Orders

So, to start with, here's a very simple example of changing an order into a statement of information. 'Listen' or 'Listen to me' is possibly the most frequently used order that parents give to children, and if you're anything like me, it is generally delivered in a way that ranges from fury to desperation.

Children have to obey an awful lot of orders in their lives, and if we want them to be more willing to do that when it's important, it helps to vary orders sometimes with a statement which does not tell them what to do:

'I have something to tell you.'

'I think you'll want to hear this.'

'I have an announcement to make.'

'I would like your attention now.'

'I expect you're wondering what I'm going to say... '

'I bet you can't guess what I'm going to tell you.'

'I think you'll be interested to hear this.'

'I'm about to tell you something.'

If you remember that 'I' draws a child's attention towards you, you can see that in these statements the words themselves make it more likely that your child will listen - and without you ordering her to.

Confronting Unacceptable Behaviour

When our child does something we find unacceptable we would obviously like her to stop doing it, and we would also like her to be willing to stop and never do it again. That's a bit of a big ask, but we can certainly help her to grow out of unacceptable behaviour more quickly by the way we confront it. Shaming a child by using labels and judgements or threatening punishment doesn't help her to think about her behaviour, take responsibility or facilitate her growth. So how do we get her to stop?

Remember that a message of trust is far more likely to make someone want to help you. In [Chapter Three](#) we looked at sharing clear, accurate information with children, with implicit trust that they will get it. But when we want a child to stop doing something, often it's the last thing we think of doing. And yet we don't give a child a fair chance to modify her own behaviour if we withhold the relevant information she needs in order to understand what she should do.

So what would the relevant information be for a child who is doing something you don't like?

The Child's Behaviour

My second son lived in his own world more than the others. He was easily distracted and could be a bit dreamy. I was forever getting impatient with him when his attention wandered and I could see that he wasn't listening to what I was saying. He would get angry and defensive whenever I angrily or irritably said something like 'Look at me when I'm talking to you. It's really rude to look away,' and the exchange would go downhill from there. He might listen to me in the end, but he would do so grudgingly.

So let's start by defining what the actual behaviour is that we would like the child to stop. If we get into the habit of observing actual behaviour rather than jumping ahead into our subjective interpretations and assumptions, as I did with my son, we will be less likely to immediately confront a child using a label such as 'That's really rude', 'Don't be so mean to him' or 'Stop being silly.' So we are immediately setting off on a different path: one that is far less likely to lead to punishment and tears.

Those statements above fail to give the child information about what exactly it is he is doing that you don't like. Remember that children so often dwell in their own little worlds, oblivious to what's happening around them. Their unacceptable behaviour is so often unintentional: they just don't realise what they are doing. Simply pointing it out, without using labels, is often enough information for them to instantly know what to do to put it right:

'You're standing on my foot.'

'You've dropped your coat on the floor.'

'You've left your dirty washing in your room.'

'You've got muddy shoes on.'

'You're right in front of the telly.'

'It's bedtime and you're still playing.'

'You've left your toys all over the floor.'

'You took that without asking.'

'You just barged straight into him.'

'You haven't cleared your plates away.'

'I asked you to put your things away but you're still sitting on the settee.'

If we can manage to make such a simple statement and stop there, we make it much easier for a child to respond with ‘Ooops. Sorry’ and put it right. Because we don’t give him the solution he puts it in for himself. He knows what to do and you have left him space to realise it.

I remember the occasion in the kitchen one day when I first tried simply pointing out my son’s actual behaviour when he had looked away as I was talking to him:

‘I’m telling you something and you’ve just looked away,’ I said, with slight surprise and indignation.

He looked back at me immediately. ‘Ooh. Sorry, Mum. I just thought I saw something,’ he said apologetically, and then willingly listened to what I had to say with great concentration.

Why had I never thought to just point out his actual behaviour before? Why had it never occurred to me to simply trust him? He never did have a motivation to be rude.

Our Feelings About Our Child’s Behaviour

Another area of information we could share with a child when challenging their behaviour is simply how we feel about it. Often the feeling we instantly express to a child is anger, which is not very helpful because when anger is directed towards us we invariably respond with our own anger. We get defensive.

If we can stop for a minute, recognise the initial feeling beneath the anger and express that instead, we might find we don’t need to then turn it into anger at all.

Let’s say, for example, that your child starts screaming at you in the middle of the supermarket, or somewhere in public. Your initial feelings are likely to be a mixture of embarrassment, feeling shown up, humiliated, ashamed, guilty, feeling watched and judged, impatient, afraid of not being able to handle it, nervous about your inadequate parenting skills, exposed, vulnerable, not good enough, overwhelmed, scared of your child’s anger, pressured to do something about it, and on and on. That’s a big emotional overload and we instantly convert it all to anger, which we direct towards the child:

‘Stop that noise. That’s really naughty. You’re not getting any sweets if you carry on.’

We do this to protect ourselves: those real initial feelings make us feel vulnerable, so we jump to anger to reassert our power.

We lose our authority when we do this: we are reacting unconsciously rather than acting consciously. Remember that our most primitive feelings come from the amygdala and that naming a feeling for ourselves helps to calm down the amygdala? If we take a moment to stop and draw a deep breath before responding we are more able to recognise our initial feeling, name it for ourselves and express that instead:

‘I’m really embarrassed. I feel like everyone’s watching us and thinking I’m a bad mother.’

Whenever we express our true feelings to a child we need to make it serious and authoritative, clear and deliberate, no-nonsense – just giving the facts. We have to be careful not to sound pleading, hesitant or apologetic. Otherwise we will come across as a victim. If we are in ownership of our feelings and speak with a confidence in our right to express them our statement carries a lot more authority than an angry outburst at the child. If we wheedle and moan – or exaggerate a sad, disappointed or let down expression on our face we are manipulating our child emotionally, and that doesn’t work. It will invariably make the child angrier.

Here’s another example: you have just spent time and effort organising and taking your children to a park or an attraction they really wanted to visit and they are arguing and complaining about everything. Your real feelings may be a mixture of irritation, feeling used, unappreciated, unvalued, disappointed, taken for granted, fed up, frustrated, confused, unacknowledged, despondent, resentful, regretful, let down, helpless, outraged and indignant. We will take all that and fuse it into an expression of anger (or possibly fury):

‘You lot are just spoilt brats. I’m not bringing you to a place like this again.’

The alternative expression of your true feelings may be something like:

‘I’ve made a lot of effort to bring you here and now I just feel resentful that you are not appreciating it and I regret bringing you.’

Or consider the scenario where you have arranged to meet a friend and sit outside a cafe for coffee, and as you are sitting there chatting your little boy starts to try and climb a dangerously high wall. You would probably feel worried, anxious, nervous, afraid, apprehensive, distracted, tense,

frightened, scared, jumpy, alarmed, concerned, stressed, horrified and unable to relax. Fear often jumps straight to anger:

‘Get down off that wall now. Don’t be so stupid. You’re going to fall and break your neck.’

An expression of our true feeling may be:

‘It’s making me really nervous seeing you climb that wall. I can’t relax and enjoy my coffee.’

A child is more able to hear us if we express our real feelings underneath the anger, as these are human feelings which the child can relate to: embarrassed, scared, nervous, worried, frustrated, confused – all are emotions that a child knows very well so he is far more likely to feel empathy, which he doesn’t when the feeling expressed is anger.

An expression of feeling may be very simple – just a sound communicated by your tone of voice, or a word:

‘Ouch.’

‘Ugh.’

‘Urrrrrgh.’

We do not always know how we are feeling in the moment and that’s OK, too. If we feel unsure about something, that is how we are feeling:

‘I’m not sure about that.’

‘I feel a bit uncomfortable about that.’

‘I’m feeling uncertain. I don’t know...’

‘I’m not sure how I feel about that.’

After my hot tea experience with my third son (which I described at the beginning of this chapter) I prepared myself for the inevitable next time he threw himself on the settee next to me as I was holding a cup of hot tea – and this time I was determined not to label him or tell him what to do. I was ready for it, and when it happened I responded with just an expression of feeling, which in this case was fear:

‘Aaargh. Hot tea.’

He looked immediately shocked, said ‘Ooh... sorry, Mummy,’ and sat next to me absolutely still, trying not to move a muscle. I learned that he cared about me, didn’t want to hurt me, and was quite capable of modifying his own behaviour accordingly. He was three.

The more we give our children the chance to demonstrate their intelligence the more we begin to genuinely trust them and the less angry we feel when they do something we don’t like. So it’s win-win all round.

Our Thoughts and Opinions

Our feelings about a behaviour can also include our opinions, views, thoughts and values:

‘I don’t like that.’

‘I think that’s unfair.’

‘I don’t feel happy about that.’

‘I don’t agree with that. I don’t think it’s right.’

‘I’m not OK with that.’

‘That doesn’t feel right to me.’

‘I don’t think it’s right to keep people waiting, so I’m not prepared to be late for your teacher.’

The Effects of a Child’s Behaviour

Children don’t know as much as we do. We learn as we get older that our behaviour has an impact on the world, but we don’t realise that when we are little. Children are not aware of the effects of their behaviour on others unless we point it out to them. How could they be when they simply haven’t had enough experience of life yet?

I have already mentioned how we try to modify a child’s behaviour by pointing out the unpleasant consequences for him, and how that doesn’t work because the instinctive reaction is to deny it. It is, however, effective to point out the consequences for ourselves, or other people.

A course participant – Emma – is with her little boy Finn, watching a busker performing in town. Finn keeps running up to the man’s hat on the ground and enjoys stirring all the coins around and letting them fall through his hands. Emma can see that the busker is getting nervous about his money and she’s tempted to say ‘Finn, stop that. That’s really naughty.’ Instead she just shares with him her observation of the effects his behaviour is having on the man.

‘Finn’ she says, nodding towards the busker. ‘I think he’s worried you’re going to steal his money.’

‘Ooh,’ says Finn, shocked. He hadn’t noticed that.

‘Sorry,’ he says, and he stops doing it.

It’s the obvious response from any reasonable person; it is probably the response we would give ourselves. We only need to remember that our children are reasonable human beings who are just lacking in experience, and we get a far better reaction from them if we treat them as such.

So be observant of the likely effects on others of your child's behaviour on others and point it out to her:

'I think her mummy is getting worried you're going to hurt her.'

'The shopkeeper looks a bit nervous. I think he's worried you might break that.'

'She doesn't look very happy that you took that without asking her.'

'That lady looks annoyed. I think the noise is too loud for her.'

'I think they're getting irritated because they can't hear what she's saying.'

'She looks like she just needs to get on with cooking dinner.'

'He looks a bit fed up with having to repeat things.'

One important thing you are doing here is pointing out the social cues that people send, so that your child begins to notice the natural social consequences of her behaviour. If you do so quietly and privately as much as possible when you are in public you also help your child to save face, which is always credit in the bank for a parent. We can't underestimate the gratitude of children when we take care to do this – as we would naturally do with adults – because a child so easily feels shamed, and that feeling is so overwhelming and unbearable that they will often cover it with anger so that they don't have to experience it. This is especially true when you confront a child in front of her friends.

The Real Effects on You

Think carefully and honestly about the real effects on you of your child's behaviour because it is our honesty which communicates itself so clearly, and any exaggeration or manipulation with false information will be picked up by your child. This ties into the importance of knowing your own needs, as discussed in the previous chapter: it is more difficult to be honest about the impact of your child's behaviour on you if you are not clear about what your own needs are.

So, for example, if we recognise that telling a child the consequences of her behaviour on her will likely meet resistance, what is the true effect on you when she is rocking backwards and forwards on her chair during dinner, if it is not 'You're going to fall and hurt yourself'?

The effects on us may be something like:

'I can't relax and enjoy my dinner while you're rocking on your chair.'

If a child still responds with ‘Why? I won’t fall,’ we don’t need to get into a discussion about what we think the odds are on that. We need to stick with our needs:

‘Maybe not, but it makes me nervous – and I need to feel relaxed when I’m eating so my food does me good, which it won’t if I’m tense.’

Similarly, when your child refuses to put her hat and scarf on, rather than ‘You’ll catch cold’ we could say ‘If you catch cold I’m the one who’s going to have to look after you and I haven’t got the time to do that.’

If she still argues ‘But I won’t catch cold’ we need not get involved with that argument, but stay with our own boundaries:

‘OK, but I’m not prepared to risk it.’

If we don’t want arguments to develop we need to perfect our air of finality, our this-discussion-is-over voice. As well as expressing self-respect we are treating our child with trust, both in her intelligence and her reasonableness, rather than patronising her with long-winded patient explanations. If a conversation is over we also need to act as if it is and turn our attention to our own business, sending the clear message ‘I trust that you understood and you are willing to help me.’

Let’s look at some more examples of stating clearly the effects of behaviour on us:

When your children are dancing in front of you while you are watching TV: ‘I can’t see the telly.’

When you are on the phone and your child is making a lot of noise: ‘I can’t hear what she’s saying with all that noise.’

When your child leaves her toys all over the floor: ‘I can’t relax in a messy room.’

When your child runs in to the house with muddy shoes on: ‘I’m going to have to clean the carpet.’

When your child pulls at you and demands your attention while you’re talking to a friend: ‘I can’t concentrate on what she’s saying.’

When your children are not taking care of things: ‘If that gets broken I’ll have to pay for it.’

If we want our children to grow up with a sense of how their behaviour impacts on others, they learn far quicker by hearing our honest reactions in real life than by our teaching and lecturing. The most difficult thing in all this is in learning to stop after sending the message, to give your child the chance to say ‘Oops. Sorry’ and change their behaviour by themselves.

When they do this neural connections are made in children's brains, and these are strengthened every time they are allowed the chance to work out the appropriate behaviour by themselves.

Sibling Fights

When two siblings are always fighting and getting at each other it is very easy for parents to slip into habitually treating one child as the victim and the other child as the bully which, as I have already pointed out, is not helpful for either of them.

So let's take a look at this area – and for parents of one child, the principles and skills in this section are equally applicable to friendship spats.

Sibling relationships can have a real impact on family life: children who are constantly in conflict can wear parents down and create a hostile atmosphere in the home, so this issue can be one of the greatest sources of discord in the family. One of the reasons it is best not to label children is that this can create further rivalry and set children against each other in fierce competition. If we are to respond with trust, and consequently be more effective in facilitating a change in their behaviour, we need to know some background information.

Part of the job of siblings is to test each other out and learn about intimate relationships through their interaction with each other, so those conflicts are neither unusual nor a cause for concern in themselves. The challenge for parents is to stay out of them emotionally as much as possible so that we do not add to the strength of feelings and thus the competition between children. Often the reason we get emotionally involved is because of our worry for the child who is getting bullied or bossed around (usually, but by no means always, the younger child.)

We worry that she will become timid and nervous amongst other children at school if she is always picked on at home, but there is no evidence to suggest that children carry over their position in the sibling hierarchy into other areas of life. In fact the younger, more vulnerable child at home is learning to stand up for herself in a relatively safe environment, so she is often more confident at school than more protected children. If you observe a playground full of children it is more likely to be the younger siblings who boss around their peers or take on leadership roles, because

having cut their teeth on the relationship with an older sibling they are unafraid to assert themselves in the peer group.

The idea that oldest siblings become leaders is a myth. There is actually no correlation between birth order and future position and character.

So if we worry too much about the effects of sibling rivalry that colours our reaction to it and makes it more difficult for us to stay out of the emotional drama. We will find ourselves taking sides and adding more emotional weight to the issues if we get too involved, which is likely to escalate the competition between our children.

Much of children's reaction to each other is born out of frustration, not an inherent intentional desire to be nasty. If we bear that in mind and try to respond to the actual behaviour rather than our assumptions about the motivation for it we are likely to be less emotional ourselves and more able to step back.

The other reason that parents are so emotionally invested in their children's relationship with each other is that we really want our kids to be friends and to continue that close connection into their adult lives. The fact is that their innate personalities are probably a higher indicator of whether they will end up being friends, but what we can do is facilitate the growth of their relationship while they are children by allowing them to own it and by not jumping in and making the stakes higher.

Remember that your children's relationship belongs to them, not to you, and ultimately it is their business to sort things out and not yours. The more you jump in and act as judge and jury – and the more responsibility you take – the more they will be unable to work things out for themselves (and the same applies to friendship issues).

The Effects on the Other Child

In our responses we need to allow space for genuine ashamed feelings and regret to be experienced, as it is those feelings which are the real motivation for a child to try not to do it again. Just as over-praising gives no space for intrinsic warm, fuzzy feelings to be experienced, over-criticism and judgement allow no opportunity for natural feelings of regret. We replace feeling ashamed with being shamed.

Pointing out the effects of the behaviour is one way of confronting it without shaming a child or provoking anger in place of that regret. We might bring to his attention the effects of his actions on his sibling:

‘He doesn’t like that.’
‘I think that’s hurting her.’
‘She’s beginning to look a bit upset.’
‘He’s getting annoyed.’
‘I think that’s going to make him cry.’
‘She looks like she’s getting really fed up with that.’
‘He’s starting to look a bit angry.’
‘She’s not happy about that.’
‘I don’t think he likes being poked.’
‘She might get upset if you keep doing that.’

In making the observation about his sibling we are not focusing on the child’s behaviour and reinforcing it – nor are we making judgements about him, which he will inevitably resist angrily. We can express irritation or annoyance in our voice but it’s best to stay clear of anxiety or pity, which may encourage the injured party to play it up for more of our sympathy as a way of winning the battle. The more trouble the aggressor gets into the more reason for the injured party to manipulate us by exaggerating their pain.

The Effects on Us

Another way of simultaneously dealing with a sibling fight while staying out of the drama is to state the effects on ourselves, and to do this effectively we need to be really honest. How does the behaviour interfere with our needs? What is it preventing us from doing? How exactly does it inconvenience us? Usually the answer to these questions will be some version of ‘I can’t get on with what I need to do’:

‘I can’t get on with cooking dinner while you guys are fighting because I keep having to come in and check on you.’

‘I can’t concentrate on this work if I’m getting distracted by you two fighting.’

‘I can’t just relax and eat my dinner while you two are arguing.’

‘If I have to come in and look after him when he’s crying it stops me from getting my jobs done.’

‘I have to comfort her when she’s upset and I don’t have the time - I’m going to be late getting out.’

‘It’s my job to look after him if he gets hurt and that means I can’t talk to my friends.’

‘If I have to keep an eye on you two I can’t just relax and enjoy myself.’

‘I’m getting distracted while I’m driving, and that’s really dangerous.’

Statements like this take the focus and attention away from the children and the particular drama they are engaged in and put it on you and your needs and boundaries. Children have no idea of this information unless we tell them.

Stating the tangible effects on you is another way of expressing self-respect, establishing your boundaries and staying out of their drama. If you reframe children’s fights as disrespectful behaviour towards you and challenge it from that perspective you are far less likely to be dragged in to their battles. Remember that in the language of self-respect the key is not to engage with the content of what your child is saying, but to challenge the way they are saying it. The same principle applies here: becoming engaged with the details of their drama can validate their means of expression (fighting and hurting each other).

A statement of self-respect in the case of sibling fights may be something like:

‘I am not prepared to be drawn in to your battles.’

‘I will not put up with screaming and shouting.’

‘I refuse to play judge and jury in other people’s arguments.’

To sum up, when we confront a child’s behaviour the information she needs in order to know how to behave may be one of – or a mixture of – the following:

- Our honest needs.
- Our boundaries (messages of self-respect).
- The actual behaviour we don’t like (using no labels).
- How we feel about the behaviour (our true initial feeling underneath the anger) or how someone else feels/may feel.
- Our views, beliefs or opinions.
- The honest real effects of the child’s behaviour on ourselves or others.

If we withhold this useful information from our child she is disadvantaged in terms of knowing what is expected of her, but when we share it we find out just how much she can work out for herself. Every time we give a child some relevant information without spelling out what she must do we send a

huge message of trust in her, allowing her to grow in self-discipline and confidence.

And it makes life so much easier for us.

Putting Information Together

We can use any of these areas of information to confront a child's behaviour: sometimes just one will do, but at other times we can mix and match:

'I need quiet. I can't hear what she's saying to me on the phone while you're shouting and making so much noise.'

'It's really irritating when you keep holding on to me. It's stopping me getting on with my jobs.'

'I need to talk to my friends and I can't when you keep grabbing me. I'm not OK with that.'

'It's so frustrating when I can't get on with making dinner because you two are fighting.'

'You've left your things all over the floor. I'm not happy about that, I'm busy working and I haven't got the time to come and remind you.'

'I'm embarrassed when you shout at me in front of people, and I can't get on and do the shopping.'

'I can't just relax and have a nice time with my friend while you are running around, and I'm worried that those people at the next table are getting annoyed.'

'Ouch. You just stepped on my foot.'

'I don't think it's right to keep pestering someone when they've already told you and I can see she's getting irritated.'

'I'm getting stressed about the time this is taking and I'm worried we're going to be late. I don't think it's right to keep people waiting.'

'I can't relax and enjoy my dinner while you keep getting up from the table.'

'I'm worried that she might not want to invite us round again if you don't take care of her things.'

Remember that your tone of voice and facial expression need to be authoritative, clear and unequivocal: you are not either trying to shame your child but nor are you asking permission of her. The more clear and direct we are the easier it is for our children to understand, so it makes things much simpler.

When your child responds with ‘Sorry’ and stops, you’re done. If your child resists and questions you, remember that the scientist may just be collecting data about how serious you are, so whenever possible keep the trust going for the magic three times before you tell them what to do.

Over the years with my own children I have persisted in my trust in their intelligence with statements such as these:

‘I don’t think you need me to tell you what to do.’

‘I think you can work out what to do about it by yourself.’

‘You know what to do. You’ve got a brain.’

Parental Responsibility

While we’re on the subject of useful information which a child doesn’t know unless we tell them, a statement about our job as parent runs less risk of resistance than a statement which judges or criticises the child.

We have legitimate needs as a parent: the need to feel like we are doing a good enough job; the need to feel fairly happy with ourselves as parents. The flip side of parental rights is parental responsibility – it’s a big job looking after children. We carry that responsibility every day, but it can be a mystery to children why we act as we do: they are not able to look at the job of parenting from the outside and understand the reasons for our actions. We could let them in a bit and simply share more about what leads us to make decisions in terms of our job as parents, without either apology or persuasion.

I have been known to say to my children:

‘Actually, it’s my job to make sure you eat healthily. It’s in my job description. Part 3, subsection 2a. I’ll show you one day.’

If you think about the times your child says ‘Why?’ or ‘Why do I have to?’ our reasons are very often down to these needs:

‘Because I wouldn’t be doing my job very well if I let you go into school tired after a late night.’

‘It’s part of my job as your parent to make sure your teeth don’t rot. I’d feel bad about myself if I let you not clean them.’

‘As your parent I’m supposed to bring you up to be healthy, and I wouldn’t be doing my job very well if I let you eat sweets whenever you wanted.’

‘Parents are supposed to keep their children safe. I’m just doing my job.’

‘It’s part of my job as a parent to think about how much TV you watch, and I need to feel I’m doing my job properly.’

‘It’s my responsibility to make sure you’re in school on time and I don’t want to be an irresponsible parent.’

All of those examples are honest, matter-of-fact ‘this conversation is over’ statements which assume the child’s reasonableness and intelligence.

The Teenage Years

Acting from a place of self-respect, stating your own needs and boundaries clearly and turning the spotlight on yourself rather than them becomes even more important as your children grow into the teenage years. Teenagers do like you to have a life. They are also very sensitive to criticism and judgement and, just like toddlers, they will not listen to your lectures because they have a strong drive to work things out by themselves.

It’s a time to allow them as much freedom as possible at the same time as standing up for yourself and making your personal boundaries clear. You have a right to your own house rules, and you have a right to be treated with respect. Teenagers are far more likely to respect you if you let them go and stop lecturing and trying to control their every move, so framing their behaviour in terms of the real effects on you is very helpful.

So: ‘You can’t stay out late because you’ve got school tomorrow and you’re going to fall behind if you’re tired in class.’

This becomes: ‘I can’t sleep until I know you’re back in the house safely and I’ve got work tomorrow, so not on a weekday.’

Or: ‘You’re not having the whole gang round. You can’t be trusted: you’re just going to leave a huge mess for me to clear up.’

This becomes: ‘Not tonight. I’m tired and I can’t deal with a house full of people.’

Or: ‘You need to tidy your room. It’s just a dump. How can you live in there? You need to take some responsibility.’

This becomes: ‘Your room is yours. Keep it how you like as long as you put your dirty laundry straight in the basket and bring out plates and cups and wash them, otherwise I’m running round looking for them.’

And: ‘No. You play computer games far too much: it’s not good for you. You should be doing other things with your time. You’re just wasting your life.’

This becomes: ‘No, I don’t want loud fighty war noises in the living room tonight. I need an evening of calm and quiet so I can get to relax.’

Homework

Homework can be a huge issue in households when kids start secondary school and suddenly get loads of it. I have seen families who argue and fight about it every night and every weekend, which seems like a huge waste of family time. Of course, as parents, we value education and we want our kids to get ahead, but this can mean that we end up taking full responsibility for what is in fact the child’s job. And the more responsibility we take the less they have to.

If we accept that learning is the child’s business, not ours, the whole issue of homework becomes far easier. If we view learning as part of Motivational Drive 3 (as outlined in [Chapter Four](#)), in other words as an area of intrinsic satisfaction, we need to treat it as such. Homework can also be a Motivational Drive 2 area – doing something you don’t like if the reward is great enough – and here again we need to act with the assumption and trust that children are motivated by the reward of good exam results, or the reward of a sense of achievement after sticking at something difficult.

With that trust in place our language and approach become very different.

Incomplete homework or homework handed in late only has a concrete and tangible effect on me if my child’s teacher contacts me about it in the middle of the day while I am working, so I was clear with all my children as soon as they started secondary school:

‘I work, I cook, I pay the rent, I look after you – and that’s my job. Schoolwork and homework are your job. I leave it with you. I don’t care how or when you do your homework – that’s for you to sort out – but I won’t be happy if I get emails or phone calls from school about it. I’m too busy to be dealing with that. And of course I’m here if you need help any time, but it’s your responsibility to ask me.’

I have had a few emails and calls from school over the years, but not many, and when it has happened all I have said to my child is: ‘I don’t have the time to be dealing with your teachers. Sort it. That’s your job, not mine.’ I have helped with homework when asked but that hasn’t been very often. All my children have generally just got on with it and achieved their

expected exam results, even my second son who was really unmotivated and turned off education for most of his school life.

I include that example here not as a definitive how to guide for homework, but as a bit of food for thought for parents who struggle with the homework issue, as it's an approach I have never seen advised anywhere else. Handing homework over to teenagers as their business communicates a huge message of trust and acknowledgement of their maturity and responsibility.

If you want your teenagers to take responsibility you have to allow them to take it, and stop managing their lives. Rather than getting at them from a moral perspective with a list of shoulds and oughts, challenging their behaviour in terms of the real, honest effects on you is a good starting point.

Non-negotiables

Remember that there is a huge range in the tone of voice and facial expression you can use in making all the statements illustrated in this chapter, and that only a small part of the message is communicated by the words. So make sure you speak honestly and seriously and not hesitantly or apologetically. Save your really annoyed and sharp voice for more serious transgressions, and be uncompromising when it's a nonnegotiable.

When you do need to give an order or instruction the words 'No' and 'Stop' are the most simple and unequivocal, and they work better than starting a sentence with 'Don't...' because a child tends to only hear the words that follow, missing that first crucial one.

As in the structure areas, orders and instructions in non-negotiable areas of behaviour within the structure need to be direct, clear and succinct and given in a serious, unequivocal and matter-of-fact tone of voice.

When the behaviour is a complete no-no, labels like naughty or unkind are not clear enough because these words are subjective: there are degrees of naughtiness and unkindness and you need unequivocal statements such as:

'Spitting is not allowed.'

'It is not OK to bite people and it is never OK to bite people.'

'You do not have the right to take his food.'

'You are not allowed to run too far ahead of me.'

'You don't have my permission to take my things without asking.'

'You do not hit me. That is never allowed.'

Your child will be far more willing to listen to statements like these if you give her plenty of chances to modify her own behaviour in other areas where she is just doing the normal range of annoying, irritating and exasperating things that children do every day.

You, I and We-Language

Let's sum up the language we have looked at so far in this book to clarify how we establish the building blocks of trust and shared responsibility. We have previously looked at how to use You-language and I-language to communicate trust, and in the final chapter we'll add We-language:

- You-Language is directed towards the child so it can be very ineffective when it is used to blame, accuse, judge, belittle, warn, lecture, threaten, plead or flatter. You-statements are effective when acknowledging a child as outlined in [Chapter Six](#), and to send clear instructions as shown in [Chapter Eight](#). You-statements can also be very effective in pointing out behaviour and in making the rules clear when the behaviour of the child is non-negotiable, as shown in this chapter.
- I-Language is not so helpful when our child is expressing negative feelings, when we use it to argue, agree, analyse or divert. I-statements are effective in expressing our expectations and trust in a child, as outlined in [Chapter Eight](#), and in stating our own boundaries, needs, values and self-respect, as shown in [Chapter Nine](#). I-statements can also carry great authority when sharing information with a child as a means of confronting unacceptable behaviour, as illustrated in this chapter.
- We-language is the language of teamwork: the language of the group. It communicates societal norms: it is inclusive and builds complicity between members of a group. We-statements are ineffective when they are used dishonestly – when we is used when we really mean I or when we is used when we really mean you:
 - ‘We don't like messy little girls, do we?’ (Actually, I don't).
 - ‘We need to get to bed now, don't we?’ (Actually, you do).

In the final chapter I will be looking at more uses of I-language – and also the use of We-language as a way of building complicity with our children, putting together the principles we have already been exploring throughout this book and getting children on board to be the family you want to be.

If you only take away three things from this chapter, make sure they are these:

1. Children are scientists: good at the theory, not so good at the practice. They are not deliberately being naughty so challenge unacceptable behaviour with trust.
2. Children have no idea of the effects of their behaviour on us or others unless we tell them. Give them clear, honest information. Stop telling them what to do and watch how they learn.
3. When it is absolutely definitely not OK, tell them clearly and order them to stop. Sometimes they need us to tell them, and if you save it till those times they are far more likely to listen.

CHAPTER ELEVEN: CREATING YOUR FAMILY CULTURE

I get home from work and my two youngest children, aged about seven and five, come running up to me. My son, looking furious, says:

‘Mum, tell her to give me some pieces of Geomag. She’s got enough for what she wants to make and I need those pieces for my tower.’

My daughter has that set obstinate expression on her face. ‘He’s got more pieces than me, anyway. Why should I give him some of mine?’

‘Mum, she’s just being really mean,’ shouts my son.

I am tired and I blow up. ‘Look, if you two can’t play together without fighting, go into separate rooms,’ I shout, and head upstairs.

When I come down I find my daughter sitting on the bottom stair, crying, and my son sitting down where they had been playing with a fixed mutinous look on his face.

So that didn’t work, then.

This is not the kind of family I want. I want to get home to happy friendly children who rush up to me and say ‘Mummy, Mummy. Come and see what we’ve been doing. We’re having such a lovely time and we love each other. And we’ve missed you... welcome home.’ I want to be one of those kinds of families.

We are not that bad, though. When my second son was about six I took him round to visit another family, and I remember feeling quite shocked at how the three sons ran the whole show. They fought constantly and really hurt each other; they ignored their parents and they ran wild. They jostled and pushed each other during the meal and each one jumped up and ran off

once he'd finished, without a thank you or even a backward glance at their mother. My son did the same.

On the way home I said to him 'You know how they do things in that family? Well, that's their way. But our way is to say thank you and ask to leave the table, and I don't want you to forget that when you're round at other people's houses just because they do it a different way.'

He nodded, looking a bit ashamed. 'Yeah, OK,' he said. He seemed a bit shell-shocked, too.

I began to understand something about family culture from that experience. I realised that in that house the boys had created a very macho culture, and the parents were hovering in the background allowing them to do so. It just felt wrong and that was when it first hit me that it is the parents' job to create the family culture, not the children's.

I began to define my own values more clearly: I realised that if I wanted my family to reflect my values I had to be more certain and confident in them. So the final chapter of this book is about creating your own family culture and how to get your children on board to take their share of the responsibility in being the kind of family you want to be.

We're going to look at building complicity, which simply means being on the same team. And we'll look at the use of language which assumes this complicity, in place of the us against them kind of language which expresses mistrust. It is the parents' job to define and set the family culture, but you want your kids to be willingly on board.

Let's start by looking at those situations that always go wrong.

Confronting Repeated Dramas

You know how it is when you have a situation where no matter what you do it always ends in tears, or nagging, or shouting and punishing? It may be getting out of the house in the mornings, or mealtimes, or bedtimes, or car journeys. It may be what always happens when you pick up your child from friends' houses, or from the playground, or it may be when your child has friends over to play. It might be the screaming and tears every time you leave the park or the hassle of doing the supermarket shop with your child.

It is those situations where we throw our hands in the air and say 'I've tried everything, and nothing works.' Let's look at those times.

First of all, I'm going to call these situations dramas because these are the times when we all play our part in the creation of this sort of scenario.

We all have our different scripts, and it does begin to feel a bit like a soap opera which is broadcast at the same time every day. When a situation becomes habitual a powerful dynamic is created which seems to be stronger than the players within the drama, and it's important that we acknowledge our role in it. Only the parent has the power to break the dynamic by stepping outside the drama and confronting it from there. A child cannot do this. A child is stuck in the details of the drama, and it is impossible for her to look at the whole picture from the outside: she does not have the experience to do this, but the parent does.

Viewing the Whole Picture

Do you remember what it was like to be a child, when life was a series of disparate, unrelated bits which you couldn't join up, and you didn't understand how things fitted together to make up the whole? Apparently this is the reason that children are so keen on jigsaw puzzles: they get to take all the little bits and fit them together to make up the whole picture. This is so satisfying that a child will break up the puzzle and put it together again many times. It is probably also why children like to do join-the-dots puzzles.

As we grow up we learn to put the pieces together in life: we gain a wider perspective and develop the ability to see not just the details but the whole picture. We begin to see connections and the relationship between things and how they work together. We can stand back. Children don't yet have this ability, but we can help our children to do this too by inviting them to join us outside the drama and view it as a whole. This is a great way of confronting repeated dramas because children are so enthusiastic about understanding the whole picture that they are already onside and willing to join you. You get their attention because you are letting them in on something they really want to know.

Seeing the Dynamic

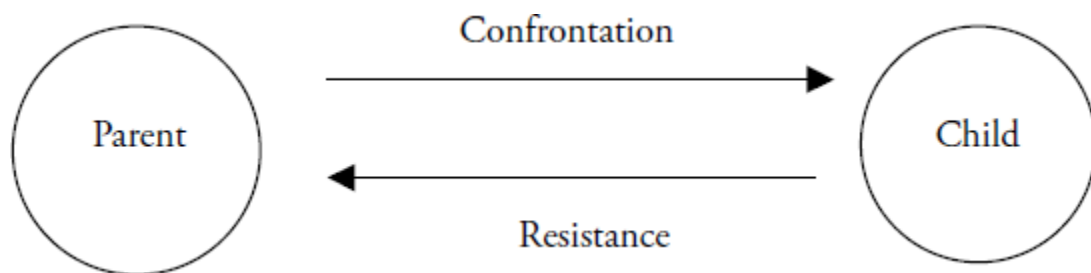
To step outside a drama and view it clearly we need to define that dynamic for what it is. To move from a state of feeling blameless (because we have tried everything) into a perspective from outside the drama we need to get out of the details and understand the overall dynamic. In any situation that always goes wrong our child is behaving in ways that we don't like, and we are trying to change that behaviour so that things work better. We try all

sorts of ways to do this, but our child resists in all sorts of ways and doesn't change the behaviour.

- The parent's methods may take many forms: we may plead, cajole, flatter, explain, persuade, appeal to reason, offer rewards and praise, or we may scold, get angry, criticise, lecture, shout, threaten punishment or actually punish the child.
- The child's responses also take many forms: she may ignore us, run away, sulk, cry, whine, get angry, shout, scream, throw a tantrum, act defiantly, or just deliberately do the very thing we don't want her to do.

Our ways of trying and our child's responses may be very varied but the dynamic created is always the same one of confrontation-resistance.

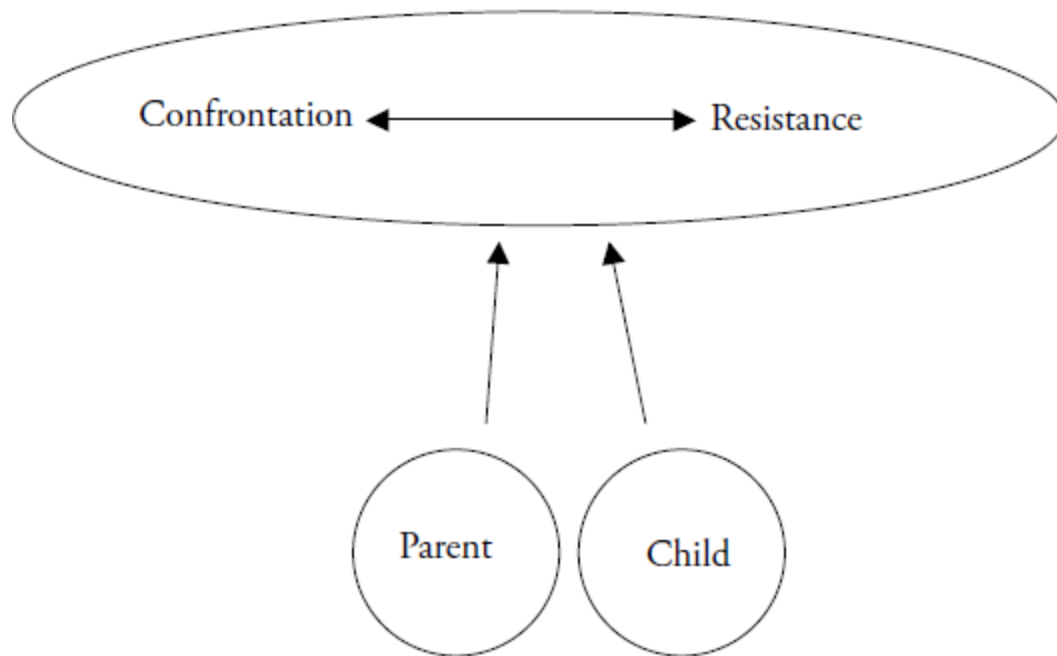
Fig. I. Confrontation-resistance



While we stay within that dynamic we will only do more of the same in different ways, strengthening the overall dynamic further and setting it in stone. Rather than continuing to confront our child, we need to step outside and confront the whole drama together. Let's give the drama a name, step outside, take the child with us and have a look at it.

Fig. II. Stepping outside the drama

Drama: Getting Out of the House in the Morning



In stepping outside we are no longer confronting the child and her behaviour but the drama that we have created together, and that's a lot easier for the child to listen to.

We do this at times, anyway. We get into an argument that is not going well, step back and say something like:

‘Whoa. Let’s rewind and start again. This is not working.’

This is exactly the same principle carried out, not when you are embroiled in the drama, but at a time when you are both outside it anyway and not caught up in the feelings and conflict.

The Language of Confronting a Drama

In order to stay outside the dynamic we need to take ownership of the part we have played in it, using the language of teamwork in a way which builds complicity with the child:

‘I’m not happy about the way we are doing getting out of the house in the mornings.’

This statement introduces the subject of the drama succinctly, owns the fact that this is my opinion (‘I’m not happy... ’) and owns my part in the situation (‘the way we are doing... ’). It’s a statement which assumes that we are on the same team. Rather than lecturing a child on the importance of taking responsibility it’s much more effective to treat a child with the

assumption that he naturally does take responsibility, giving him the opportunity to demonstrate it.

We might add:

‘I don’t think it’s working very well.’

We can sum up the result on both us and the child without pointing the finger at her behaviour:

‘It always ends up with me shouting and you being unhappy. It’s not working for either of us.’

That is all we need to say to outline the situation and set the scene. We don’t want to dwell too much on what we don’t want: we need to move on to what we would like instead.

Painting the Picture

This is where it gets playful and fun. We can let rip with our vision of what mornings could be like and share that with our child. Let him in, confide in him, think aloud, have a conversation. It’s not the time to put on our teacher voice and lecture him about how it should be. It’s the time to be human and trust that he will obviously want the same thing as us. Words are very powerful when we paint pictures with them, remember. So replace the negative scenario with a lovely picture:

‘I would love it if we are all happy in the mornings, and we all get on with what we need to do to get ready, and we have a lovely relaxed breakfast and enjoy preparing for the day ahead... and then we all end up leaving the house in plenty of time so we can have a fun journey to school instead of rushing, and we all feel good and full of energy to start the day.’

Our enthusiasm is infectious and our child is drawn into this vision we are creating: we are giving her a picture which she was previously incapable of imagining herself. The use of the word We is important here: in using it we are acting with the assumption that we are a team. We might say ‘You’ll get yourself ready’ as long as we balance that with ‘And I’ll get myself ready.’ Keep it general, rather than focusing on specific demands of the child, such as ‘You need to listen to me and do as you’re told’ which puts the blame and the responsibility all on her shoulders.

What we are doing is creating a shared goal. Rather than trying to enforce responsibility on our child we are communicating in a way that facilitates her natural willing responsibility.

We could then invite our child to participate in the rule-setting but in my experience children much prefer that you just tell them, which does have the advantage of being quicker, easier and clearer for everyone. The daily routines are part of the secure structure you are creating, and as it's in the area of Parental Authority it is the parent's responsibility to make the decisions.

Don't forget that every way we communicate sends an underlying message and if we spend time working out how to make it happen with our children, the subtext is 'This is a big problem which needs all of us to spend a lot of time working out. I don't trust that, having agreed what we all want, you guys are capable of just doing it. I need it all worked out down to the last detail before I can trust that you get it.' It's an awfully big fuss to make about what is, after all, just normal expected behaviour.

Whereas if we employ the Julian principle we could just say:

'Great. OK – we'll do it like that from now on, starting tomorrow.'

That statement assumes that it's a done deal and communicates absolute trust.

Shared Ownership

This way of dealing with behaviour issues doesn't lecture children on the importance of taking responsibility and being a team. It acts it out. Having taken shared ownership of the situation we have to keep it up, which means not blowing up, nagging, pleading, or going back into our own old patterns of relating when we're back in the drama scenario again.

Of course, we all know that children won't instantly become perfect. They will forget, make mistakes and get it wrong, but we have facilitated a willingness and a motivation to get it right, so we're halfway there already. All we need do when our child does forget is to remind her matter-of-factly:

'We're doing it our new way now. Remember?'

'Hey, we're not doing it that way any more.'

'Remember, we're trying a new way now because that way didn't work.'

'We said we'd do it differently now. Let's all try to remember.'

I'm assuming that, by this point in the book, I don't need to tell you that for these statements you need your serious, matter-of-fact, goes-without-saying, I-know-you-already-get-this-but... tone of voice and not your

whining, pleading, nice, disappointed, lecturing or furious voice (just checking).

It's important that we continue our language of shared ownership and teamwork when we confront our child so that we don't slip back into the previous dynamic, and also that we practice the language and approach outlined in [Chapter Eight](#) (which is less likely to create the dynamic in the first place).

That means that if we descend into shouting and screaming we have to allow our child to remind us, too, and respond to them in the way we'd like them to respond to us:

'Daddy, we said we were doing it a new way now.'

'Oops. Sorry, I forgot. OK... rewind. Start again. Coat on now. Thank you.'

We have to model the behaviour we want and let mirror neurons do the rest. When we as parents act like we're a team our kids tend to act like it, too.

When my children were little we used to have terrible car journeys whenever we drove the six hours it took to visit Grandma: by the time we arrived we were all angry and barely speaking to each other. Here is the vision I painted to my children when the next journey was looming and I was feeling the familiar feeling of dread:

'I would like us all to set off to Grandma's like it's a big adventure. We're On the Road, and it's really exciting. We get to do fun things that we don't usually do, like play number plate games and sing along to music tapes and listen to stories and stop off at motorway service stations to buy magazines and crisps... and we all have a lovely, happy, exciting journey so that we arrive at Grandma's happy, and we all still like each other.'

I could see my children taking in this image of our happy family on the road and they were all naturally enthusiastic about making it happen without me once referring to their actual behaviour, lecturing them or telling them what to do. It made a huge difference to family trips from then on – and if any arguing did start, all it took to calm things down was for me to say 'Hey, we're doing it the Exciting Adventure way now, remember.'

My favourite car journey story, though, came from a course participant – Christine – who had talked about how difficult the school run was every morning with her two children fighting over who would sit in the front every day. After the course she reported this:

‘Yesterday morning, after the usual fighting debacle as to who goes in the front, I talked to my kids about how the car journey just wasn’t working for any of us and how nice it would be if we could do it differently. That’s honestly all I said, and then I forgot about it.

This morning they got into the car without any fuss and my son said ‘It’s OK, Mum – Gertie goes in the front Monday, Wednesday and Friday and I go in the front Tuesday, Thursday and Saturday.’ My mouth hit the floor and then I just smiled.’

I love that story because it illustrates just how easy things can be when we are simply honest, give information to our children and trust them to know what to do without spelling it out for them.

The way we communicate with our children either facilitates their natural reasonableness and intelligence or stifles it, and what makes the difference is the underlying message of trust.

Staying Out of the Drama

Huge emotional dramas can happen any time with children. It’s that primitive brain again, exploding out of nowhere, with no executive control. If kids can hook in the adults, get them engaged in all the emotions and details of the drama, then it’s likely to run and run, like a re-commissioned bad soap. This will worry us far more than it worries them so it’s important that we stay outside and refuse to join in with a drama. (Unless it looks like one that we might enjoy.)

If we do get hooked in and it all ends in tears, we really don’t need to talk it through later and get to the bottom of things. The more interested we are in dramas the more our children are obliged to create them.

Taking a child with you outside the drama can be very simple:

‘You know what happened earlier? Let’s not do that again. It wasn’t much fun.’

If you can collapse into giggles about it together, all the better. Learning to laugh about yourselves together is a great way to build complicity.

The Language of Inclusion

Having read this far in this book I can imagine you may be thinking ‘Yes, but there are times when I just have to punish my child. What about when their behaviour is really awful/dangerous/completely out of order?’

I hope I have made it clear throughout this book that I have been outlining the communication skills which will make it less likely that you will reach the point of punishment, not make you (heaven forbid) into a perfect, always-saintly parent. I have also explained the difference between punishment and real natural consequences, so let's take another look at that here because maybe it's just a question of semantics.

When my first son was little he used to blow up and lash out at other children. It was very stressful having other children round to play as I never knew when it was going to happen (although it inevitably would, every time) and I had no idea how to manage it. I sought professional help and was told to punish him with a time out whenever he did it, and insist that he apologised. I tried that several times and it made things much worse. It just made him even angrier and set up a kind of fighting relationship between us.

In a classic brushing-aside of my two middle children (sorry, guys), fast forward to my daughter. Her tantrums and screaming fits were another huge challenge for me. By that stage I was beginning to understand that children express frustration in many different ways – and that I just happened to have had two children who expressed it in the more extreme ways – but I still had no idea how to handle it.

It was during one dinner time – when the whole family was sitting round the table and my daughter (who was then about three years old) had started screaming and screaming because something wasn't quite right for her – that I looked around at the ashen faces of my boys and it hit me that I had a real responsibility to stop this kind of behaviour. Not to teach my daughter a lesson but to look after the needs of the whole family. Nobody could eat their dinners while the screaming was going on. Everyone was miserable. I also knew by that stage that if punishment had made things worse with my first son, we would be in for Armageddon if I tried it with my daughter.

So I said in a loud, clear voice:

'Here's your choice: stay at the table and be quiet so everyone can eat, or carry on screaming, but do it in the living room.'

She carried on screaming so I tried one more time:

'OK. You can scream, but you have to do it in the living room. If you want to stay here you have to quieten down because it's making everyone unhappy. We all really want you to stay.'

She carried on screaming, so I said ‘OK. In the living room, then.’

I had to pick her up, screaming and struggling, and put her there – and then I had to close the door because she tried to get back in.

As I was doing so, I continued talking in a loud, clear voice:

‘We really want you to be with us but we can’t eat our dinner while you’re screaming. So I can’t allow you to stay, because my job is to look after everyone. We all want you to eat with us, though, so as soon as you can stop screaming please come back in and join us. I have to close the door because we can still hear you and I can’t allow you to come back in until you’ve stopped screaming.’

By the time she had quietened down we had all finished our dinner, but when she knocked on the door to be allowed back in we all welcomed her back.

Over the next couple of weeks she made two more half-hearted attempts to start screaming at the table but stopped quickly, and after that she never did it again. I had, in effect, carried out exactly the same action as a punishment, but the crucial difference was that I used the language of inclusion rather than the language of exclusion. My intention was completely different.

Membership of the Group

In the example above, the last thing I wanted to do was shame my daughter: I knew that I would have a real fight on my hands if I did that. I had also observed at school that excluded children can feel rejected by the group and then begin to view it as a group they don’t want to belong to anyway.

The typical language used in punishment goes something like this:

‘That’s very naughty. If you can’t behave, you’re getting a time out. You’ll stay outside until you can behave properly and I want you think about what you’ve done and then come back in and apologise.’

That is the language of exclusion, which focuses on the behaviour of the child.

Remember that children are born with a drive to be an accepted member of the group? Sometimes it’s inevitable that we have to remove a child from the group (if their behaviour is dangerous or interferes in some way with the needs of the other members) but if we communicate with trust in their desire to be accepted within the group we are working with their developing brains and not against them.

We have to be uncompromising and direct, yes. But we also need to be human if we are to get the best out of our children.

The Parents' Job

When the behaviour is extreme we have to step up into our parental authority and make the rules clear, but if we approach this kind of behaviour from the point of view of our responsibilities towards the whole group and communicate that to our child we are taking the focus off her actual behaviour and shining the spotlight on the family instead.

Even as we are being firm and uncompromising in removing a child from the group we can communicate very differently as we are doing so, in a way which facilitates her innate desire to follow the rules.

We can do this by giving her the relevant information about the family group and our job as parents:

‘My job is to look after all the children, so I can’t allow anyone to hurt anyone else.’

‘I wouldn’t be doing my job properly if I allowed any of my children to hurt another one. I would do the same if it was you being hurt.’

‘I want us all to have a nice time, but if one person makes that impossible I have to do something about it. That’s my job. And, actually, there’s nothing else I can do. I don’t have any other option.’

This is simply clear honest information about our job responsibility. Add to that the language of inclusion and we are communicating both Parental Authority and trust:

‘We all really want you to be here with us, so please come back in as soon as you calm down.’

‘We all like it better if you’re here but I can’t allow you to stay while you’re upsetting everyone.’

Using language like this also helps a parent to feel genuinely less angry with the child and more in control and matter-of-fact – not in a cold way, just with less heavy emotion adding to the mix.

Building Complicity

If we trust that our children naturally want to fit into the family group and obey its rules we can reflect that in our language. We can reinforce a sense of family pride very simply when things are going well:

‘We have such fun in our family don’t we?’

‘I love our family, we really look out for each other.’

That word ‘we’ is very useful for building complicity. Making cheerful proud statements about our family is a very simple and easy to remember way of creating a shared sense of positive identity which your children will want to live up to.

Rather than lecturing children about their behaviour we can get them on board more willingly with statements about the family:

‘I want us to be the kind of family that welcomes people round.’

‘I’d like people to enjoy visiting our family.’

‘We don’t hurt people in our family, we take care of each other.’

‘We don’t do it like that in our family, we work things out.’

Clear confident statements about your family are very powerful for both you and your child. Your child of course believes you because you are the adult and you know things.

Politeness and Manners

We have been looking at ways of challenging a child’s behaviour from the context of the family group, and in this way we have been building complicity with our child – and the sense of belonging to the same team. It really helps the group to function well, though, if our children are polite and well-mannered – which is actually just another way of saying respectful.

I have talked about the importance of expressing self-respect and stating our own needs and boundaries clearly, all of which is fantastic modelling. But what about those times when our child doesn’t say ‘Thank you’ or ‘Please’ or ‘Sorry.’ How do we make politeness and good manners happen?

This is another area where we should stop telling children what to do. Really, they should be absorbing by osmosis the social rules regarding manners, just by being with us. But they don’t, do they? They forget, they are distracted, they are in their own little worlds and they don’t always get it right. But maybe it’s also because we make it more difficult for them by always giving the instruction, or by being angry and disapproving as if they are being deliberately rude.

When we give the order ‘Say thank you’ every time our children forget, we create a set pattern over time whereby it is almost impossible for the child to say thank you until they hear the instruction, and it’s the same with please or sorry.

Although we want this to become automatic behaviour it's not the same as 'Coat on now' which is a simple instruction to perform a physical act in the physical world. Politeness involves more nuanced understanding, and the connection of a feeling (gratitude, regret) to a particular word. As parents we want our children to say these words automatically, but we also want them to mean it.

Children want to understand and follow the rules of their society, so a more effective way of facilitating this willingness is to give them some information about the effects on you or other people when they forget – and some simple information about the social rules, as we did in [Chapter Three](#) on the issue of sharing toys:

'I think Grandma feels unappreciated when you don't say thank you.'

'When I give you something I want some thanks, otherwise I feel like I'm a slave.'

'When people thank us we feel much more like giving them something again.'

'She likes to be thanked when she gives you something. Then she knows you're pleased.'

'We say please so it doesn't sound like we're giving orders.'

'People just like you better if you say please. Otherwise they think you're rude.'

'I feel more like giving you something if you say please when you ask.'

Remember that all of this is just simple information, and if it is delivered in that way a child is far more likely to listen. We can, of course, also put in the thank you for ourselves, preferably a gushing over-the-top expression of thanks to demonstrate what we'd like to hear. My second son and I were once arranging something by text message, and at the lack of any thank you I texted him this:

'Thank you, thank you, thank you!!! I SO appreciate your help, Mum. Thank you a million times. I love you so much!!'

He sent me the message back followed by a row of smiley faces and a few rows of kisses.

Making Reparation

We especially want children to mean it when they say sorry, as we know that a grudging or insincere sorry is worse than nothing at all. We can order

a child to say sorry, but we can't order a child to mean it. So how do we facilitate genuine regret?

The first thing to remember is that when a child gets it wrong there is often an instant reaction of shock, regret and shame, whether that is because she has just hit her brother or spilled the water from the paint jar all over the table. If we catch that moment we can respond to the regret:

‘You didn’t mean to do that... ?’

‘Oops...’

We stand more chance of getting a genuine sorry that way. Sometimes, though, your child will still be defensive and make excuses to justify their action (it has to be said, though, that if you don’t generally punish and shame your child for getting it wrong she has less reason to do this). But still, she may respond:

‘Well, he was taking my toys without asking.’

‘It wasn’t my fault. I didn’t know it was there.’

In reaction, we may be tempted to use the combination of lecturing and labels that make things worse:

‘Yes, but you shouldn’t have hit him. That was really mean.’

‘Well, you should be looking. That was really careless.’

If we want to escalate a fight, that’s fine. But if we don’t, it’s better to state the effects of the behaviour and give some information:

‘Yes, but that really hurt him. I know you didn’t mean to, but when we hurt people we can always make up for it. An apology usually makes someone feel better.’

‘I’m going to have to clear up the mess, though. I’d feel better about that if I felt that you were sorry about it.’

Each of my children at some point during their primary school years was rude to a teacher, and I was quite shocked to hear the report from school when my second (angelic) son had shouted at the kindergarten teacher during playtime and refused to do what she’d told him. I talked to him about it at home. He was still angry and outraged at what he saw as the injustice of the situation, and I listened to him and acknowledged his side of the story until he calmed down. Then I gave him some information about the rules (which by that stage in my parenting journey I was very clear about), and the effects of his behaviour:

‘Well, you know, it’s never OK for a child to shout at a teacher. That’s just not on. You know she loves you. She thinks you’re a great kid, and I

can imagine she probably felt quite shocked and hurt about it.'

He looked ashamed.

'Don't worry, though,' I said cheerily. 'We all make mistakes, but when we do we can always make up for them.'

'What shall I do?' he asked.

'Well, you know... if someone upsets me I usually find that an apology works instantly. It's like magic. I forgive people immediately when they apologise. If I were you I'd do it as soon as you get to school tomorrow, then it'll make you feel better for the rest of the day.'

He asked if I would go with him, so that's what we did the next day – and of course he got a big hug from the teacher and all was forgiven. I could see how moved he was and how relieved he felt, because it was quite a scary thing for him to do.

It was this experience that clarified for me the overall message I wanted to give to my kids whenever they got something wrong:

'You made a mistake. We all make mistakes, but we can always make up for them and put them right. We can always make reparation.'

That's a huge message of matter-of-fact trust, and if you stick with that principle in your communication with your children you won't go far wrong, no matter what actual words you use.

Self-Disclosure

We don't become stereotypical generic mothers or fathers as soon as we start having children, do we? We're all different. We're all unique people: we can't fit ourselves into a mould. Everyone has to live by their own beliefs and values. We can't adopt someone else's persona and play the good mother or good father role according to someone else's ideology. And the great thing is that our kids would prefer us to be who we really are. So it's easy, really.

If we want an authentic relationship with our children we need to be authentic. Our children need to know who we really are as people, and not just acting out a parent role. Sharing our real selves, our likes, dislikes, beliefs and experiences with our child not only brings us closer but it also helps children learn things far more effectively than continually teaching and lecturing them.

I remember when my kids were little I went away on a weekend training course and right at the beginning the leader of the group made a statement

based on an assumption that all of us in the group would share that view. I could see clearly that all the other participants did agree, but I didn't. So I had a real dilemma. Should I speak up and risk offending other people? Would everyone else hate me? On the other hand, how could I spend a whole weekend with people I'd only just met and keep up the pretence? I spoke up and said 'I'm not sure I agree with that. There is so much to take into account on that issue. I really don't feel I understand enough to be able to make a definitive judgement.' And it was fine. Nobody hated me, and I felt that I had been congruent without judging other people.

And that's exactly how I relayed the story to my (very young) children who were, of course, fascinated, asked questions and decided that I had done the right thing. My intention in sharing that with them was not to teach them anything, but just to tell them about my weekend. However, I am convinced that this is the way that children really learn, far more than being lectured. Kids are so honoured to be let in to the adult world and so thrilled when you talk about real stuff with them. Of course, you wouldn't go into marital or financial difficulties with children – it has to be appropriate – but there is so much that we can share with them just through our normal lives and experiences.

We often wait until they are having problems and then give advice:

'He's being really mean to me. He's not my friend any more.'

'Well, I'm sure he didn't mean it. He was probably just having a bad day.'

'No. He hates me.'

Given that we adults also experience friendship difficulties and misunderstandings there is so much we can share with our children which facilitates their own wisdom, rather than waiting to teach them the correct way to feel when they are having problems. Here's something I told my third son on the way home from school when he was about seven:

'I bumped into my friend in town today and she was a bit off. She didn't seem to want to talk to me. It was sort of bothering me all morning. I wondered if I'd done something to upset her. But then I thought no... It was probably nothing to do with me.'

He listened with real interest and empathy, and then said thoughtfully:

'Yeah, Mum. She was probably just having a bad day.'

Hearing about a difficulty you have experienced – and how you dealt with it – is very interesting for a child. It facilitates their learning and innate

wisdom and brings you closer. All-round result.

What Did You Do at School Today?

This is the classic question we ask our child when we pick her up at the school gates at the end of the day. She, inevitably, replies ‘Nothing.’ The reason why we fire questions at our children is that we really want to know about their experiences, share in their lives and feel connected to them, but to the child it can feel like an inquisition.

If we want our family to be the kind that shares stuff with each other we need to model that. We, as parents, set the normal in terms of communication in our family, and the level at which we communicate with our children will be the level at which they communicate with us. Here’s an alternative scenario at the school gates:

‘You’ll never guess who I bumped in to today on my way to pick you up.’

‘You’ll never guess what I did at playtime today.’

That doesn’t mean we never ask our children such questions, of course, just that we need to remember that sharing is a two-way thing.

Mealtimes are an area of family life that can be a source of constant stress, and yet this is a time when families get the chance to chat and reconnect after a day apart. Rather than focus on children’s behaviour at the table or quiz them about school we can really take this opportunity to share things from our day, or our thoughts or observations about things that interest us, and model how we would like family mealtimes to be.

If we want children to imitate us, as they so naturally do, we have to give them something worth imitating. If we focus always on children’s behaviour we send a very clear message that this is the most interesting subject for us.

Lessons Learned

This seems like as good a time as any to sum up the biggest lesson I learned throughout my parenting journey: that whereas most of the advice we hear from either parenting camp is very child-directed, we do better to take exclusive focus off the child and balance it with attention to ourselves and the family group as a whole.

In our present culture our worth as parents seems to be measured in terms of how much we are prepared to give to our child, but I learned to ask

myself this question as a matter of habit:

‘When I give something to my child, what am I taking away?’

And my answers, over the years, have been:

‘If I give too much praise and reward, I take away intrinsic motivation.’

‘If I give too many presents or material possessions, I take away gratitude.’

‘If I give too much help, I take away responsibility.’

‘If I give too much reassurance and sympathy I take away inner strength.’

‘If I give too much judgement I take away the child’s ability to judge for himself.’

‘If I give too much attention I take away the child’s ability to look outside herself.’

‘If I give too much direction I take away the child’s ability to figure things out for himself.’

‘If I give too many answers I take away the child’s ability to think for herself.’

And, in the end, if I give too much to my child I lose myself. Ultimately that’s not good for me, the child, or our relationship.

Of course we have to give lots of time and attention to our children when they are little, and also giving is lovely and it’s part of our relationship with our children. But the pressure to continually give, give, give can only lead to guilt and stress for parents.

It’s worth remembering that we live at a point in history and culture where we are almost unique in having the time and resources to give this much to our children, and that our species has managed to survive up to this point even with parents who were far too distracted by matters of survival to pay much attention to the kids beyond keeping them alive.

And in the end healthy relationships are not built on one-way giving, even the relationship between parent and child.

Creating Your Family Culture

So what sort of family do you want to be? If respect, trust, honesty, intimacy and fun are important to you in relationships within the family, those are broad abstract principles which we have the power to bring down into our day-to-day reality with a little awareness and confidence in ourselves.

But it doesn't do any harm to spell it out to our children sometimes, and paint the picture of how we want it to be.

That day when my two youngest had been fighting and I had blown up I sat down on the floor with them, feeling a bit helpless about the situation of stalemate. Rather than talk about their behaviour, I began to talk about me.

'You know what,' I said. 'I want to get home to happy friendly children who rush up to me and say 'Mummy, Mummy. Come and see what we've been doing. We're having such a lovely time and we love each other. And we've missed you. Welcome home.' I want to be in one of those kinds of families.'

(You might recognise those words from the start of this chapter).

I continued 'I would love it if my children were always friendly and happy playing together. I don't want to be one of those shouty, angry families. I want us to be one of those families where everyone gets along well with each other... I mean not perfect, obviously, but just where we try to help each other and care about each other, and we generally have fun... '

I noticed that my son's facial expression had softened and my daughter had stopped crying. I continued thinking aloud:

'I think a family should be a safe place that we all get back to at the end of the day. You know... like we all go out into the world and people might be mean to us, or we might get bullied, but when we get home we feel safe from all that sort of stuff, so we can relax and recharge our batteries and set off into the world again feeling more confident. Like our home is our safe haven from the world outside... '

Out of the corner of my eye I noticed that my daughter was surreptitiously pushing pieces of Geomag across the carpet towards my son, who was beaming at her. So I stood up, walked off and left them playing happily together, having made no reference to their behaviour or what they should be doing at all.

We will never be the perfect family (they don't exist), and in any family things sometimes go horribly wrong. There are blow-ups and stand-offs, and anger and tears. That's just life. But those things happen on more of a surface level if you have a basic foundation of respect and trust in place: they are not so damaging and you get over them quickly with a little self-deprecation, humour and a willingness to forgive yourself your own imperfections (and your children theirs).

That day, sitting on the carpet with my two youngest, for the first time I really clarified and voiced for myself what kind of family I wanted – and I wondered why I had never thought to do that before, or share it with my children. The brilliant thing was that with all the understanding I had built up over the years I had the confidence by that stage to know that I could make it happen. Not perfectly, not all the time, but enough of the time. I hope this book helps you to do the same.

If you only take away three things from this chapter, make sure they are these:

1. Step outside dramas and take your child with you. Don't join in with any dramas you don't think you're going to enjoy.
2. Take your exclusive attention away from the behaviour of your child and put it more on yourself and what you want: you may find that your child's behaviour just falls into place.
3. You really do have the power to create the family you want. Don't give it away to your kids – but let them come on board, build complicity, invite them in.

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